IT Business Development Executive Handbook

A practical curriculum for technology services sales

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For new BDEs, sales managers, and technology agency founders.

A good IT BDE helps a buyer reach a commercially viable decision. That requires understanding the problem, testing its business impact, discussing possible solutions, bringing in the right specialist, and making commitments the delivery team can keep.

This handbook teaches that job from first principles. It combines a 90-day training course with a field reference for prospecting, discovery, technical handoffs, proposals, negotiation, and account growth. The goal is technology fluency and sound commercial judgment. Coding is not a prerequisite.

How to use this book

Trainees should follow Chapter 22 in order. Read the assigned chapters, produce the required work, and pass the stage assessment before moving forward. Managers should review one work sample and one conversation each week. Chapters 3, 5, 7, and 24 are reference catalogs. Learn the agency's two main offers first, then expand your range.

Must know means you must explain the idea in plain English, apply it in a conversation, and record it correctly. **Awareness** means you must recognize it and know which expert to involve. **Specialist decision** means you must not commit without technical, financial, or legal approval.

All companies, deals, prices, targets, and project results in training examples are fictional or illustrative unless a source is explicitly cited. They are not claims about Easenext's capabilities, customers, performance, or rate card. Before using this internally, management must populate the capability register in Chapter 2 with actual evidence.

Manager setup before day one

Assign a sales mentor and a technical mentor. Provide approved service descriptions, delivery capacity, three permission-cleared case studies, the pricing approval process, CRM access, contract templates, target markets, and outreach rules. Give trainees access to sanitized project artifacts and consented call recordings. Do not use confidential customer data as practice material.

Allow roughly 60 to 90 minutes of structured learning per working day in the first month, plus supervised practice. The 90 days are calendar-day stages, not 90 consecutive working days. Assignments fall on scheduled working days. Passing this course authorizes only the responsibilities specified in the assessment. It does not make someone an architect or an enterprise closer.

Evidence and current relevance

Stable fundamentals include qualification, acceptance criteria, cost control, data ownership, and honest follow-through. Product features, prices, model rankings, regulation, and market demand need periodic review. Numbered sources in the text connect to the research register at the end. Interpret survey results within their populations. Developer preference is not customer demand; interest in AI is not an approved budget.

The 2026 McKinsey AI survey reports wider deployment alongside uneven financial results and operating-cost constraints. DORA's 2025 research emphasizes the importance of the surrounding delivery system. These findings support teaching workflow economics and delivery controls alongside AI opportunities. They do not justify promising an automatic productivity gain. [1][2]

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1 The IT BDE role

1.1 The job in plain English

An IT Business Development Executive finds organizations with problems the agency can solve, earns a useful conversation, determines whether a commercial opportunity exists, and helps the buyer and delivery team agree on the next step. In small agencies, the BDE may own prospecting through closure. In larger firms, those responsibilities are divided. Clarify your job boundary before accepting a quota.

A request for an app is not yet an opportunity. An opportunity needs a plausible business problem, an identifiable owner, commercial potential, and a credible path to a decision. A meeting with someone who is only collecting prices is a conversation until those conditions improve.

1.2 Roles and boundaries

Role	Main responsibility	Typical handoff or success measure
BDE	Develop new business, sometimes across the entire sales cycle	Qualified pipeline and profitable wins within assigned scope
SDR	Qualify leads and create meetings, often including inbound	Meetings that the receiving seller accepts
BDR	Develop new accounts, often outbound	New qualified opportunities; titles vary by company
Account Executive	Run an opportunity through discovery, proposal, and close	Bookings, win rate, forecast accuracy
Sales Manager	Coach people and run the sales system	Team attainment, quality, forecast, and margin
Account Manager	Maintain relationships after sale and develop accounts	Retention, customer health, and expansion
Solution Consultant	Translate business needs into suitable solution options	Validated fit and a clear business case
Pre sales	A function supporting technical and commercial evaluation	Discovery, demos, estimates, and proposal inputs
Technical Sales	Sales work requiring substantial technical fluency	Credible technical conversations and commercial progress
Sales Engineer	Validate feasibility, integrations, demos, and proofs	Technical approval and documented limitations

SDR and BDR are not universal definitions. Pre-sales is not always a job title. A sales engineer may also be called a solution consultant. Ask who owns each deliverable, not just what the title means.

1.3 A normal working day

Review commitments first. Resolve overdue follow-ups, customer questions, and blocked approvals. Research a small number of suitable accounts. Contact relevant people with a reason tied to their business. Prepare and run calls. Debrief with technical colleagues. Update evidence, risks, and next actions in CRM. Learn from one call or project each day.

A BDE does not independently design production architecture, certify compliance, guarantee a release date, change contractual liability, invent references, or promise engineers who have not been reserved. The right answer to an unknown is: “I need our technical lead to validate that. I will return with the answer and its assumptions by Thursday.” Then do it.

1.4 Career progression

Stage	Skills to demonstrate before promotion
Fresher	Accurate research, plain-language technology explanations, reliable notes, ethical outreach
BDE	Focused prospecting, first discovery, qualification, disciplined follow-up
Senior BDE	Independent standard opportunities, stakeholder mapping, proposal coordination, basic economics
Business Development Manager	Segment strategy, partnerships, negotiation, coaching, repeatable pipeline
Sales Manager or Account Director	Team execution or strategic account growth, forecasting, retention, margin discipline
Head of Sales or VP Sales	Positioning, resource allocation, hiring, pricing governance, predictable commercial performance

Promotion should reflect repeatable capability, not just tenure or one lucky deal. Enterprise selling is a separate specialization involving procurement, security, legal, and many stakeholders.

1.5 Metrics that expose reality

Metric	Definition	What it helps diagnose
Useful activity	Researched accounts and relevant, permitted contacts	Effort quality, not raw message volume
Held meetings	Meetings actually attended by a relevant buyer	Separates booked meetings from real access
Qualified opportunity rate	Accepted opportunities divided by held discovery meetings	Targeting and discovery quality
Proposal rate	Proposals divided by qualified opportunities	Progress, but high rates can hide premature proposals

Metric	Definition	What it helps diagnose
Pipeline value	Value of open qualified opportunities using one consistent period	Potential business, not guaranteed revenue
Win rate	Wins divided by wins plus losses for a defined cohort	Competitive and qualification effectiveness
Sales cycle	Days from agreed opportunity creation to decision	Buying friction and forecast timing
Bookings	Value of signed commitments under the company's definition	Commercial commitments, distinct from revenue
Revenue	Amount recognized under the finance policy	Delivery-related financial result
Gross margin	Revenue less direct delivery cost, divided by revenue	Deal quality before overhead and taxes
Retention and expansion	Renewed and added business within existing accounts	Delivery fit and account development
Stage aging	Days in the current stage without buyer-confirmed progress	Stalled or inflated pipeline

Do not attribute retention entirely to a junior BDE. Sales, account management, and delivery share responsibility. Define credit rules before using these metrics for compensation.

Worked funnel. In one illustrative cohort, 100 suitable accounts produce 12 positive replies, 8 held meetings, 4 qualified opportunities, 3 proposals, and 1 win. Meeting-to-opportunity conversion is 50%. This is an exercise, not an industry benchmark. A seller with 500 emails and no accepted opportunities may perform worse than one with 40 contacts and two good opportunities.

Exercise. Classify ten CRM records as lead, meeting, opportunity, proposal, or signed deal. Pass when at least eight classifications are correct and every opportunity has evidence, an owner, and a next step.

2 Foundation before lead generation

2.1 Why tools do not fix an unclear offer

Apollo can find contact records. Clay can combine data and workflows. An email sequencer can schedule messages. None can decide whether the agency has relevant proof, whether a buyer has a problem, or whether delivery can fulfill the promise. Starting with volume creates weak targeting, generic claims, irrelevant meetings, and preventable reputation damage.

The prerequisite is a useful answer to four questions: Who can we help? With which expensive or urgent problem? Why should this buyer trust us? What can we deliver profitably now?

2.2 The foundation register

Complete this with the sales manager, delivery lead, and finance owner. Treat unknown items as work to do, not permission to guess.

Foundation	Evidence to collect	Question a trainee must answer
Company	Ownership, locations, team structure, factual introduction	Who are we and how do we operate?
Services	Approved catalog with deliverables and exclusions	What does the client actually receive?
Ideal customers	Wins, losses, profitable accounts	Which buyers fit our economics and proof?
Industries	Project references and domain specialists	Where do we understand the workflow?
Personas	Roles involved in previous purchases	Who experiences, funds, and approves the problem?
Business problems	Interview notes and measured baselines	What is slow, costly, risky, or blocking growth?
Technology problems	Architecture reviews and incident patterns	Which constraint prevents improvement?
Reasons to buy	Recorded triggers and buying criteria	Why did clients act now?
Reasons not to buy	Loss interviews and no-decision records	What made the project unattractive or unsafe?
Competitors	Actual alternatives in deals	What can the buyer choose instead?
Positioning	One clear offer for one buyer group	What should buyers remember us for?
Differentiation	Verifiable methods, proof, or expertise	What can we demonstrate rather than claim?
Pricing and margins	Rate approvals and cost assumptions	Where is the approved commercial floor?

Foundation	Evidence to collect	Question a trainee must answer
Delivery capability	Capacity, start dates, partners, constraints	Can we staff this work responsibly?
Team capability	Skills matrix and interview availability	Who has relevant experience?
Case studies	Approved scope, evidence, reference permissions	Which story is safe and relevant to share?
Successful projects	Original problem, delivery, and measured result	What made success possible?
Failures and lessons	Retrospectives, overruns, scope disputes	What warning signs must we catch earlier?
Qualification	Stage criteria and required evidence	What makes an opportunity worth investment?
Disqualification	Clear commercial and ethical stop rules	When should we decline or defer?

Capability claim template. Service: [ ]. Delivered before: [yes/no]. Evidence: [project and permission]. Lead specialist: [ ]. Current capacity: [ ]. Supported constraints: [ ]. Exclusions: [ ]. Approved public wording: [ ]. Last reviewed: [ ].

“Experienced in healthcare” needs more than a healthcare-themed website. Specify what was delivered, which data was handled, the team's role, and the controls implemented. Do not confuse a partner's experience with the agency's own experience.

2.3 The commercial chain

Stage	Required output before the next stage
Product	A defined service offer with deliverables, boundaries, and proof
Market	A segment where the problem matters and buyers can purchase
ICP	Account selection and exclusion rules
Persona	Roles, priorities, influence, and likely objections
Problem	A buyer-relevant hypothesis to test
Value	A measurable improvement and its assumptions
Message	A short, credible reason to talk
Channel	A permitted place to reach the persona
Lead	A real account and relevant person with verified context
Qualification	Evidence of fit, problem, commercial potential, and process

Stage	Required output before the next stage
Discovery	A shared understanding of current state and desired change
Solution	Options validated by the appropriate specialists
Proposal	Scope, economics, responsibilities, and acceptance
Negotiation	Resolved trade-offs and approved terms
Close	Signed agreement and required purchase conditions
Delivery	Accepted handoff, execution, communication, and value measurement
Expansion	A new validated need following demonstrated delivery value

This chain loops. Discovery may reveal a different persona or invalidate the original value hypothesis. Returning to an earlier stage is better than forcing a bad lead through the funnel.

2.4 Positioning that can be defended

Weak: “We do every technology for every industry at affordable prices.” It gives the buyer no useful way to assess fit.

Stronger illustrative positioning: “We help field-service operators replace duplicate paper and spreadsheet reporting with an offline-capable reporting workflow connected to billing.” This specifies a buyer, a problem, and a deliverable. Only use it if the agency can show relevant work.

Differentiate using evidence: a reusable migration method, accessible design expertise, a domain workflow, a reliable transition plan, or a relevant reference. “Quality,” “innovation,” and “customer focus” become useful only when supported by concrete practices.

2.5 When to stop pursuing

Decline or escalate requests involving deceptive claims, unauthorized data access, impossible delivery conditions, payment terms outside policy, or missing specialist capability. Defer when there is no owner, no credible funding route, no access to essential systems, or no reason to change. Record the reason and the condition that would justify reopening.

A small budget is not automatically a bad lead. A smaller scope, paid diagnostic, existing product, or referral may fit. A large budget is not automatically a good lead if liabilities and delivery risks are uncontrolled.

Foundation gate. Deliver a two-minute company introduction, explain two offers and their exclusions, present one approved case study, classify five accounts, calculate one margin example, and identify three disqualifiers. Manager scores accuracy 30, relevance 25, commercial judgment 25, clarity 20. Pass at 80/100 with no fabricated claims or unauthorized promises. Full-scale lead generation remains locked until this gate and the technical fluency gate in Chapter 22 are passed.

3 How IT services businesses make money

3.1 Separate what is sold from how it is billed

A mobile app is a service deliverable. Fixed price is a pricing model. Staff augmentation is a responsibility model. MVP is a scope strategy. Managed service is an operating commitment. These dimensions can combine. For example, an MVP may begin with fixed-fee discovery and continue with capped monthly time and materials.

An agency sells delivery capacity, expertise, risk reduction, or an operated outcome. Revenue must cover direct staff cost, delivery management, rework, tools, overhead, and profit. Utilization means how much available capacity is spent on billable work. A high hourly rate does not ensure profit if the team spends too many unbilled hours.

The cards below use the requested commercial format. Example amounts are hypothetical USD training figures, excluding taxes, licenses, cloud charges, and travel unless stated. Complexity is relative: low means bounded and familiar; medium means multiple workflows or dependencies; high means substantial integration, regulatory, migration, or uncertainty risk.

3.2 Project based development

What it is: A finite piece of work with an agreed objective and completion condition. **Why businesses buy it and problem solved:** A missing portal, workflow, or product blocks operations or revenue. **When to sell:** There is an owner, a defined outcome, and a path to acceptance. **When not to sell:** Continuous operational responsibility is being disguised as a one-off build.

Who buys and key buyer: Founders and operating departments; budget usually sits with the founder, product head, or IT head. **Terminology:** Scope, milestone, deliverable, acceptance. **Discovery:** What must users accomplish? Who accepts completion? **Integrations:** Existing identity, CRM, payments, or reporting. **Typical team:** Product analyst, designer, developers, QA, project manager. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Commercial model:** Fixed price or T&M.

Example project and pitch: A $30,000 dealer portal. “We can map dealer ordering and deliver the first approved workflow in stages.” **Advantage:** Clear objective. **Risk and objection:** Scope expands while price stays fixed; buyer fears delays. **Common mistake:** Selling a feature list without acceptance criteria.

3.3 Fixed price

What: One agreed price for defined scope. **Why and problem:** Buyer needs budget certainty. **Sell when:** Requirements, dependencies, and acceptance are sufficiently known. **Do not sell when:** Critical integration or data feasibility remains unresolved. **Who and key buyer:** Finance-conscious business sponsor with procurement.

Terminology: Baseline scope, change request, assumptions, contingency. **Discovery:** What is excluded? Which client inputs can delay us? **Integrations:** Validate access and API behavior before committing. **Team:** Estimating technical lead, delivery team, PM. **Complexity:** Any size, but uncertainty must be bounded. **Commercial model:** Milestone payments against explicit deliverables.

Example and pitch: $18,000 for three approved workflows after discovery. “We can commit to this scope and price once these dependencies are confirmed.” **Advantage:** Predictable commercial envelope. **Risk:** Agency bears estimation risk. **Objection:** “Why pay for changes?” Explain baseline versus new requirements. **Mistake:** Giving a fixed quote from a one-paragraph brief.

3.4 Time and materials

What: Charge for approved effort at agreed rates, plus agreed expenses. **Why and problem:** Priorities evolve or uncertainty cannot be priced sensibly. **Sell when:** Buyer can govern the backlog and review progress. **Do not sell when:** Buyer needs a guaranteed total without controlling scope. **Buyer:** Product head or CTO; finance approves budget.

Terms: Burn rate, cap, timesheet, backlog. **Questions:** Who prioritizes? What spend triggers approval? **Integrations:** Any, with exploratory work budgeted. **Team:** Cross-functional delivery team. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Weekly reporting and monthly invoicing, optionally with a spending cap.

Example and pitch: Four-week work period capped at $16,000, then review. “You can change priorities while keeping visibility into spend and completed work.” **Advantage:** Flexibility. **Risk:** Poor governance creates endless spending. **Objection:** “Is this a blank cheque?” Offer budget alerts and stop points. **Mistake:** Treating a cap as a promise to complete every feature.

3.5 Hourly work

What: A billing unit for small tasks or consulting; often part of T&M. **Why and problem:** A buyer needs limited expert help. **Sell when:** Work can be authorized in small batches. **Do not sell when:** Many dependencies require coordinated project ownership. **Buyer:** Engineering or IT manager.

Terms: Minimum engagement, billable hour, rounding, approval. **Questions:** Who authorizes tasks? What counts as billable? **Integrations:** The existing codebase and tools. **Team:** One specialist with review support. **Complexity:** Low to medium. **Model:** Example 20 approved hours at $50, or $1,000.

Pitch: “Start with a bounded diagnostic and approve further effort after the findings.” **Advantage:** Low initial commitment. **Risk:** Context-switching and coordination reduce efficiency. **Objection:** “Why does this take ten hours?” Explain investigation, validation, and review. **Mistake:** Quoting only keyboard time and omitting testing.

3.6 Prepaid bucket

What: A purchased block of hours consumed against approved work. **Why and problem:** Recurring small tasks are hard to procure individually. **Sell when:** Demand is intermittent and the task boundaries are clear. **Do not sell when:** Buyer expects guaranteed 24/7 response without an SLA. **Buyer:** IT or marketing operations manager.

Terms: Expiry, rollover, response window, consumption report. **Questions:** Which roles can use the hours? Do unused hours expire? **Integrations:** Existing sites and platforms. **Team:** Shared support specialists. **Complexity:** Low to medium. **Model:** Example 40 hours for $2,000 with explicit validity and scheduling rules.

Pitch: “Reserve a small support budget and see the balance after every task.” **Advantage:** Simple purchasing. **Risk:** Disputes about expiry or availability. **Objection:** “What if we do not use it?” Discuss a smaller bucket or retainer. **Mistake:** Calling prepaid hours an unlimited support plan.

3.7 Dedicated developers

What: Named engineering capacity allocated to a client. **Why and problem:** Roadmap demand exceeds the client's hiring capacity. **Sell when:** The client has a product owner and work to assign. **Do not sell when:** Nobody can manage priorities or review output. **Buyer:** CTO or engineering manager.

Terms: Allocation, notice, replacement, overlap hours. **Questions:** Who manages daily work? How will skills be validated? **Integrations:** Client repository, tickets, CI/CD. **Team:** Developer, account support,

optional tech lead and QA. **Complexity:** Depends on product and onboarding. **Model:** Example $6,000 monthly allocation with defined capacity and holidays.

Pitch: “Add verified capacity for the integration backlog, with agreed overlap and a documented transition.” **Advantage:** Continuity. **Risk:** Dependency on individuals. **Objection:** “Will the developer be fully allocated?” Specify it contractually. **Mistake:** Promising unlimited monthly hours or presenting an unavailable CV.

3.8 Staff augmentation

What: Specialists join the client's operating team while the client retains delivery direction. **Why and problem:** Temporary skill gaps or workload spikes. **Sell when:** Responsibilities and supervision are clear. **Do not sell when:** Buyer expects the agency to own the entire outcome at a staff-only rate. **Buyer:** Engineering leader, vendor manager, procurement.

Terms: Resource onboarding, access, worker classification, replacement. **Questions:** Who owns delivery risk? Which systems need access? **Integrations:** Client tools and security controls. **Team:** Requested specialists plus account owner. **Complexity:** Medium, sometimes high in regulated environments. **Model:** Monthly or hourly capacity.

Example and pitch: Two QA engineers for three months. “We can support your release team with tested specialists and defined onboarding.” **Advantage:** Speed and flexibility. **Risk:** Poor client direction or employment-related complications. **Objection:** “We prefer employees.” Compare the temporary need honestly. **Mistake:** Treating augmentation as a managed project without pricing management.

3.9 Managed services

What: Ongoing responsibility for a defined service with measured operating commitments. **Why and problem:** Systems need reliable operation and incident response. **Sell when:** The agency can staff the support model. **Do not sell when:** On-call capacity or system visibility is missing. **Buyer:** CIO or IT operations head.

Terms: SLA, service hours, severity, response, restoration, escalation. **Questions:** Which systems? What business loss follows an outage? **Integrations:** Monitoring, ticketing, cloud, identity. **Team:** Service manager, engineers, security and escalation support. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Monthly fee with volume and scope limits.

Example and pitch: $4,500 monthly for specified business-hours operations. “We will own monitoring and incident handling within these service boundaries.” **Advantage:** Predictable recurring work. **Risk:** Underpriced incident load. **Objection:** “Is resolution guaranteed?” Distinguish response from restoration targets. **Mistake:** Selling 24/7 as a slogan without staffing it.

3.10 Retainer

What: A recurring fee for agreed access, capacity, or deliverables. **Why and problem:** Buyer needs continuity without procuring every task. **Sell when:** A repeatable need exists. **Do not sell when:** Deliverables and availability are undefined. **Buyer:** Founder, department head, or IT manager.

Terms: Included work, cadence, rollover, notice. **Questions:** Is the fee for availability, hours, or outputs? **Integrations:** Existing systems. **Team:** Depends on retained expertise. **Complexity:** Low to high. **Model:** Example $3,000 monthly for defined improvement and review work.

Pitch: “We can reserve capacity for the priorities you approve each month.” **Advantage:** Planning continuity. **Risk:** Mismatched expectations. **Objection:** “Why pay in a quiet month?” Explain the reservation or change the model. **Mistake:** Using retainer and managed service as synonyms.

3.11 Consulting

What: Expert diagnosis and recommendations, sometimes implementation oversight. **Why and problem:** Buyer must make a difficult technology or investment decision. **Sell when:** Independent analysis has value. **Do not sell when:** Buyer only wants free architecture for a competitive tender. **Buyer:** CEO, CTO, CIO, or business sponsor.

Terms: Assessment, options, roadmap, decision record. **Questions:** Which decision must this work enable? Who will act on it? **Integrations:** Read-only access to relevant documentation and systems. **Team:** Domain consultant and architect. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Fixed-fee assessment or expert-day billing.

Example and pitch: $5,000 modernization assessment. “You will receive options, risks, and a costed next-step recommendation.” **Advantage:** Reduces uncertainty. **Risk:** Advice is never implemented. **Objection:** “Can you include this free?” Separate light qualification from substantive consulting. **Mistake:** Delivering a generic slide deck without a decision.

3.12 Paid discovery and proof of concept

What: Discovery defines the problem and scope; a POC tests a specific uncertainty. **Why and problem:** Buyer should not fund a full build before feasibility is clear. **Sell when:** Unknowns materially affect viability. **Do not sell when:** The experiment has no success or stop criteria. **Buyer:** Product sponsor and CTO.

Terms: Hypothesis, test set, feasibility, go/no-go. **Questions:** What must we learn? What would make us stop? **Integrations:** Sandbox or representative data. **Team:** Analyst, architect, targeted engineer, QA. **Complexity:** Bounded experiment despite potentially complex subject. **Model:** Example $4,000 fixed-fee assessment.

Pitch: “Test the difficult integration first, then decide whether to invest.” **Advantage:** Limits downside. **Risk:** Prototype mistaken for production. **Objection:** “Why not just build?” Explain the cost of the unresolved risk. **Mistake:** Promising a POC automatically proves scale, security, and reliability.

3.13 MVP development

What: The smallest usable product that tests an important commercial assumption. **Why and problem:** A founder needs evidence before funding a full roadmap. **Sell when:** There is a target user and testable value proposition. **Do not sell when:** 'MVP' means a large product at a small price. **Buyer:** Founder or product leader.

Terms: Core journey, hypothesis, activation, learning metric. **Questions:** What must users do? What result would change the investment decision? **Integrations:** Only those essential to the core journey. **Team:** Product lead, designer, full-stack engineer, QA. **Complexity:** Medium, rising with payments or regulated data. **Model:** Paid discovery then phased fixed scope or T&M.

Example and pitch: $24,000 first release for one buyer group. “Validate one complete workflow before expanding.” **Advantage:** Focused learning. **Risk:** Cutting necessary security to save money. **Objection:** “Can we add five more modules?” Revisit the hypothesis. **Mistake:** Treating minimum as unreliable.

3.14 Product development

What: Continuous improvement of a software product across releases. **Why and problem:** Customer needs, competition, and operational demands keep changing. **Sell when:** A product owner can prioritize

outcomes. **Do not sell when:** No funding or ownership exists beyond launch. **Buyer:** Head of Product or CTO.

Terms: Roadmap, backlog, release, technical debt. **Questions:** Which user behavior or business metric must improve? **Integrations:** Analytics, support, billing, business systems. **Team:** Durable product squad. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Monthly T&M squad or capacity agreement.

Example and pitch: Three-month enhancement program with monthly reviews. “We will prioritize releases against adoption and operating needs.” **Advantage:** Compounding domain knowledge. **Risk:** Feature output replaces value measurement. **Objection:** “How do we control spend?” Use capacity, outcome reviews, and stop points. **Mistake:** Selling a roadmap as a fixed list of guaranteed future features.

3.15 Maintenance and support

What: Fix defects, update dependencies, and support agreed production behavior. **Why and problem:** Software degrades as environments and threats change. **Sell when:** Ownership, access, and support hours are known. **Do not sell when:** The inherited system is unassessed but unlimited responsibility is demanded. **Buyer:** IT manager or product owner.

Terms: Warranty, severity, patch, end of support. **Questions:** What qualifies as a bug versus enhancement? **Integrations:** Repository, monitoring, ticketing, hosting. **Team:** Support engineer, developer, QA. **Complexity:** Depends on system condition. **Model:** Assessment plus retainer or ticket-based work.

Example and pitch: $1,800 monthly bounded support. “Keep the existing system reliable with a clear queue and escalation path.” **Advantage:** Continuity. **Risk:** Legacy defects consume the fee. **Objection:** “Shouldn't all fixes be free?” Refer to agreed warranty boundaries. **Mistake:** Including new features in an undefined warranty.

3.16 QA outsourcing

What: External testing capability or responsibility for an agreed quality scope. **Why and problem:** Releases fail, regression takes too long, or internal QA is thin. **Sell when:** Access, environments, and release ownership are available. **Do not sell when:** Buyer expects zero defects from a limited test budget. **Buyer:** Engineering manager or QA head.

Terms: Coverage, regression, flaky test, defect severity. **Questions:** Which failures hurt customers most? **Integrations:** CI/CD, issue tracker, test data. **Team:** QA lead, manual or automation engineers. **Complexity:** Medium. **Model:** Diagnostic followed by project, capacity, or retainer.

Example and pitch: Automate 20 critical checkout tests after a testability review. “Protect the release journeys that create the most business risk.” **Advantage:** Independent scrutiny. **Risk:** Brittle automation. **Objection:** “Developers already test.” Identify uncovered risks. **Mistake:** Selling test count instead of meaningful coverage.

3.17 Cloud and DevOps support

What: Improve deployment, infrastructure, reliability, or cloud economics. **Why and problem:** Releases are slow, outages recur, or costs are unclear. **Sell when:** Baselines and access can be established. **Do not sell when:** An infrastructure redesign has no business justification. **Buyer:** CTO, platform lead, or CIO.

Terms: CI/CD, infrastructure as code, RTO, RPO, observability. **Questions:** What fails today? What does recovery require? **Integrations:** Cloud, repositories, monitoring, identity. **Team:** Cloud architect,

DevOps or SRE, security. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Assessment, migration project, then optional managed service.

Example and pitch: $7,500 deployment and recovery improvement phase. “Make releases repeatable and test recovery before promising uptime.” **Advantage:** Reduces operating friction. **Risk:** Migration downtime and uncontrolled spend. **Objection:** “Cloud is already managed.” Explain customer responsibilities. **Mistake:** Guaranteeing savings before reviewing usage.

3.18 AI consulting and implementation

What: Select, test, integrate, and govern AI for a real workflow. **Why and problem:** Repetitive language, prediction, image, or speech tasks consume capacity. **Sell when:** Value, data rights, evaluation, and exception ownership are feasible. **Do not sell when:** A simple rule solves the problem or errors cannot be controlled. **Buyer:** Operations head, product leader, CTO.

Terms: Evaluation, RAG, inference cost, human review. **Questions:** Which task? What is an unacceptable error? **Integrations:** Knowledge stores, CRM, helpdesk, identity. **Team:** Domain owner, AI engineer, backend engineer, QA, security. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Paid diagnostic and pilot, then phased rollout.

Example and pitch: Test an internal support assistant on approved documents. “Measure answer quality and total handling cost before expanding.” **Advantage:** Potential capacity improvement. **Risk:** Hallucinations, leakage, cost growth. **Objection:** “Why not use a chatbot subscription?” Compare workflow integration needs. **Mistake:** Selling an autonomous agent before proving a supervised workflow.

3.19 Digital transformation

What: Coordinated changes to processes, data, systems, and operating behavior. **Why and problem:** Fragmented workflows limit business performance. **Sell when:** Leadership will own process change and adoption. **Do not sell when:** A website redesign is being inflated into enterprise transformation. **Buyer:** CEO, COO, CIO.

Terms: Current state, target state, operating model, adoption. **Questions:** Which business process and owner? How will behavior change? **Integrations:** ERP, CRM, finance, operations. **Team:** Business consultant, architect, change lead, delivery specialists. **Complexity:** High. **Model:** Assessment and staged program.

Example and pitch: Digitize order-to-cash in phases. “Start with the slowest handoff and measure its effect before wider change.” **Advantage:** Systemic improvement. **Risk:** Organizational resistance. **Objection:** “We cannot disrupt operations.” Design staged transition. **Mistake:** Pricing software only while omitting training, data cleanup, and adoption.

3.20 Technology modernization

What: Improve or replace legacy components while preserving needed business behavior. **Why and problem:** Unsupported systems, slow releases, or fragile integrations raise risk. **Sell when:** Constraints and migration paths can be assessed. **Do not sell when:** A functioning system is being rewritten only for fashion. **Buyer:** CIO, CTO, application owner.

Terms: Refactor, replatform, rehost, strangler pattern, rollback. **Questions:** What must remain stable? Which dependencies are undocumented? **Integrations:** Legacy databases, jobs, ERP, identity. **Team:** Architect, legacy and target-stack engineers, QA, migration lead. **Complexity:** High. **Model:** Paid assessment then phased T&M or bounded migrations.

Example and pitch: Replace one reporting module before the core system. “Reduce the highest-risk dependency without a big-bang rewrite.” **Advantage:** Controlled risk reduction. **Risk:** Hidden behavior and data loss. **Objection:** “Why not replace everything?” Compare operational risk. **Mistake:** Estimating only new code and forgetting parity testing.

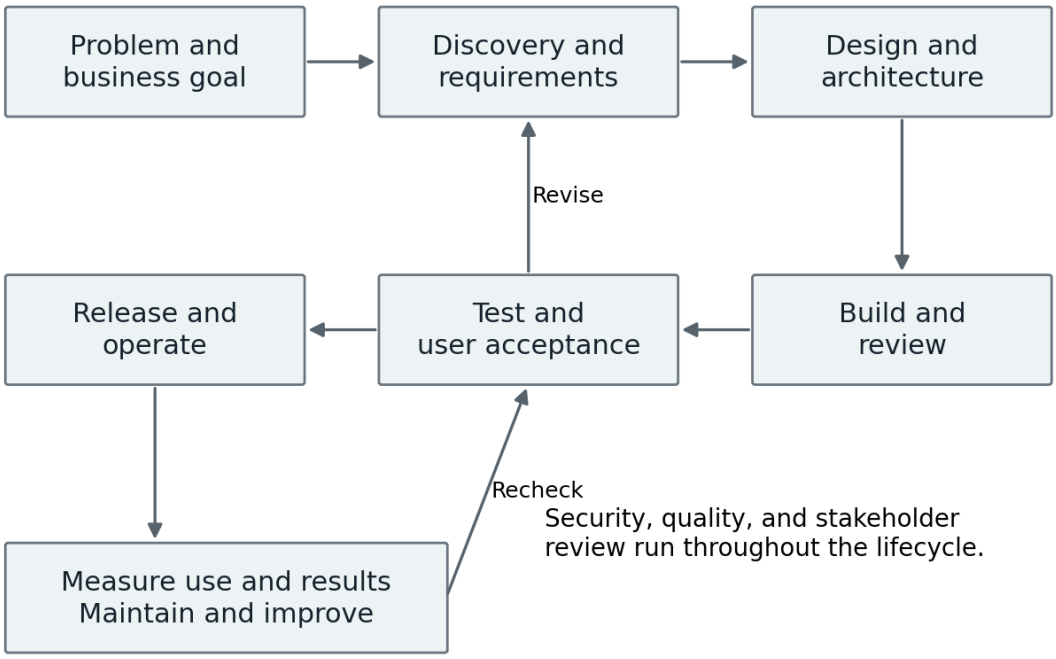
Assignment. Choose a model for five requests: unclear AI concept, stable portal scope, temporary QA gap, production support, and legacy migration. Explain who controls scope, who bears risk, and how work is accepted. Pass when all five choices are defensible and no model promises an outcome it cannot control.

4 The software development lifecycle

4.1 From problem to an operated system

Software work moves from understanding a problem to designing, building, checking, releasing, and improving a system. The sequence is not rigid. Teams revisit requirements and design as they learn. Agile means short learning and delivery cycles with prioritization; it does not mean no documentation, no estimates, or unlimited changes.

A sprint is a short planning and delivery period. A backlog is a prioritized list of work. A release is a version made available to users. The definition of done describes the checks required before work counts as complete. A demo shows progress; it is not automatically contractual acceptance.



4.2 Stage by stage field guide

Stage and owner	What happens and what the BDE must understand	Question and commercial risk
Idea, sponsor	Initial belief about an opportunity	Who needs it? Unvalidated demand can waste the entire budget.
Business requirement, sponsor and analyst	Define the business change and its impact	Which measurable problem? Vague goals cause conflicting scope.
Discovery, analyst and architect	Investigate users, workflows, constraints, and options	Which assumptions could invalidate the build? Discovery reduces estimate uncertainty.

Stage and owner	What happens and what the BDE must understand	Question and commercial risk
Requirement gathering, analyst	Interviews, examples, exceptions, and priorities	Can users show a real transaction? Missing exceptions cause rework.
BRD, analyst and sponsor	Business Requirements Document describes objectives and scope	Who approves the business baseline? Unclear ownership delays decisions.
FRD, analyst and technical lead	Functional Requirements Document describes system behavior	What should happen in each situation? Missing rules increase effort.
User stories, product owner	Describe a user, a need, and its purpose	Which user and why? Large stories hide multiple workflows.
Acceptance criteria, product owner and QA	Observable conditions for successful behavior	How do we know this works? Subjective acceptance creates disputes.
UX and UI, designer	UX organizes use; UI defines visible controls and screens	Which devices and accessibility needs? Late redesign adds cost.
Architecture, architect	Decide components, connections, constraints, and trade-offs	What quality attributes matter? Overengineering adds recurring cost.
Database, data engineer or backend lead	Model records, relationships, access, and history	What data must be retained or migrated? Cleanup can exceed build effort.
Frontend, frontend engineer	Build the interface users operate	Which browsers and screen sizes? Device variety expands testing.
Backend, backend engineer	Implement rules, permissions, and processing	What must happen if a step fails? Hidden rules drive complexity.
API, backend or integration engineer	Define controlled system-to-system communication	Are docs, access, and limits available? Missing APIs change scope.
Third-party integration, integration engineer	Connect external services and handle failure	Who owns credentials and fees? Vendor delays affect the critical path.
Development, engineering team	Implement and review working code	Are priorities stable for the work period? Repeated switching slows delivery.
QA, QA team with engineers	Test behavior, risk, and regressions	Which failures are unacceptable? Late defect discovery creates rework.
Security, security lead and engineers	Threat analysis, secure design, access, and testing throughout	What data and threat exposure? Security is not a final checkbox.
Deployment, DevOps and release owner	Move a tested version into an environment	Who approves release and rollback? Access delays block launch.

Stage and owner	What happens and what the BDE must understand	Question and commercial risk
DevOps, platform and engineering teams	Maintain practices and tools for reliable delivery	How repeatable is deployment? Manual operations add risk.
Monitoring, operations	Observe health, errors, usage, and service quality	Who gets alerts and acts? Unowned alerts do not improve reliability.
Maintenance, support owner	Fix defects and keep dependencies supported	What is warranty versus change? Ambiguity causes unpaid work.
Scaling, architect and operations	Increase capacity as demand changes	Which peak load and cost limits? More servers do not fix every bottleneck.
Product enhancement, product owner	Improve workflows using evidence	Which metric justifies the next feature? Unprioritized ideas drain budget.

4.3 Worked requirement example

Business problem: a distributor takes too long to approve credit orders. Business requirement: reduce approval handling time while preserving finance controls. Functional requirement: orders above a configured credit threshold require finance approval before release.

User story: “As a finance approver, I need to review flagged orders so that the warehouse releases only authorized credit orders.”

Acceptance criteria: An over-limit order enters Pending Approval. Only the finance approver role can approve it. Approval records user, time, and decision. Rejected orders cannot be released. If the finance service is unavailable, the order remains pending and the user sees a retry-safe message. Notification failure must not approve the order.

Non-functional requirement: under a defined test load of 100 concurrent users, 95% of approval-list requests complete within two seconds in the agreed environment. This is a sample requirement to validate, not a default promise.

The first request sounded like “add an approval button.” Discovery revealed roles, data rules, audit history, integrations, error handling, and performance. Those details explain effort without hiding behind jargon.

4.4 Responsibility and scope discipline

The client sponsor owns business priorities and acceptance authority. The product owner clarifies daily requirements. The architect validates technical choices. Engineers and QA estimate their work. The PM coordinates dependencies and delivery. The BDE preserves the commercial agreement and prevents sales context from being lost.

Exercise. Convert “build a customer dashboard” into one business goal, three user stories, five acceptance criteria, two quality requirements, and three dependencies. Have QA identify ambiguous wording. Pass when the team can test the criteria without asking what “fast,” “simple,” or “user-friendly” means.

5 Technology knowledge for IT sales

5.1 Learn systems before brand names

A user interacts with an interface. The interface sends a request to application logic. That logic checks permissions, reads or changes data, and may call other systems. Hosting runs the software. Monitoring tells the team whether it is healthy. Security applies across every layer.

A website mainly publishes content. A web application supports interactive work such as approving orders. A mobile application runs through a mobile platform and may require device features. A SaaS product provides software as an ongoing service, often with multiple customer organizations. None of these terms tells you the project's size by itself.

Must know: Explain this flow, distinguish frontend/backend/database, recognize APIs, describe testing and hosting responsibilities, and ask about users, data, integrations, quality, and ownership. **Awareness:** Recognize platform names and their broad fit. **Specialist decision:** Choose architecture, security design, model provider, database configuration, or production sizing.

The commercial cards in this chapter apply to each named technology beneath them. Use the card for the business conversation and the comparison rows for technology-specific fit. A framework is usually an implementation choice inside a service, not a separate service to pitch.

5.2 Frontend and interface development

What it is: The part people see and operate. **Why businesses buy it:** Users cannot complete tasks efficiently or the company needs a new digital channel. **Problem solved:** Confusing journeys, inaccessible interfaces, slow interactions. **When to sell:** A known user task needs a better interface. **When not to sell:** A visual redesign cannot fix broken fulfillment or business rules.

Who buys and key buyer: Product and marketing teams; product head or CMO. **Terminology:** Responsive design, accessibility, component, rendering, browser. **Discovery questions:** Who uses it? On which devices? Must content be discoverable by search engines? What can users not complete today? **Common integrations:** Backend APIs, identity, analytics, CMS. **Typical team:** UX/UI designer, frontend engineer, QA, backend support. **Complexity:** Low for a simple page, high for offline or real-time collaboration. **Commercial model:** Design discovery then bounded build or product squad.

Example project and pitch: A dealer ordering interface. “We can simplify the order journey and validate it with representative users.” **Common objections:** “Just copy this design.” Ask which user needs it meets. **Common BDE mistakes:** Promising that a framework alone will improve conversion or accessibility. Web fundamentals remain useful regardless of framework fashion. [11]

Technology	What it is and typical use	Strength and limitation	Fit question
HTML	Defines web page structure and meaning	Essential foundation; does not supply application logic	What content and forms must be accessible?
CSS	Controls web layout and presentation	Responsive interfaces; visual styling cannot repair poor workflows	Which screen sizes and brand rules?
JavaScript	Programming language used heavily in browsers and also servers	Interactivity and broad ecosystem; complexity needs discipline	How interactive is the workflow?

Technology	What it is and typical use	Strength and limitation	Fit question
TypeScript	Adds static type checking to JavaScript development	Helps teams catch classes of errors; does not guarantee runtime correctness	Does the existing team use it?
React	Library for building component-based interfaces	Reusable UI patterns; needs surrounding architectural choices	Is this an interactive product with existing React capability?
Next.js	React framework supporting routing and server-side capabilities	Useful for content plus application experiences; hosting and caching add decisions	Which pages need server rendering or search visibility?
Angular	Structured frontend framework	Useful for convention-heavy applications; learning and migration effort	Is there an existing Angular estate or team standard?
Vue	Progressive frontend framework	Flexible adoption; team availability and existing systems still matter	Is gradual interface adoption required?
Flutter	Dart-based cross-platform UI toolkit	Shared mobile UI work; native integrations and platform testing remain	Are custom visuals and mobile platforms central?
React Native	React-based approach to mobile apps using native platform capabilities	Shares skills and code; native modules may still be required	Which device features and native SDKs are needed?
Ionic	Web-based cross-platform UI approach, commonly paired with native wrappers	Fits web-skilled teams and some business apps; native-heavy performance needs validation	Could a web-first app meet the device requirements?

Flutter, React Native, and Ionic belong in a cross-platform application conversation, not a list of equivalent browser frameworks. Also recognize Swift for iOS and Kotlin for Android at awareness level. Native development can be appropriate for deep platform features, even when shared-code options look cheaper.

5.3 Backend engineering

What: Server-side business rules, permissions, processing, and integration. **Why and problem:** Reliable transactions and operational workflows. **Sell when:** The product needs controlled behavior or integration. **Do not sell when:** A standard SaaS configuration solves the requirement adequately. **Who and key buyer:** Product or IT teams; CTO. **Terms:** Service, endpoint, queue, transaction, authorization. **Questions:** Which rules? What happens on failure? What already exists? **Integrations:** Database, identity, payment, ERP. **Team:** Backend engineer, architect, QA. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Project or squad. **Example and pitch:** “Implement the order rules and integration checks behind the portal.” **Objection:** “Which language is fastest?” Clarify workload and team constraints. **Mistake:** Claiming one language is universally scalable.

Technology	Use and positioning	Trade-off and question
Node.js	JavaScript runtime often used for APIs and event-driven applications	CPU-heavy work may need different execution patterns. Is the team already using JS/TS?
Python	APIs, automation, data work, ML and AI integration	Runtime and deployment choices affect performance. Is data or AI work central?
Java	Established enterprise applications and service platforms	Strong fit with existing estates; migration and team standards matter. What systems must remain compatible?
.NET and C#	Enterprise applications, APIs, and Microsoft-oriented environments	Modern .NET is cross-platform; do not assume Windows-only. Which identity and Microsoft systems exist?
PHP	Web applications, CMS ecosystems, and frameworks such as Laravel	Suitable for many web workloads; existing code quality varies. Is there a PHP/CMS estate to extend?
Go or Golang	Services, infrastructure tooling, and concurrency-heavy work	Often requires specific team capability. Is this an operational or high-concurrency service?
Ruby	Commonly encountered through Rails products and established SaaS applications	Strong existing-product relevance; hiring and team familiarity matter. Are we extending Rails or proposing a rewrite?

Never dismiss PHP, Java, .NET, or Ruby as obsolete based on social media. Existing systems create valuable maintenance, integration, and modernization work. Verify support status for the actual versions involved.

5.4 Databases and storage

What: Organized persistence of business records and other data. **Why and problem:** Reliable orders, users, inventory, and reporting. **Sell when:** Data consistency, access, or migration is a real constraint. **Do not sell when:** A database replacement lacks evidence of the bottleneck. **Buyer:** CTO or data lead. **Terms:** Schema, transaction, index, consistency, backup, replication. **Questions:** What data, volume, relationships, retention, and recovery needs? **Integrations:** Applications, analytics, migration tools. **Team:** Backend/data engineer, architect, QA. **Complexity:** Medium, high for migrations. **Model:** Assessment plus implementation. **Example and pitch:** “Validate and migrate customer records with reconciliation and rollback.” **Objection:** “Can we move everything over a weekend?” Test it. **Mistake:** Confusing a backup with proven recovery.

Concept or product	Plain meaning and fit	Limit or discovery question
SQL	Relational data, typically structured into related tables	What transactions and relationships must remain consistent?
NoSQL	Broad family including document, key-value, and other models	It does not mean no structure or automatic scale. Which access patterns matter?

Concept or product	Plain meaning and fit	Limit or discovery question
PostgreSQL	Relational database with extensive data and extension capabilities	Useful general-purpose option, not a default for every workload. What operational skills exist?
MySQL	Widely used relational database for web and business applications	Existing systems and operational fit matter. Are there migration dependencies?
MongoDB	Document database for document-oriented access patterns	Flexible documents still need deliberate schema and consistency design. How is data queried?
Redis	In-memory data structures, often used for cache and fast temporary access	Durability and eviction behavior require design. Is it a cache or system of record?
Data warehouse	Store organized for analytical queries across business data	It serves different workloads from transaction processing. Who defines each metric?

PostgreSQL's official material describes broad capabilities, but capability alone does not settle fit or operational cost. [12]

5.5 APIs and integrations

What: Controlled communication between systems. **Why and problem:** Stop re-entry and keep workflows connected. **Sell when:** Data ownership and access are available. **Do not sell when:** The vendor prohibits access or there is no supported interface and no approved alternative. **Buyer:** IT or operations head. **Terms:** Endpoint, authentication, rate limit, mapping, retry, idempotency. **Questions:** Who provides documentation, sandbox, credentials, and support? What happens if the same request arrives twice? **Integrations:** CRM, ERP, payments, identity. **Team:** Integration/backend engineer, analyst, QA. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Feasibility check then bounded integration. **Example and pitch:** “Sync approved orders to finance with reconciliation and failure alerts.” **Objection:** “It is only an API.” Explain permissions and exception handling. **Mistake:** Estimating from endpoint count alone.

Term	Meaning	Why the BDE should care
REST API	A common style of web API organized around resources	Ask for actual API documentation, not just “REST supported.”
GraphQL	Query language and API execution approach letting clients request specified data	Can support flexible data access; authorization and query cost still need controls.
Webhook	A service sends an event notification to another service	Events can repeat or arrive out of order. Receiving work must be safe to retry.
OAuth	Framework for delegated authorization	It is not, by itself, a complete user authentication protocol.
SSO	Sign in once through an identity system to access connected apps	Common implementations use OpenID Connect or SAML. Enterprise identity can add scope.

Term	Meaning	Why the BDE should care
Payment gateway	Service that processes or routes payment interactions	Ask about countries, refunds, subscriptions, disputes, and reconciliation.
CRM integration	Exchange contacts, opportunities, and customer activity	Define source of truth and ownership of duplicate records.
ERP integration	Exchange finance, stock, purchasing, or operational records	Posting rules and reconciliation can be more complex than transport.
Third-party API	External service interface controlled by another organization	Version changes, fees, limits, downtime, and approval delays affect the deal.

5.6 Cloud platforms

What: Rented computing services operated through a provider. **Why and problem:** Launch or scale systems without owning all infrastructure. **Sell when:** Requirements and operating responsibilities justify it. **Do not sell when:** A move has no cost, reliability, or strategic benefit. **Buyer:** CIO, CTO, platform lead. **Terms:** Region, availability zone, compute, storage, network egress, shared responsibility. **Questions:** Where may data reside? What downtime and recovery loss are acceptable? **Integrations:** Identity, network, monitoring, databases. **Team:** Cloud architect, DevOps, security, application owners. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Assessment, migration, optional operations. **Example and pitch:** “Design a recovery-tested hosting plan aligned to the business workload.” **Objection:** “Cloud will automatically be cheaper.” Compare total costs. **Mistake:** Treating provider certification as application compliance. [10]

Platform	Plausible fit	What to validate
AWS	Broad application and infrastructure needs	Relevant services, team competence, region, support, and cost model
Microsoft Azure	Microsoft-oriented estates and wider cloud needs	Identity integration, procurement, existing agreements, and operations
Google Cloud	Application, analytics, and AI-related workloads	Data ecosystem, team skills, region, and integration needs
DigitalOcean	Some smaller application and infrastructure needs	Required managed services, availability needs, region, and support coverage

Compute runs workloads. Storage holds files or objects. A managed database reduces some operating work but still needs schema, security, and backup decisions. Serverless shifts server management to a provider and often bills by usage; it is not “no servers” or “always cheaper.” Containers package applications and dependencies. Kubernetes coordinates container workloads and adds operational responsibilities. A CDN caches content closer to users. Backups create recoverable copies. Monitoring observes behavior. None replaces tested incident procedures.

The CNCF survey published in January 2026 reported Kubernetes production use among 82% of surveyed container users. That is evidence within a cloud-native population, not a reason to put every SME application on Kubernetes. [4]

5.7 DevOps and reliability

What: Practices and tools that connect software delivery and operations. **Why and problem:** Slow, fragile releases and difficult recovery. **Sell when:** A measured delivery or operating bottleneck exists. **Do not sell when:** Tool installation is being mistaken for process improvement. **Buyer:** CTO or platform head. **Terms:** CI/CD, Git, infrastructure as code, observability, rollback. **Questions:** How does a change reach production? What fails? Who can recover it? **Integrations:** Repository, tests, cloud, alerts. **Team:** DevOps/SRE, developers, security, QA. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Improvement project or managed service. **Example and pitch:** “Create repeatable releases and test recovery with the people who operate the system.” **Objection:** “Our developer deploys manually.” Measure failure and waiting time. **Mistake:** Promising uptime without defining dependencies.

Git tracks source-code changes. GitHub and GitLab host collaboration and related tooling. CI automatically builds and checks changes. Continuous delivery prepares releasable changes; continuous deployment automatically releases eligible changes. Docker is widely used to build and run containers. Kubernetes orchestrates them. Infrastructure as code defines infrastructure through versioned configuration. Cloud migration changes where or how systems run and requires data, network, testing, and rollback planning.

Monitoring tracks known conditions; observability uses outputs such as logs, metrics, and traces to investigate system behavior. RTO is the targeted recovery time. RPO is the targeted amount of data loss measured in time. Neither is guaranteed merely by naming a cloud service.

5.8 QA and quality engineering

What: Work that reduces the risk of incorrect or unreliable software. **Why and problem:** Customer failures, expensive regressions, slow release confidence. **Sell when:** Critical journeys and ownership are identifiable. **Do not sell when:** “100% bug-free” is the acceptance standard. **Buyer:** QA head or engineering leader. **Terms:** Test case, test data, regression, coverage, defect, flaky test. **Questions:** What failed recently? Which journeys create the greatest loss? **Integrations:** CI/CD, issue tracker, environments. **Team:** QA lead, test engineers, developers. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Audit then project or retained capacity. **Example and pitch:** “Build evidence that the critical release journeys work, and reduce repeated manual checking.” **Objection:** “AI can write tests.” Someone still needs to choose risks and validate the tests. **Mistake:** Counting test scripts as business value.

Type or tool	Meaning and suitable use	Constraint or question
Manual QA	Human checks of behavior and experience	Valuable for exploration and changing features; repetitive checks consume time.
Automation QA	Programmed repeatable checks	Needs maintenance, stable selectors, environments, and test data.
Functional testing	Checks required behavior	Are requirements and expected results explicit?
Regression testing	Checks that changes did not break existing behavior	Which paths are most important after each release?
API testing	Checks service behavior directly	Include permissions, error cases, and data integrity.

Type or tool	Meaning and suitable use	Constraint or question
Performance testing	Tests behavior under defined workload	Specify load profile, environment, and acceptable results.
Security testing	Investigates security weaknesses	Define authorization and scope; not proof of perfect security.
Mobile testing	Tests device, OS, network, and app behavior	Device coverage and offline use affect effort.
UAT	User Acceptance Testing by authorized business representatives	Customer acceptance is distinct from internal QA.
Selenium	Browser automation ecosystem	Useful in established suites; maintenance and browser setup matter.
Cypress	Web testing framework	Evaluate application fit and team experience.
Playwright	Browser automation and testing framework	Strong candidate for web end-to-end tests; not a substitute for a test strategy.
Postman	API development and testing tool	Useful for API exploration and checks; needs controlled credentials and environments.

Playwright's documentation confirms supported browser testing and setup workflows. Tool support must be checked against the client's required browsers and versions at proposal time. [13]

5.9 AI concepts without inflated promises

AI is a broad category of systems performing tasks associated with intelligence. Machine learning learns patterns from data. Deep learning uses multi-layer neural networks. Generative AI produces content such as text, images, audio, or code. These terms overlap; they are not interchangeable product categories.

Concept	Plain meaning	BDE discovery implication
LLM	Large language model trained to process and generate language-like sequences	Ask about task quality and failure handling, not just model size.
NLP	Natural language processing, including classification, extraction, and other language tasks	Some tasks need a simpler classifier rather than a large generative model.
Computer vision	Interpreting images or video	Lighting, camera placement, labels, and deployment conditions affect results.
Speech AI	Speech recognition, synthesis, and related processing	Accents, noise, latency, consent, and telephony integration matter.
AI chatbot	Conversation interface to rules, retrieval, or models	A chat interface does not prove useful answers or secure access.

Concept	Plain meaning	BDE discovery implication
AI copilot	Assistance that keeps a person in control of work	Define what the person checks and how much review costs.
AI workflow	A defined sequence including model calls and ordinary software steps	Often easier to test and govern than open-ended autonomy.
AI agent	A system where a model can choose actions or tool use toward a goal	Limit permissions, duration, spend, and allowed actions.
Multi-agent system	Several agents assigned interacting roles	Coordination can add cost and failure paths. Require evidence it improves the task.
AI automation	Using AI inside a process to reduce manual work	Compare against rules, templates, and existing automation.
AI API	A programmatic way to call a model or AI capability	Data terms, availability, cost, and limits become dependencies.
Prompt engineering	Designing instructions, examples, and context for a model	Useful, but it cannot guarantee truth or access control.
Embedding	Numerical representation used for similarity and other tasks	Similarity is not proof of factual correctness or permission.
Vector database	Storage/search capabilities for vectors and metadata	A dedicated product is not always needed; existing databases may suffice.
RAG	Retrieval-augmented generation: retrieve relevant material and use it as model context	Check retrieval quality, freshness, citations, and document permissions.
Fine-tuning	Further training a model on examples for specific behavior	Not the default way to inject frequently changing company facts.
AI governance	Ownership, policies, evaluation, review, and control over AI use	Ask who can approve, monitor, change, and stop the system.
AI security	Protection against data leakage, misuse, malicious inputs, and unsafe actions	Ordinary application security still applies.

Commercial card for AI delivery

What it is: A controlled improvement to a task using predictive or generative techniques. **Why businesses buy it:** Reduce processing effort, improve service access, or enable a previously impractical workflow. **Business problem:** Repeated reading, classifying, drafting, searching, seeing, speaking, or forecasting. **When to sell:** Task volume, data access, evaluation, oversight, and unit economics support a pilot. **When not to sell:** There is no owner, representative test set, lawful data access, or manageable failure mode.

Who buys and key buyer: Business process owners with IT, data, and security; the budget owner may be the COO rather than CTO. **Terminology:** Baseline, evaluation set, inference, hallucination,

groundedness, human review, latency. **Discovery questions:** Which exact task? How often? What does a wrong answer cost? What data can be used? What actions are prohibited? **Common integrations:** Knowledge stores, CRM, ERP, helpdesk, identity, telephony. **Typical team:** Domain owner, AI engineer, backend engineer, QA/evaluation specialist, security, product lead. **Complexity:** Medium for supervised narrow work; high for actions across regulated systems. **Commercial model:** Assessment, paid pilot, staged production, ongoing evaluation and support.

Example project and pitch: “Test a draft-response assistant on a representative set of historical support cases, with approved data and human review.” **Common objections:** Reliability, cost, privacy, vendor dependence. **Common BDE mistakes:** Selling a demo as a production system, guaranteeing factual accuracy, or assuming all customer data can be sent to an external model.

Choose the least complex adequate approach

Start by asking whether a clear rule, search interface, standard integration, or existing product solves the task. If it does, do not add AI merely to make the proposal sound modern. For text generation, start with a bounded task and evaluation. Add retrieval when current or proprietary source material is needed. Consider fine-tuning when stable behavior is the problem and there are suitable examples. Use an agent only when flexible action selection adds enough value to justify its controls. Anthropic's guidance distinguishes fixed workflows from more autonomous agents and recommends matching complexity to need. [8]

RAG does not guarantee truth. It can retrieve the wrong document, miss a needed passage, or produce an unsupported answer. A production design must address ingestion, permissions, retrieval, answer evaluation, and monitoring. Microsoft's architecture guidance treats RAG as a system with evaluation requirements. [9]

Provider and platform conversation

OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google Gemini are examples of model ecosystems. Open-source and open-weight models may support self-hosting or alternative deployment, subject to the actual license. “Open-weight” does not automatically mean unrestricted use, no operating cost, or complete transparency.

Select a provider through a task-specific comparison: quality on representative data, latency, total cost per successful task, regional availability, data retention and use terms, security controls, support, and exit options. Do not memorize a “best model” ranking. Models and commercial terms change too quickly.

Vector search options include database extensions and dedicated vector search products. Orchestration frameworks such as LangChain/LangGraph or LlamaIndex can help organize retrieval and workflows, but add dependencies. Model Context Protocol, or MCP, is an integration protocol to understand at awareness level; it does not make tools safe or permission-correct automatically. The architect chooses tooling after requirements, not before.

AI opportunity worksheet and economics

Write one sentence: “[Role] performs [task] [volume] times per period, taking [time], with [failure cost]. We will test [approach] against [baseline], using [data], with [reviewer] responsible for exceptions.”

Illustrative example: 4,000 support cases monthly require six minutes each, or 400 hours. An assistant saves three minutes on 60% of cases. Gross time released is 120 hours. If review and exception handling consume 40 additional hours, net time released is 80 hours. At a $25 loaded hourly cost, capacity value is $2,000 monthly. With $800 additional monthly operating cost, modeled net value is $1,200 before implementation cost. A $12,000 implementation has a simple ten-month payback only if the assumptions hold. Capacity released is not cash saved unless staffing cost is actually avoided or capacity produces additional value.

Include model usage, retrieval, hosting, monitoring, QA, human review, support, and change costs. Measure cost per successfully completed task, not just cost per token.

Pilot design that can fail honestly

1. Select one process and name the owner.
2. Establish the current time, quality, and exception baseline.
3. Build a permitted, representative evaluation set with difficult and out-of-scope cases.
4. Define quality, critical-error, latency, cost, and escalation criteria before testing.
5. Compare a simple baseline, an AI approach, and a human-assisted option where appropriate.
6. Review performance by relevant case type, not only an overall average.
7. Decide to stop, revise, or expand. Record who made the decision and why.

Illustrative pilot thresholds might include 90% acceptable draft responses, no observed critical permission breaches in the test set, and at least 20% lower total handling time. Zero observed breaches does not prove zero future risk. Criteria must reflect the actual consequences and sample limitations.

Governance and security essentials

An AI risk register should identify the intended use, affected users, data classes, provider, model/version, permissions, known failure modes, evaluation results, owner, and rollback process. NIST offers a risk-management structure; it is not a product certification. [14]

Teach trainees to recognize prompt injection, sensitive-data disclosure, unsafe output handling, excessive action permissions, and resource abuse. Route these to security specialists. Treat retrieved documents and tool results as untrusted inputs. Use least-privilege tools, server-side authorization, logging, and approval for consequential actions. OWASP provides a focused risk reference. [15]

For voice agents, validate identity disclosure, consent and calling rules, recording rules, interruption handling, language/accent performance, human transfer, and cost per completed call. Do not allow a sales prototype to make medical, financial, or contractual commitments. The legal owner must approve market-specific use before live calls.

EU AI obligations depend on use case and the party's role. The Commission's current implementation material reflects staged obligations and amended timelines. Never promise “AI Act compliant” based only on a model choice. Obtain a use-case-specific review against current official guidance. [16]

5.10 Blockchain and Web3

What: A shared ledger system with rules for agreeing on records across participants. **Why and problem:** Multiple parties may need verifiable shared state without relying entirely on one operator. **Sell when:** Shared ownership, transfer, or verification requirements justify the added complexity. **Do not sell when:** One organization controls the data and a conventional database works. **Buyer:** Product head, consortium sponsor, or fintech lead. **Terms:** Smart contract, wallet, token, custody, gas fee, finality. **Questions:** Why must records be shared this way? Who controls keys? What must remain private? **Integrations:** Wallets, identity, payment rails, off-chain systems. **Team:** Blockchain engineer, backend engineer, security auditor, domain/legal experts. **Complexity:** High. **Model:** Feasibility, audited pilot, phased production. **Example and pitch:** “Compare shared-ledger verification against a conventional signed-record system.” **Objection:** “Do we need a token?” Usually that needs a separate business case. **Mistake:** Selling token appreciation or immutable personal data as benefits.

A smart contract is code executed under a blockchain's rules. A wallet manages credentials or keys used to authorize interactions. Tokens represent defined units or rights within a system; legal rights depend on actual arrangements. NFTs distinguish tokens but do not automatically transfer copyright. DeFi describes financial applications using blockchain-based components and carries significant financial, operational, and regulatory risk. Tokenization represents assets or claims digitally but does not settle custody, ownership, or enforceability by itself.

Web3 apps combine ordinary interfaces and backends with blockchain interactions. Blockchain payments require decisions about settlement, custody, conversion, reconciliation, and jurisdiction. Blockchain integrations must handle chain events and failures. Speculative NFT launches are a low-priority general-agency offer unless there is validated demand and specialist capability.

5.11 Internet of Things

What: Connected physical devices that collect data or control equipment. **Why and problem:** Operations lack timely visibility into physical assets. **Sell when:** Sensors, connectivity, installation, and maintenance are feasible. **Do not sell when:** The proposal covers a dashboard but ignores device deployment. **Buyer:** Operations, plant, fleet, or facility head. **Terms:** Sensor, gateway, telemetry, firmware, edge, connectivity. **Questions:** Where are devices? Who installs and repairs them? What happens offline? **Integrations:** Device platforms, maps, ERP, maintenance systems. **Team:** Embedded/device specialist, cloud/backend engineer, dashboard engineer, field support, QA/security. **Complexity:** High. **Model:** Site assessment, small pilot, staged rollout and support. **Example and pitch:** “Validate device reliability and useful alerts at one site before scaling.” **Objection:** “Can we guarantee real-time data everywhere?” Define network conditions and latency. **Mistake:** Excluding hardware and field service from total cost.

Sensors measure conditions. Devices collect or act. Gateways connect local devices to networks or cloud services. Connectivity may use cellular, Wi-Fi, wired networks, or specialist protocols. Device management covers identity, updates, health, and retirement. “Real-time” must be defined as an acceptable delay.

Examples include smart-city asset monitoring, logistics cold-chain alerts, manufacturing machine telemetry, healthcare equipment tracking, agriculture irrigation monitoring, and fleet location reporting. Clinical or safety-critical control introduces specialist requirements beyond ordinary dashboard development.

5.12 Data engineering and analytics

What: Make data usable and trustworthy across systems. **Why and problem:** Reports conflict, data arrives late, or decisions depend on manual consolidation. **Sell when:** A business owner can define useful metrics. **Do not sell when:** A new dashboard is expected to repair missing or incorrect source records. **Buyer:** Data head, CFO, COO. **Terms:** ETL, ELT, pipeline, lineage, warehouse, lake. **Questions:** Which decision? Which source is authoritative? How fresh must data be? **Integrations:** ERP, CRM, files, transactional databases. **Team:** Data engineer, analyst, domain owner, architect. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Data audit then pipeline and reporting project. **Example and pitch:** “Reconcile sales and fulfillment data before publishing a shared operating dashboard.” **Objection:** “Can you just connect the spreadsheet?” Inspect quality and ownership. **Mistake:** Selling charts without metric definitions.

ETL means extract, transform, then load. ELT loads first and transforms in the target environment. A pipeline moves and processes data. BI, or business intelligence, helps people analyze business performance. A warehouse structures analytical data; a lake stores varied data for different uses. Real-

time analytics processes data with low delay and typically costs more to operate than periodic reporting. Ask whether hourly or daily freshness is sufficient.

5.13 Cybersecurity

What: Reduce risks to confidentiality, integrity, and availability. **Why and problem:** Systems and data face misuse, loss, and interruption. **Sell when:** The scope and authorization are explicit and qualified specialists are available. **Do not sell when:** The agency lacks the expertise or permission to test. **Buyer:** CISO, CIO, IT/security head. **Terms:** Identity, access management, vulnerability, threat, penetration test, remediation. **Questions:** What assets and data? What authorized scope? Who fixes findings? **Integrations:** Identity, logging, cloud, code pipelines. **Team:** Security specialist and remediation owners. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Scoped assessment and remediation; ongoing service only with capacity. **Example and pitch:** “Identify and prioritize exposed application risks, then verify the fixes.” **Objection:** “Will this certify us?” Explain the engagement's limits. **Mistake:** Equating a scan with a penetration test or compliance certification.

Application security concerns software behavior. Cloud security includes configuration and operating controls. Identity and access management decide who can do what. Vulnerability assessment identifies potential weaknesses. Penetration testing explores exploitability within authorized scope. Compliance concerns satisfying applicable obligations and evidence requirements; it is not identical to security. Never promise that one test makes a system secure forever.

5.14 ERP and CRM

What: CRM organizes customer relationships; ERP coordinates core business records and operations. **Why and problem:** Fragmented customer, inventory, finance, and process data. **Sell when:** Process owners can standardize work and maintain data. **Do not sell when:** Every existing habit is to be reproduced through expensive customization. **Buyer:** Sales operations for CRM; COO/CFO/CIO for ERP. **Terms:** Configuration, customization, migration, workflow, master data. **Questions:** Which process? Which system of record? Who owns adoption? **Integrations:** Email, finance, inventory, eCommerce, identity. **Team:** Functional consultant, platform specialist, integration/data engineers, trainer, QA. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Model:** Fit-gap discovery, implementation, support. **Example and pitch:** “Standardize lead-to-order and migrate clean data before adding custom modules.” **Objection:** “The license includes everything.” Separate software licensing from implementation. **Mistake:** Promising a full ERP rollout after seeing only the sales module.

Platform	High-level positioning	Discovery focus
Salesforce	CRM platform and ecosystem	Actual edition, data model, automation, integration, administration capacity
HubSpot	Customer-facing marketing, sales, and service platform	Required hubs, workflows, contact/data limits, and adoption
Microsoft Dynamics	Family of business applications across CRM and ERP needs	Which specific product, Microsoft integrations, business process fit
Odoo	Suite of modular business applications	Edition, modules, local accounting needs, customization and support
SAP	Broad enterprise application ecosystem, including ERP	Product/version, implementation partner capability, change and migration scope

5.15 Application and sector vocabulary

Area	What it means commercially	First question
eCommerce	Sell and fulfill orders online	Is standard platform configuration enough?
SaaS	Operate software as a recurring service	How are customer organizations isolated, billed, supported, and retained?
Mobile apps	Mobile-first software using platform capabilities	Does the use case need offline work, push, camera, location, or app-store distribution?
Marketplaces	Connect multiple participant groups	Who supplies, buys, pays, resolves disputes, and bears payment risk?
Fintech	Technology supporting financial services	What regulated activity and funds/data flows are involved?
Healthtech	Technology supporting health-related workflows	Is this administration, clinical support, or a regulated medical function?
Edtech	Technology supporting learning and education operations	Who learns, who buys, and are children involved?
Proptech	Technology for property-related work	Which property lifecycle process is inefficient?
Logistics	Movement and coordination of goods	Which dispatch, visibility, or proof-of-delivery gap matters?
Martech	Marketing technology	Which audience, attribution, consent, or execution problem?
Legaltech	Technology for legal work	Which documents, confidentiality, privilege, and review controls?
Insurtech	Technology supporting insurance	Which underwriting, policy, or claims workflow and regulator?
Traveltech	Technology supporting booking and travel operations	Which inventory, supplier API, cancellation, and payment rules?
Govtech	Technology used in public services	Which procurement, accessibility, hosting, and security requirements?

These labels do not determine architecture. A healthtech appointment app and diagnostic system can have radically different obligations.

5.16 Priority map for 2026 learning

Classification	Learn or discuss	Commercial interpretation
Established	Web/mobile delivery, APIs, relational data, cloud, QA, identity, CRM/ERP	Core selling fluency for most agencies
Growing	Applied AI, evaluation, governance, data integration, modernization, reliability and cost optimization	Strong areas to investigate, subject to segment-specific proof and demand
Emerging	Bounded agents, multimodal workflows, agent interoperability, edge AI	Sell carefully scoped experiments before broad operating promises
Overhyped or low priority	Agents for every task, unnecessary multi-agent designs, token projects without a business case, Kubernetes for every app	Added complexity needs demonstrated value

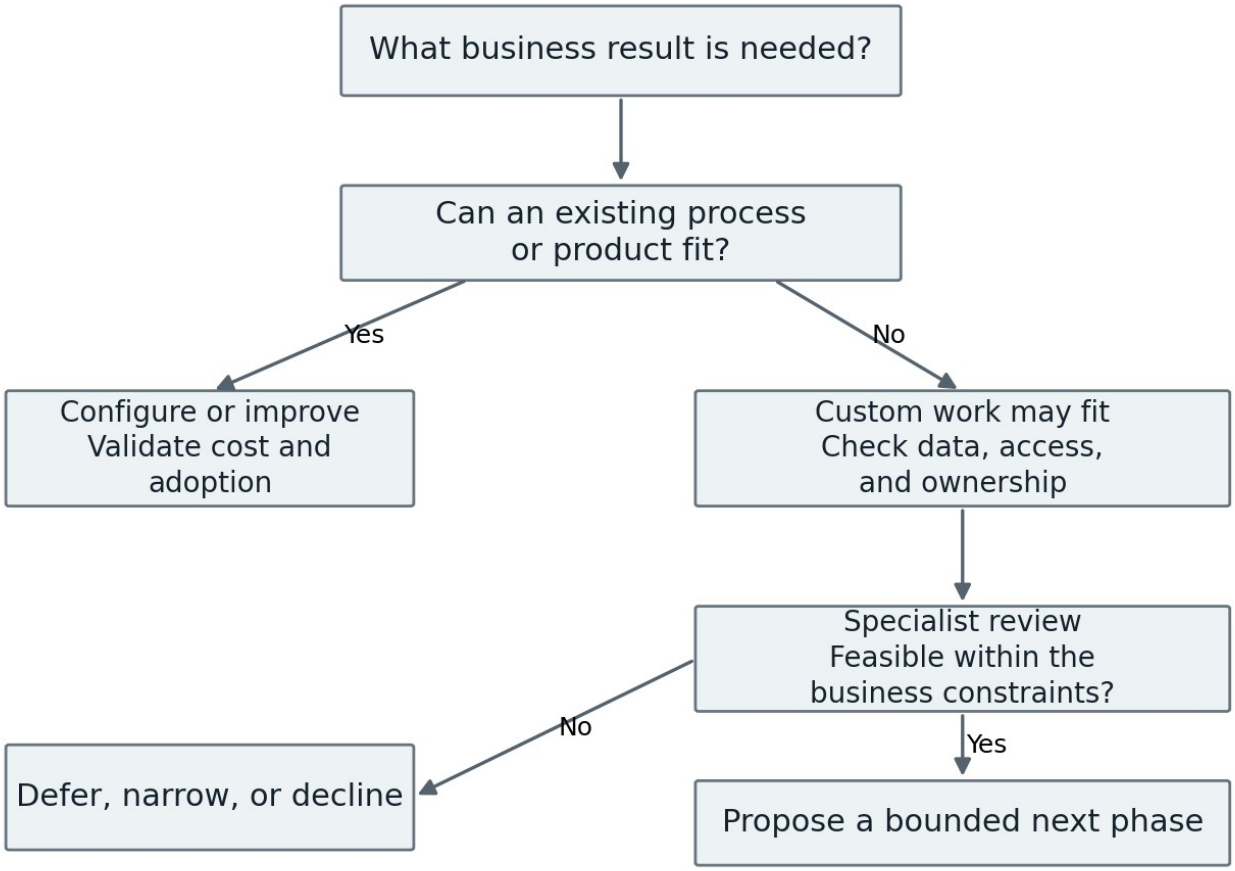
This is an editorial learning-priority judgment, not a measured market-share ranking. Stack Overflow's 2025 survey shows changes in developer usage, including Python growth, but self-selected survey data cannot forecast an agency's sales. Older frameworks and languages still create valuable installed-base work. Unsupported versions, weak proof, and low-value offers deserve more concern than a fashionable ranking. [3]

Technology assignment. Explain a customer portal to a nontechnical manager in two minutes. Then describe where data is stored, which systems connect, how access is restricted, and how changes are tested. Pass if the explanation is accurate and you explicitly reserve architecture decisions for the technical team.

6 Technology decision trees

6.1 Route a request before naming a stack

Each tree starts with a business request, then branches on a material constraint. Low complexity means limited workflows with known dependencies. Medium includes several roles or integrations. High includes major migration, uncertain devices, sensitive operations, or strong regulatory constraints. These are discussion labels, not estimates.



Web application

Problem: People need to complete work through a browser. **Decision:** If the need is mainly publishing content, assess CMS or a standard website. If a standard SaaS already meets the workflow, compare configure/buy with custom build. If unique rules or integrations create the value, bring in a product analyst and architect.

Discovery questions: Which users, roles, core journey, search visibility, devices, accessibility, integrations, and peak use? **Technology possibilities:** Existing platform, React/Next.js, Angular/Vue, backend API and relational database. **Delivery team:** Designer, frontend/backend, QA, PM. **Rough complexity:** Medium; high for many roles or real-time collaboration. **Risks:** Unclear rules and integration access. **Commercial model:** Paid discovery, then bounded build or T&M.

Mobile application

Problem: Users need access away from a desk. **Decision:** If browser access meets the need, consider responsive web or a PWA. If app distribution and device access are important, compare cross-platform with native. If deep hardware interaction or platform-specific behavior is critical, obtain a native specialist review.

Questions: iOS, Android, offline, push, camera, location, Bluetooth, device fleet, app-store ownership? **Possibilities:** Flutter, React Native, Ionic, Swift/Kotlin. **Team:** Mobile engineer, backend, designer, device QA. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Risks:** Sync conflicts, permissions, store review, device diversity. **Model:** Prototype/device feasibility, then phased build.

AI

Problem: A task involving language, images, speech, or prediction is costly. **Decision:** If rules solve it, use rules. If data or permission is missing, do a readiness assessment. If a supervised model can help, run a measured pilot. If actions must be autonomous, require tool controls, escalation, and security review.

Questions: Volume, baseline, error cost, data rights, evaluation set, reviewer, budget per task? **Possibilities:** Search, ML classifier, LLM API, RAG, bounded agent. **Team:** Domain owner, AI/backend, QA/evaluation, security. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Risks:** Wrong outputs, leakage, runaway cost. **Model:** Fixed-fee assessment and pilot before rollout.

Business process automation

Problem: Repeated manual work delays a process. **Decision:** Map the process first. If rules are stable and APIs exist, use workflow integration. If interfaces lack APIs, assess authorized RPA and its fragility. If inputs are unstructured, consider AI only for that step with review.

Questions: Trigger, inputs, decisions, exceptions, approvals, volume, system owner? **Possibilities:** Native platform workflows, integration platform, custom API workflow, RPA. **Team:** Analyst, integration engineer, process owner, QA. **Complexity:** Low to high. **Risks:** Automating a broken process, duplicate actions, hidden exceptions. **Model:** Process assessment, one-workflow pilot, staged automation.

Cloud migration

Problem: Hosting limits reliability, cost, supportability, or growth. **Decision:** If the application should be retired or replaced, do not migrate it automatically. For retained systems, compare rehost, replatform, or refactor. If downtime or data movement is difficult, prototype migration and rollback before quoting the cutover.

Questions: Inventory, dependencies, licenses, region, data volume, RTO/RPO, outages, operating owner? **Possibilities:** AWS, Azure, Google Cloud, simpler hosting where sufficient. **Team:** Cloud architect, application owner, data, security, DevOps, QA. **Complexity:** High for interconnected estates. **Risks:** Downtime, egress fees, hidden dependencies. **Model:** Assessment plus phased migration and optional operations.

SaaS product

Problem: A business wants repeatable software revenue. **Decision:** If the target user and willingness to pay are untested, start with interviews/prototype. If validated, define one paid workflow. If multiple organizations share the service, design tenant isolation, billing, support, and administrative controls explicitly.

Questions: ICP, paid use case, tenant model, subscriptions, roles, onboarding, retention, data export? **Possibilities:** Modular web app, managed services, billing/identity integrations. **Team:** Product, design, full-stack, QA, DevOps/security. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Risks:** Building too much, tenant data leakage, weak adoption. **Model:** Discovery, narrow MVP, ongoing squad.

CRM or ERP

Problem: Business records and processes are fragmented. **Decision:** If standard platform functions fit, configure. If gaps remain, quantify them before customizing. If data quality is poor, clean it before migration. If process owners disagree, resolve ownership before implementation.

Questions: Current process, modules, users, approvals, master data, integrations, reporting, training? **Possibilities:** Salesforce, HubSpot, Dynamics, Odoo, SAP or existing system improvement. **Team:** Functional consultant, platform specialist, data/integration, QA, trainer. **Complexity:** Medium to high. **Risks:** Scope expansion, unusable data, low adoption. **Model:** Fit-gap assessment, implementation milestones, support.

eCommerce

Problem: Sell and fulfill online. **Decision:** If standard catalog and checkout fit a platform, configure first. If B2B pricing, unusual checkout, or multi-party settlement is essential, validate platform limits. Custom build needs a clear reason.

Questions: Catalog, stock, currencies, taxes, payment methods, refunds, shipping, ERP/POS, traffic peaks? **Possibilities:** Hosted commerce, existing CMS commerce, headless or custom where justified. **Team:** Commerce specialist, designer, integration engineer, QA. **Complexity:** Low to high. **Risks:** Inventory mismatch, failed payments, fraud, operational readiness. **Model:** Discovery and launch project plus maintenance.

Blockchain

Problem: Parties need shared verification or transfer rules. **Decision:** If a trusted operator and conventional database suffice, recommend that. If distributed control is necessary, validate participants, governance, asset rights, and legal feasibility. Stop if the case depends only on token speculation.

Questions: Trust model, custody, private data, transactions, finality, fees, audit, jurisdiction? **Possibilities:** Signed records, permissioned ledger, public-chain integration. **Team:** Domain/legal, blockchain, backend, specialist security. **Complexity:** High. **Risks:** Irreversible actions, key loss, regulation, vulnerable contracts. **Model:** Feasibility and audited pilot with explicit limits.

IoT

Problem: Observe or manage physical assets. **Decision:** If existing devices provide data, validate access and reliability. If new hardware is required, test installation and connectivity. If safety-critical control is involved, bring in the appropriate domain and safety specialists before selling.

Questions: Device type, environment, power, coverage, latency, installation, maintenance, firmware updates? **Possibilities:** Existing IoT platform, gateways, edge processing, cloud and dashboards. **Team:** Device/embedded, field specialist, cloud/backend, QA/security. **Complexity:** High. **Risks:** Hardware failure, coverage gaps, unsupported devices. **Model:** Site pilot, staged rollout, service agreement.

Decision exercise. For each tree, identify one reason to recommend an existing product, one reason for custom work, and one fact that would stop the deal. The manager should reward a justified “do not build” recommendation.

7 Industry knowledge

7.1 Learn the workflow and the money

Industry fluency begins with how work moves, who pays, what can fail, and which records matter. Use the cards below to form hypotheses, not diagnose a prospect from its sector label. The opportunities are practical ideas to validate, not claims that every company currently wants them.

For every sector, ask the operating team to walk through a recent real transaction. Identify the trigger, handoffs, systems, exceptions, approvals, and final result. This reveals more than asking, “Do you need an app?”

7.2 Healthcare

Basics and buyers: Providers deliver care while administrators coordinate appointments, records, billing, and patient communication. Buyers include practice owners, operations heads, CIOs, and clinical leaders. **Business and technology problems:** Administrative burden, missed handoffs, fragmented records, weak interoperability. **Typical software and integrations:** EHR, scheduling, patient portals, billing; identity, labs, payment and HL7/FHIR interfaces where available.

Opportunity and concerns: Patient intake or administrative portals can help, but health data, access, audit, consent, and jurisdiction matter. HIPAA applicability depends on entity, activity, and data, not the word “healthcare.” Relevant business-associate arrangements must be reviewed. [17] **Discovery:** What data will the portal hold? Which EHR supports access? Who validates workflow safety? **Pitch:** “Start with intake and appointment communication, with the data and integration boundaries approved first.”

7.3 Fintech

Basics and buyers: Technology supports payments, lending, investments, or related financial activity. Founders, product heads, compliance, and CTOs participate. **Problems:** Failed transactions, slow onboarding, reconciliation gaps, fraud, disconnected providers. **Software and integrations:** Payment orchestration, onboarding, ledgers, risk tools; banking, identity/KYC providers, payment gateways.

Opportunity and concerns: Reconciliation automation and controlled operational dashboards may be valuable. Funds flow, licensing, payment security, AML/KYC, and data obligations need specialist review. **Discovery:** Who holds funds? Which party is regulated? What happens on a duplicated or reversed transaction? **Pitch:** “Map the transaction and reconciliation flow before selecting the integration design.” Do not equate a payment API integration with permission to operate a financial business.

7.4 Banking

Basics and buyers: Banks manage deposits, lending, payments, and risk under substantial oversight. Buyers include CIOs, business heads, enterprise architects, and vendor-risk teams. **Problems:** Legacy dependencies, slow releases, complex approvals, inconsistent data. **Software and integrations:** Core banking, customer channels, risk and reporting; identity, payment rails, enterprise messaging.

Opportunity and concerns: Peripheral workflow modernization can be more feasible than replacing the core. Security, resilience, audit, third-party risk, and jurisdiction-specific outsourcing rules matter. **Discovery:** Which system is authoritative? What change windows and vendor gates apply? **Pitch:** “Assess one bounded customer-service workflow and its integration risk before proposing broader modernization.” Enterprise readiness and reference requirements may disqualify a young agency from direct core-system work.

7.5 Insurance

Basics and buyers: Insurers price risk, issue policies, collect premiums, and process claims. Buyers include claims operations, CIOs, underwriting, and digital product teams. **Problems:** Document-heavy claims, duplicate entry, fragmented policy data, slow status updates. **Software and integrations:** Policy administration, claims systems, document management, broker portals; identity, payments, external data.

Opportunity and concerns: Supervised document extraction and claims status workflows. Privacy, auditability, fairness, retention, and decision authority require care. **Discovery:** Which claim stages need human judgment? What error could wrongly affect a claimant? **Pitch:** “Reduce document preparation effort while retaining authorized review for claims decisions.” Avoid promising autonomous coverage or payout decisions from a simple AI pilot.

7.6 Real estate

Basics and buyers: Property firms acquire, market, lease, sell, or manage assets. Buyers include owners, sales heads, property operations, and IT. **Problems:** Lead leakage, repeated listing updates, maintenance coordination, scattered documents. **Software and integrations:** CRM, listing portals, property management, tenant apps; listing feeds, payments, calendars, accounting.

Opportunity and concerns: Lead-to-viewing automation or tenant-service workflows. Personal data, location details, tenancy records, and local transaction rules matter. **Discovery:** Where do leads enter? Which system owns listing availability? Who follows up? **Pitch:** “Connect inquiry capture to viewing and follow-up so the team can see where opportunities stall.” A new website will not fix unowned lead response.

7.7 Construction

Basics and buyers: Projects coordinate contractors, site activity, materials, cost, and compliance evidence. Buyers include contractors, project directors, operations, and finance. **Problems:** Delayed field reports, missing evidence, change-order disputes, disconnected job costing. **Software and integrations:** Field reporting, project management, document control; accounting, scheduling, maps, storage.

Opportunity and concerns: Offline site reports with photo evidence and approval workflows. Worker data, access, contractual records, and site safety context matter. **Discovery:** What happens without connectivity? Who signs off quantities and changes? **Pitch:** “Capture site evidence once and connect approved reports to project and billing workflows.” Do not promise a reporting app replaces engineering or safety approval.

7.8 Manufacturing

Basics and buyers: Plants transform materials into products while managing quality, capacity, and downtime. Buyers include plant heads, operations, quality, and IT/OT teams. **Problems:** Manual production logs, unplanned stops, quality traceability gaps. **Software and integrations:** ERP, MES, maintenance, quality systems; machine data, scanners, PLC/SCADA interfaces where authorized.

Opportunity and concerns: Production visibility or digital quality checks at one line. Operational technology segmentation, safety, access, and downtime constraints matter. **Discovery:** Which machines expose data safely? What is the cost of a stopped line? **Pitch:** “Pilot visibility on one production line without disturbing machine control.” Never estimate a factory rollout from a dashboard mockup alone.

7.9 Logistics

Basics and buyers: Operators move goods through dispatch, transit, and delivery. Buyers include fleet owners, dispatch heads, COO, and IT. **Problems:** Late status updates, driver calls, missing proof of delivery, billing delays. **Software and integrations:** TMS, dispatch, driver apps, tracking; GPS/telematics, maps, customer systems, accounting.

Opportunity and concerns: Driver workflow and exception alerts. Location privacy, device access, offline operation, and data accuracy matter. **Discovery:** Do vehicles already have tracking devices? Which exceptions require action? **Pitch:** “Connect delivery evidence and exceptions to dispatch so the team can act without repeated calls.” Tracking dots alone may not improve operations.

7.10 Supply chain

Basics and buyers: Coordinate suppliers, purchasing, inventory, and fulfillment across organizations. Buyers include supply-chain heads, procurement, operations, and CFOs. **Problems:** Stock uncertainty, supplier delays, poor forecasts, inconsistent item records. **Software and integrations:** ERP, WMS, supplier portals, planning tools; EDI, carrier, procurement, and inventory systems.

Opportunity and concerns: Supplier visibility or inventory-data reconciliation. Commercial confidentiality, partner access, and source-data ownership matter. **Discovery:** Which inventory number is trusted? How are exceptions escalated? **Pitch:** “Create a shared view of purchase and stock exceptions with clear ownership.” Forecasting should follow data validation, not substitute for it.

7.11 Retail

Basics and buyers: Stores sell inventory and serve customers across physical and digital channels. Buyers include owners, retail operations, merchandising, and IT. **Problems:** Stock mismatch, disconnected customer data, slow replenishment, inconsistent reporting. **Software and integrations:** POS, inventory, loyalty, workforce, analytics; accounting, eCommerce, payments.

Opportunity and concerns: Store-to-online inventory sync or operating dashboards. Payment security, customer privacy, refunds, and store downtime matter. **Discovery:** How quickly must stock update? What happens during connectivity loss? **Pitch:** “Reduce stock discrepancies between stores and online channels with reconciliation and exception handling.” Integration is often more valuable than replacing every system.

7.12 eCommerce

Basics and buyers: Online sellers acquire customers, convert orders, fulfill, and manage returns. Buyers include founders, eCommerce heads, operations, and marketing. **Problems:** Checkout friction, failed orders, fulfillment gaps, poor catalog quality. **Software and integrations:** Commerce platform, PIM, order management; gateways, shipping, ERP, CRM, analytics.

Opportunity and concerns: Checkout diagnosis, order workflow automation, integration repair. Payment scope, privacy, fraud, tax, and accessibility need review. **Discovery:** Where does conversion drop? Are abandoned checkouts caused by UX, payment failure, or shipping cost? **Pitch:** “Diagnose the highest-loss checkout step before proposing a redesign.” Do not promise a conversion uplift without baseline and measurement design.

7.13 Education

Basics and buyers: Institutions and training businesses deliver learning and manage learners. Buyers include institution leaders, academic operations, product heads, and IT. **Problems:** Disconnected enrollment, scheduling, assessment, and learner support. **Software and integrations:** LMS, student information, assessment tools; identity, payments, video, content systems.

Opportunity and concerns: Enrollment workflow or learner-support tools. Student privacy, minors, accessibility, content rights, and assessment integrity matter. **Discovery:** Who is the learner and who pays? What can an automated assistant answer? **Pitch:** “Reduce enrollment administration and make the next learner action clear.” Clinical or high-stakes certification assessments require more control than general course content.

7.14 SaaS businesses

Basics and buyers: Sell ongoing access to software and depend on adoption, retention, and expansion. Buyers include founders, CTOs, product and engineering leaders. **Problems:** Backlog, onboarding friction, reliability, integration demand, technical debt. **Software and integrations:** The product itself, billing, support, analytics; SSO, CRM, payment, data tools.

Opportunity and concerns: A narrow product squad, quality improvement, or enterprise readiness. Tenant isolation, contracts, uptime commitments, data export, and usage economics matter. **Discovery:** Which roadmap item blocks adoption or a real sale? **Pitch:** “Address the specific integration or reliability gap that is delaying customer value.” Distinguish a prospect's requested feature from a validated market need.

7.15 Media

Basics and buyers: Create, manage, distribute, and monetize content. Buyers include publishers, product heads, content operations, and technology leaders. **Problems:** Fragmented content workflows, slow publishing, rights confusion, poor distribution. **Software and integrations:** CMS, digital asset management, streaming, subscriptions; ad platforms, CDN, identity, payments.

Opportunity and concerns: Editorial workflow automation or content operations search. Copyright, permissions, provenance, audience privacy, and moderation matter. **Discovery:** Who owns rights for each content type? Which review must remain human? **Pitch:** “Reduce publishing handoffs while preserving editorial approval and rights checks.” AI-generated content does not eliminate rights or accuracy review.

7.16 Travel

Basics and buyers: Sell and coordinate bookings across suppliers. Buyers include travel operators, product, reservations, and IT. **Problems:** Fragmented inventory, booking failures, slow changes, manual reconciliation. **Software and integrations:** Booking engines, reservation systems, traveler portals; supplier APIs, GDS where relevant, payments, messaging.

Opportunity and concerns: Booking-management workflows or exception handling. Personal and travel-document data, payment, cancellation, and supplier terms matter. **Discovery:** Is inventory live? What happens if payment succeeds but supplier confirmation fails? **Pitch:** “Design booking and refund reconciliation around real supplier failure cases.” A search screen is only a small part of a booking system.

7.17 Hospitality

Basics and buyers: Hotels and hospitality operators manage rooms, guests, services, and occupancy. Buyers include owners, general managers, operations, and IT. **Problems:** Repeated guest requests, fragmented property data, manual staff coordination. **Software and integrations:** Property management, reservations, POS, guest apps; channel managers, payments, messaging.

Opportunity and concerns: Staff task management or bounded guest-service assistance. Guest privacy, identity information, multilingual accuracy, and after-hours escalation matter. **Discovery:** Which requests need a staff member? What systems can confirm availability? **Pitch:** “Route guest requests to the right staff with status tracking and escalation.” Do not let an AI assistant invent room availability or pricing.

7.18 Automotive

Basics and buyers: Includes manufacturers, dealers, workshops, fleets, and parts businesses. Buyers vary by segment: operations, service, product, engineering, or IT. **Problems:** Service scheduling, parts visibility, dealer data, inspection records. **Software and integrations:** Dealer management, workshop systems, connected services; inventory, diagnostic systems, telematics, finance.

Opportunity and concerns: Service workflow or inspection evidence. Vehicle/customer data, safety boundaries, device access, and ownership matter. **Discovery:** Is the system administrative or controlling vehicle behavior? **Pitch:** “Improve the service booking and inspection handoff while preserving the existing dealer system.” Vehicle control and safety-related software require specialist assurance beyond ordinary app development.

7.19 Agriculture

Basics and buyers: Farms and agribusinesses manage land, inputs, equipment, labor, yield, and selling. Buyers include farm owners, cooperatives, agribusiness operations, and product firms. **Problems:** Scattered records, poor stock visibility, missed tasks, weak cost tracking. **Software and integrations:** Farm management, field records, finance, equipment dashboards; weather, maps, sensors, accounting.

Opportunity and concerns: Offline field task and resource tracking. Connectivity, shared devices, location data, seasonal timing, and data ownership matter. **Discovery:** Who enters records and when? Does the workflow work without mobile coverage? **Pitch:** “Start with field tasks and input records that the team can maintain during the season.” Avoid yield promises without agronomic evidence.

7.20 Government

Basics and buyers: Agencies deliver public services under public accountability and procurement rules. Buyers include program owners, CIOs, procurement, and security teams. **Problems:** Paper workflows, inaccessible services, legacy records, slow case handling. **Software and integrations:** Citizen portals, case management, records; identity, payments, registries, inter-agency systems.

Opportunity and concerns: A bounded service workflow or modernization subcontract. Tender eligibility, accessibility, retention, public records, hosting, and security obligations matter. **Discovery:** What procurement route and accreditation are required? **Pitch:** “Map one citizen-service journey and the evidence needed for procurement and delivery.” A good conversation is not permission to bypass a tender process.

7.21 Legal

Basics and buyers: Legal teams manage matters, documents, deadlines, and advice. Buyers include partners, legal operations, general counsel, and IT. **Problems:** Document search, repeated intake, manual matter updates, billing friction. **Software and integrations:** Matter management, document systems, time/billing; email, identity, finance, e-signature.

Opportunity and concerns: Matter intake or permission-aware search with attorney review. Confidentiality, privilege, access, retention, and source accuracy matter. **Discovery:** Which documents may be accessed by each matter team? Who checks output? **Pitch:** “Reduce document-finding time while preserving matter-level permissions and legal review.” Do not sell automated legal conclusions as ordinary chatbot output.

7.22 Professional services

Basics and buyers: Consultancies, agencies, and advisory firms sell expertise and delivery capacity. Buyers include founders, partners, COO, and finance. **Problems:** Fragmented sales-to-delivery handoffs, resource planning, timesheets, billing, knowledge access. **Software and integrations:** CRM, PSA, projects, finance, knowledge systems; calendar, documents, accounting.

Opportunity and concerns: A connected proposal-to-project workflow or internal knowledge assistant. Client confidentiality, contractual access, utilization economics, and data ownership matter. **Discovery:** Where is work re-entered? Which handoff delays billing? **Pitch:** “Connect signed scope, staffing, and billing records so project teams start with the same information.” Avoid assuming every small firm needs a custom platform.

7.23 Geographic selling without stereotypes

US and Canadian buyers are not interchangeable, especially for outreach rules. UK and European requirements vary by country and recipient type. The Middle East is not one jurisdiction: distinguish the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and other markets, then check hosting, procurement, and language needs. Australia has its own outreach and privacy rules. India-based delivery teams must also plan time-zone overlap, local holidays, tax/payment handling, and cross-border data access.

For every deal record buyer location, contracting entity, end-user locations, data locations, invoicing currency, working overlap, and required local partners. Never infer preferences from nationality. Ask about the buyer's actual operating needs.

Industry assignment. Choose two sectors the agency can credibly serve. For each, map one workflow, five buyer terms, three integrations, two risk issues, and one approved proof asset. Pass when a domain colleague confirms the workflow and no unverified regulatory promise appears.

8 ICP and buyer personas

8.1 Account fit versus person fit

An ideal customer profile describes organizations worth pursuing. A buyer persona describes a role within those organizations. A 70-person distributor may fit the ICP; its finance manager, operations head, and IT manager have different priorities. Finding a CTO's email does not establish account fit.

Build the ICP from profitable delivery and real wins, not only the founder's preferred industry. Include company type, region, operating problem, relevant systems, trigger, buying capacity, proof fit, and exclusions. Employee count is a rough filter, not a budget estimate.

Illustrative ICP	Positive conditions	Trigger and suitable first offer	Exclusions
Startup	Funded or revenue-backed founder, specific user, clear product owner	Validated demand but unclear scope; paid discovery and narrow MVP	No user evidence, no financing path, equity-only proposal outside policy
SMB	Recurring operating workflow, reachable owner, clear business impact	Spreadsheet handoffs break as volume grows; workflow assessment	Standard SaaS fully solves the need and buyer refuses to consider it
Mid-market	Multiple teams, integration gaps, meaningful sponsor	Expansion, acquisition, release bottleneck; integration or modernization diagnostic	No system access or no owner across departments
Enterprise	Defined program, sponsor, procurement route, agency meets requirements	Legacy migration or specialist capacity; bounded work package	Mandatory credentials, insurance, security, or references the agency lacks

8.2 Persona field guide

Persona	Cares about and fears	Trigger and language	Objection and proof	KPI
Founder	Speed to learning, runway; fears building the wrong thing	Launch or customer demand; “What is the smallest useful release?”	“Too expensive”; scope options and relevant prototype	Activation, revenue, runway
CEO	Growth and operating results; fears disruption and wasted investment	Strategy change; “What changes for the business?”	“Why now?”; business case and accountable owner	Growth, profitability, risk
CTO	Architecture and team effectiveness; fears brittle systems	Scale or delivery bottleneck; “How does this fit our stack?”	“We can build it”; technical plan and capable people	Delivery flow, reliability, technical risk

Persona	Cares about and fears	Trigger and language	Objection and proof	KPI
CIO	Portfolio, governance, service continuity; fears uncontrolled vendors	Modernization or audit; “How will this operate?”	“Vendor risk”; controls, transition, support evidence	Service quality, spend, risk
COO	Process throughput; fears failed handoffs	Operational growth; “Where is work stuck?”	“Staff won't adopt it”; workflow proof and rollout plan	Cycle time, error rate, capacity
CMO	Pipeline, conversion, campaign execution; fears poor attribution	Channel or launch change; “Will users convert?”	“Can you prove uplift?”; measurement plan, credible UX evidence	Qualified demand, conversion, acquisition cost
Product Manager	User outcomes and priorities; fears scope chaos	Roadmap commitment; “Which user problem?”	“Too much coordination”; discovery and backlog discipline	Adoption, retention, time to value
Engineering Manager	Team capacity and quality; fears weak hires and review burden	Backlog or hiring gap; “How quickly can they contribute?”	“Onboarding slows us”; skills validation and transition plan	Cycle time, escaped defects, team load
IT Manager	Operability and support; fears access chaos	Support pressure; “Who maintains this?”	“Another system to own”; runbooks and operating responsibilities	Incidents, ticket load, recovery
Procurement	Fair terms and supplier reliability; fears unmanaged liability	Approved buying process; “Is scope comparable?”	“Rate too high”; transparent scope and commercial terms	Spend, terms, supplier performance
Operations Head	Daily execution and visibility; fears unusable workflows	Manual work or missed commitments; “Can my team use it?”	“We tried this before”; user testing and phased adoption	Throughput, rework, turnaround

8.3 Map the buying group

Identify the user, champion, economic buyer, technical evaluator, security/legal reviewer, procurement owner, and signer. One person may hold several roles. A champion actively helps you navigate the organization and build the case; friendliness alone does not establish a champion.

Ask: “Who else needs to be comfortable before this can move forward?” Then: “What would each person need to see?” Record evidence, not just names. Access to the CEO does not bypass security or procurement.

Exercise. Map a patient-portal purchase across operations, clinical, IT/security, finance, and procurement. Write one value statement for each. Pass when the statements use each role's priorities and do not repeat the same pitch five times.

9 Lead generation

9.1 Earn the right to scale

Lead generation starts after foundations, technology fluency, and message review. A trainee may research and roleplay before passing; that is not permission for mass outreach. Begin with a small, manager-reviewed campaign in one ICP and one offer. Expand only when fit, message relevance, deliverability, and opportunity quality are credible.

Gartner's 2025 release reports that many surveyed B2B buyers prefer self-service for general information, while seeking seller input for contextual fit. Irrelevant outreach can actively damage supplier consideration. This supports useful, specific contact rather than sending a capability brochure to everyone. [5]

9.2 Channels and how to use them

Channel	Practical execution	Common failure
Inbound	Respond with context, qualify the problem, route quickly	Treating every form fill as sales-ready
Outbound	Select accounts, verify a trigger, test one relevant hypothesis	Broad lists and invented personalization
Referral	Ask a satisfied contact for a specific relevant introduction	Asking for “anyone who needs software”
Partnerships	Define complementary services, ownership, and referral terms	Conflicts over client ownership or unsupported promises
LinkedIn	Research roles, contribute useful material, send selective manual messages	Unauthorized automation and generic connection pitches
Email	Short, relevant message with legitimate basis and clear opt-out	Deceptive subjects, volume-first sending, repeated unwanted follow-ups
Cold calling	Check market rules, call a relevant role, ask permission for a short reason	Long monologue or ignoring a refusal
Events	Select target conversations and follow up on actual discussion	Collecting badges without a business reason
Communities	Answer useful questions within community rules	Disguised promotion and harvesting members
Upwork or similar platforms	Select suitable briefs, diagnose scope, follow platform rules	Bidding on everything or bypassing platform requirements
SEO	Publish helpful material tied to real buyer questions	Broad traffic with no fit or evidence

Channel	Practical execution	Common failure
Content	Explain trade-offs, show methods, use permission-cleared cases	Unsupported claims and superficial AI-generated posts
Account-based marketing	Coordinate content and conversations around a few valuable accounts	Multiple employees contacting the same buyer independently
Channel partnerships	Work through a reseller, integrator, or platform partner with clear terms	No delivery boundary, margin plan, or conflict process

9.3 Tool roles

Sales Navigator supports account and role research. Apollo supplies company/contact data that must be verified. Clay can orchestrate enrichment and research workflows. Instantly and Smartlead support email campaign operations. HubSpot and Pipedrive organize relationships, stages, and follow-ups. Google and company databases help find evidence. Intent data may indicate topic interest at an account or aggregate level; it does not prove that a named person has budget or purchase intent.

Product features and plans change. Verify the current vendor documentation before procurement or integration. The recommended stack and official product references are in Chapter 20.

9.4 Outreach rules by market

This is an operational screening guide, not a complete legal review. Management should approve a country-and-channel playbook before campaigns. Applicable rules may depend on recipient location, sender location, recipient type, data source, and channel. Calling, texts, social messages, and recordings may have different rules from email.

Market	Rule to build into the campaign process
United States	CAN-SPAM applies to commercial B2B email too. Use accurate identity and subjects, clear commercial identification, a valid postal address, working opt-out, and timely suppression. Other privacy and calling rules may also apply. [18]
Canada	CASL generally requires consent or a valid applicable basis/exception for commercial electronic messages, plus identification and unsubscribe requirements. A publicly visible email is not blanket permission. Retain evidence. [19]
United Kingdom	PECR distinguishes corporate subscribers from individuals such as sole traders. Named business contacts still raise data-protection duties. Apply the correct recipient classification and suppression process. [20]
European countries	Assess GDPR and local electronic-marketing law together. Legitimate interest for data processing is not automatic permission for unsolicited email. Obtain country-specific review.
Australia	Commercial messages require an appropriate consent basis, sender identification, and functional unsubscribe under the applicable spam rules. Do not assume B2B is exempt. [21]

Market	Rule to build into the campaign process
Middle East	Identify the actual jurisdiction, such as UAE or Saudi Arabia, and verify privacy, electronic marketing, telecom, and data-transfer requirements. There is no single regional exemption.

Do not upload whole customer lists to AI or enrichment services without approved data handling. Apply least access, retention limits, and suppression lists. If someone declines, stop the sequence. Suppression records prevent future contact; deleting all evidence of an opt-out can cause accidental recontact.

Google's sender guidance requires authentication and places additional requirements on bulk senders to personal Gmail accounts. Operationally, configure SPF, DKIM, and DMARC appropriately, monitor complaints and bounces, and make opting out easy. Authentication improves trust in message origin; it does not make an unwanted message appropriate or guarantee inbox placement. [7]

9.5 What not to automate

Do not automate final fit decisions, unsupported pain claims, technical promises, price approvals, sensitive replies, or sending after opt-out. Do not create fake engagement, deceptive reply threads, or mailbox networks to evade restrictions. LinkedIn prohibits unauthorized tools that scrape or automate activity on its site. Use approved functionality and current platform rules. [22]

Appropriate automation includes deduplication, formatting, approved field enrichment, internal reminders, suppression checks, and draft preparation with review. Every external fact generated by AI needs verification before use.

Campaign gate. Manager approves ICP, evidence sample, message, market/channel basis, sender configuration, suppression handling, and success measure. Evaluate held meetings and qualified opportunities, not open rates alone. Privacy features and security scanners can make email opens and clicks misleading.

10 Lead research

10.1 A repeatable twenty minute process

Use a time budget. Spend more only when account value and evidence justify it. Research should produce a testable reason to talk, not a dossier with irrelevant personal details.

1. **Minutes 0 to 3:** Read the official homepage, product/service pages, and customer description. Write how the company earns revenue and whom it serves.

2. **Minutes 3 to 6:** Identify locations, approximate size, leadership, and the likely process owner. Record dates and sources. Separate official facts from directory estimates.

3. **Minutes 6 to 10:** Review recent official announcements, hiring pages, public product updates, and investor announcements. Verify any claimed funding event from primary evidence.

4. **Minutes 10 to 14:** Examine the user journey, public integrations, technical documentation, and relevant jobs. A job mentioning React is evidence of a hiring requirement, not proof of the entire stack.

5. **Minutes 14 to 17:** Compare two relevant competitors and identify a possible operating or product gap. Do not claim internal pain from external appearance alone.

6. **Minutes 17 to 20:** Write one hypothesis, one relevant proof asset, one question, and a pursue/defer decision. Save the source URL, access date, and confidence for each material claim.

10.2 Evidence hierarchy

An official announcement is stronger evidence of a funding event than an unverified database entry. A technical job description suggests skills being sought, not confirmed deployed architecture. Website inspection tools provide clues, not a full backend inventory. Anonymous reviews can suggest questions but are not established facts. Hiring may mean growth, replacement, or planned work, not necessarily outsourcing demand.

Label entries **confirmed**, **inferred**, or **unknown**. A useful inference is explicit: “Three integration-engineer vacancies may indicate increased integration work; ask whether external support is useful.” A bad claim is: “Your team is struggling because you cannot hire.”

10.3 Completed sample research sheet

Fictional training account: **HarborRoute Logistics**. No real funding, employee, or technology claims are implied.

Field	Training entry
Business model	Regional delivery operator paid per route and delivery contract
ICP fit	Potential fit for field reporting and delivery workflow integration
Website and product	Public site describes customer delivery-status access; trainee must record an actual URL in live work
Size and leadership	60 to 90 employees in a directory estimate; operations director listed officially; estimate needs confirmation

Field	Training entry
Funding	Unknown; do not infer from growth language
Hiring	Fictional careers page lists dispatcher and integration roles
Technology	Existing telematics vendor mentioned in a fictional integration page; backend stack unknown
Competitors	Two regional operators offering delivery-status portals; not evidence HarborRoute lacks one
Growth signal	Fictional announcement of a new depot
Pain hypothesis	More routes may increase status calls and reconciliation workload
Buying trigger	New depot and workflow rollout, timing unconfirmed
Persona	Operations director as likely problem owner; IT as evaluator
Relevant proof	Approved delivery-reporting case, if the agency has one
Opening question	“How are status exceptions handled across the new depot and your existing dispatch system?”
Next action	Verify contact role and market outreach rules, then send a reviewed note

10.4 Research quality test

Reject a research sheet with no sources, invented emails, unsupported funding, or a technology claim copied from AI. A valid work email can still be the wrong person. Record how identity and role were verified, then verify contact details through approved means. “Verified email” means a technical validation result, not permission to contact.

Assignment. Research five real accounts. For each, provide five sourced facts, two labeled hypotheses, one relevant buyer, one fit reason, and one reason to disqualify. Pass with no fabricated data and at least four defensible pursue/defer decisions.

11 Outreach and complete sequences

11.1 Write about a problem the buyer can recognize

Service-first: “We are a leading company offering React, AI, blockchain, cloud, and mobile development. Please share your requirements.” This asks the buyer to perform the diagnosis.

Problem-first: “Your rollout announcement mentions three new service regions. How will field teams submit completion evidence when connectivity is poor?” This is useful only when the announcement is real and the question fits the business.

A good message contains a verified observation, a cautious problem hypothesis, a relevant reason you might help, and one small next step. Use actual proof or omit the claim. Never invent results, shared connections, case studies, or previous conversations.

11.2 Sequence rules and common footer

The eight sequences below are complete first-contact, follow-up, and close-the-loop paths. Use day 1, day 4, and day 9 as an illustrative cadence in the recipient's working week, not a universal best practice. Stop on reply, refusal, unsubscribe, wrong-person notice, or evidence that contact is inappropriate. For a “later” reply, agree a date or trigger instead of continuing the sequence.

Replace every bracket with verified context. If a trigger is absent, ask a neutral question rather than inventing one. Each email must include the sender's real name, agency, valid postal address, and the approved market-specific commercial/opt-out wording. A sample plain footer is: “Business introduction from [Agency], [postal address]. If this is not relevant, reply ‘no’ and I will stop contacting you.” Use an unsubscribe mechanism where required by the campaign and provider rules. This footer does not replace consent where consent is required.

Sequence 1 Software development

Day 1. Subject: [Workflow] at [Company]

Hi [Name], your [verified announcement] mentions [operating change]. Does [workflow] still involve re-entering information between [known systems], or is that already connected? We help with [approved relevant capability]. If this is an active issue, would a short workflow discussion be useful?

Day 4. Subject: Re: [Workflow] at [Company]

One question worth testing is where exceptions go when a handoff fails. We could start by mapping that step and comparing integration with a custom portal. Is there a person who owns this process?

Day 9. Subject: Closing the loop on [workflow]

I will leave this here. If the workflow is already working well, no action is needed. If it becomes a priority, I can share the questions we use to assess scope before quoting a build.

Sequence 2 AI services

Day 1. Subject: [Task] review effort

Hi [Name], I saw [verified process or initiative]. Is the main burden in [task] reading information, drafting a response, or reviewing exceptions? We assess whether a supervised AI workflow can reduce total handling effort. The first step is a baseline and a test set, not a production commitment. Is this on your team's agenda?

Day 4. Subject: Re: [Task] review effort

For this type of work, the important measure is time after human review and corrections. If your team has a few approved examples, a scoping conversation could establish whether a pilot is worth considering.

Day 9. Subject: [Task] next steps

I will pause here. If you revisit this, the useful starting points are task volume, unacceptable errors, and who would own exceptions. Happy to discuss those when there is an active need.

Sequence 3 Dedicated developers

Day 1. Subject: Capacity for [specific roadmap area]

Hi [Name], your careers page lists [verified role]. Are you looking only for permanent hires, or would temporary capacity for [relevant work] help while hiring? We can discuss [verified skill availability] with technical validation and defined overlap hours. I would first want to understand how your team assigns and reviews work.

Day 4. Subject: Re: Capacity for [area]

A useful comparison is time to productive contribution, including onboarding and review effort. If temporary support is relevant, we can agree a skills check and an initial bounded work package before discussing a longer allocation.

Day 9. Subject: [Area] hiring plan

I will close this out for now. If your plan is permanent hiring only, that is useful to know. If a short-term delivery gap appears later, we can revisit it against actual capacity.

Sequence 4 QA services

Day 1. Subject: Release checks for [product]

Hi [Name], [verified release signal] caught my attention. How does the team currently check [relevant critical journey] before a release? We help teams assess regression coverage and automate stable, high-risk paths. Is release checking a bottleneck, or is it already working well?

Day 4. Subject: Re: Release checks for [product]

We would start with the failures you most want to prevent, then review environments and test data. That avoids building a large suite that becomes expensive to maintain. Would a short test-scope discussion be useful?

Day 9. Subject: QA priorities

I will leave this with you. If regression time or escaped defects become a priority, the first step can be a review of the critical journeys rather than a commitment to replace your current testing approach.

Sequence 5 Cloud and DevOps

Day 1. Subject: [Deployment or infrastructure initiative]

Hi [Name], your [verified update] mentions [migration or rollout]. Is the main challenge deployment consistency, recovery, or operating cost? We assess those against the current workload before recommending changes. Would it help to compare the main risks in a short call?

Day 4. Subject: Re: [Initiative]

One early question is whether recovery has been tested under the conditions the business expects. If that is already covered, we can focus elsewhere. Who owns the deployment and recovery process?

Day 9. Subject: Infrastructure discussion

I will pause the outreach. If this becomes active, we can start with a bounded assessment of dependencies and operating responsibilities, then decide whether a migration or smaller improvement makes sense.

Sequence 6 UI and UX

Day 1. Subject: [Specific user journey]

Hi [Name], I reviewed the public [journey] on [product]. I noticed [factual observation, not a guessed conversion problem]. Do you have evidence that users get stuck at this step? We can help test the journey with representative users before redesigning it.

Day 4. Subject: Re: [User journey]

The useful output would be a prioritized set of usability findings and a testable prototype. A visual refresh alone may not change completion. Is this journey part of your current product priorities?

Day 9. Subject: [Journey] review

I will close the loop here. If your team plans to review this flow, I can explain how we separate usability issues from backend or policy constraints before scoping design work.

Sequence 7 Mobile applications

Day 1. Subject: Mobile workflow for [users]

Hi [Name], [verified context] suggests [user group] works away from a desk. Can they complete [task] when connectivity is poor, or is online access enough? We help scope mobile workflows around device and offline needs before choosing native, cross-platform, or web delivery.

Day 4. Subject: Re: Mobile workflow

Offline data entry, sync conflicts, and device permissions usually change scope more than the number of screens. If a mobile project is active, a short discussion could clarify which of those actually apply.

Day 9. Subject: [Users] app planning

I will leave this here. If the current browser workflow is sufficient, a separate app may not be necessary. If device or offline requirements are creating a gap, we can assess those first.

Sequence 8 SaaS development

Day 1. Subject: First paid workflow for [product]

Hi [Name], your [verified product announcement] describes [target user and problem]. Which workflow needs to be complete for the first paying customer? We help founders scope a narrow release, including the billing, access, and support work that is easy to miss. Is the first-release scope settled?

Day 4. Subject: Re: First paid workflow

A useful scope test is whether every feature supports the first customer's core job or a necessary operating control. If you are still prioritizing, we can discuss what belongs in release one and what can wait.

Day 9. Subject: [Product] release planning

I will pause here. If you need outside delivery help later, a clear user journey and success measure will make estimates much more useful. We can start there when the timing is right.

11.3 Other channel scripts

LinkedIn connection request: “Hi [Name], your post on [specific topic] raised a useful point about [detail]. I work with teams on [relevant area] and would like to follow your work.” Do not claim to have read a post you have not read.

LinkedIn after acceptance: “Thanks for connecting. Your point about [detail] made me wonder how you handle [relevant workflow]. Is that something your team is working on now?” Acceptance is not consent to an aggressive pitch sequence.

Cold call opening: “Hi [Name], this is [Name] from [Agency]. This is a business development call. May I take 20 seconds to explain why I called?” If yes: “I saw [verified trigger]. We work on [relevant problem]. Is [hypothesis] relevant to your team, or have I misunderstood?” If no, stop respectfully.

If the caller reaches the wrong person: “Thanks for clarifying. Which function owns that process?” Do not pressure someone for private contact details. Verify any suggested role before contacting.

Referral request: “You mentioned [person/team] is reviewing [problem]. If you think our experience is relevant, would you be comfortable introducing us? I can send a short factual note for you to use.” Obtain the introducer's permission before using their name.

Post-event follow-up: “We spoke at [event] about [actual topic]. You mentioned [problem]. Here is the [resource] I said I would send. Would [agreed next step] still be useful?”

11.4 Evaluate messaging without fooling yourself

Test one material variable at a time, such as persona or problem hypothesis. Keep source quality and channel conditions reasonably consistent. Small samples produce unstable percentages. Record positive replies, held meetings, accepted opportunities, and reasons for rejection. Do not optimize for provocative replies that never become suitable work.

Assignment. Write one sequence for a real, approved offer. Annotate every claim with its source. Roleplay three responses: interested, wrong person, and not now. Pass when you stop appropriately and move an interested buyer toward discovery without promising a solution.

12 Discovery calls

12.1 The purpose of discovery

Discovery establishes whether a problem is real, worth solving, and suitable for the agency. The buyer should leave with a clearer understanding of the decision. The seller should leave with evidence, open questions, and an agreed next step. A call can succeed by deciding not to proceed.

Do not conduct discovery as a questionnaire recital. Follow the buyer's story while checking the necessary areas. Ask one question at a time, listen, summarize, and then go deeper. A useful question often begins with the buyer's last answer.

12.2 Before the call

Read the research sheet, previous messages, and meeting purpose. Confirm attendee roles and the buyer's time zone. Select a relevant case study only if its claims are approved. Prepare a problem hypothesis, three key unknowns, and a possible next step. Ask the technical mentor which signals require escalation.

Prepare a shared note with sections for confirmed facts, assumptions, decisions, risks, and actions. If recording is proposed, follow applicable law and company policy, explain the purpose, and obtain the required permission. Do not add recording or transcription bots silently.

Send a simple agenda: “Understand the current process, the impact of the problem, and the constraints; decide whether a technical scoping session would be useful.” If the buyer only wants a price, explain which facts are needed to provide a meaningful range.

12.3 The thirty minute framework

Time	Objective	Example wording and required evidence
0 to 3 minutes	Agree purpose and time	“What would make this conversation useful for you?” Confirm desired outcome.
3 to 8	Understand the business and trigger	“What changed that made this worth discussing now?” Identify the process and owner.
8 to 15	Explore the problem and impact	“Walk me through the last time this happened.” Capture frequency, consequences, and baseline.
15 to 20	Understand current systems and constraints	“Which systems and teams are involved?” Identify data, integration, security, and delivery dependencies.
20 to 25	Establish commercial and decision context	“How will you decide whether this is worth funding?” Explore budget route, stakeholders, timing, and alternatives.
25 to 28	Summarize and test understanding	“I heard these priorities and these unknowns. What have I missed?” Correct the record.

Time	Objective	Example wording and required evidence
28 to 30	Agree a useful next step	Name deliverable, owner, attendees, date, and decision that the next step enables.

If a serious issue emerges, adapt the agenda. Do not rush past a security blocker to finish every question. Ask to schedule the remaining discovery if needed.

12.4 Question bank with follow-up logic

Business and problem

“What does this part of the business do?” prevents assuming the workflow. “Who experiences the problem?” identifies the user. “Show me a recent example” turns vague frustration into evidence. “What did the team do next?” reveals hidden work. “How often does it happen?” establishes volume. “What is the consequence?” connects the task to money, time, risk, or customer experience.

If the buyer says, “Our reporting is slow,” ask: “Which report? Who prepares it? Where does the input come from? How long does preparation take? What decision waits for it?” Do not jump directly to selling a dashboard.

Users and adoption

“Which roles use the system?” “How do their permissions differ?” “Where do they work?” “What devices and connectivity do they have?” “Who is least comfortable with technology?” “Who will train and support them?” A product for 20 office analysts differs from one for 500 field workers even when both are called a reporting app.

Ask what users do when the current process fails. Their workaround may be essential behavior to preserve. A spreadsheet may contain undocumented approval rules that no one mentioned in the brief.

Current system and technology

“What happens from the first trigger to completion?” “Which system is authoritative?” “What must connect?” “Who owns access?” “Are there documented APIs and a test environment?” “What data must move?” “What is working well and should stay?” Avoid treating existing systems as failures just because they are old.

If the buyer names a preferred technology, ask why: team skill, procurement standard, existing code, performance requirement, or personal preference? Record the reason for the architect rather than arguing from popularity.

Team and responsibility

“Who will make daily product decisions?” “Who can explain the business rules?” “Who reviews technical work?” “Who accepts the deliverables?” “What can your team provide, and what do you expect us to own?” Unclear ownership is a commercial risk, especially in staff augmentation.

Timing and urgency

“What is the target date?” “What business event drives it?” “What happens if it slips?” “Which work must be ready then?” “When do internal approvals and access need to begin?” A deadline tied to a contract or seasonal window is different from a preference. Do not manufacture urgency when the buyer has none.

Separate decision date, desired start date, first usable release, and full rollout. The buyer may need a demo in six weeks and production later. Clarifying that can turn an impossible request into a viable plan.

Budget and economics

“Has funding been approved, or are you building the case?” “Is there an investment range we should design within?” “Who approves it?” “How does that compare with the cost or risk of the current process?” “Are licenses, hosting, and ongoing support inside the same budget?”

If the buyer refuses a number: “That is fine. We can compare a narrow first phase with a broader option. To avoid recommending something unsuitable, would an investment in [internally approved range] be clearly out of reach?” Do not invent the range. If the agency has no basis yet, say so and discuss process rather than price.

Unknown budget is a gap to investigate, not always an immediate rejection. An approved budget without a valuable problem is also weak qualification.

Decision process and competition

“Who will use, evaluate, approve, and sign?” “What criteria will you use?” “Is procurement or security review required?” “What other options are you considering, including doing nothing or using your own team?” “What must happen between today and a signed decision?”

If the buyer says “I decide,” ask what happens after their approval. Finance, legal, and vendor onboarding may still be on the critical path. If a tender is already specified around another vendor, assess whether participating is worth the cost.

Risk and success

“What would make this project fail even if the software works?” “Which data or functions are sensitive?” “Which third party could block us?” “What was difficult in previous attempts?” “What result after 30 or 90 days would make this a good decision?” Ask who will collect the baseline and outcome data.

12.5 Listening that improves the deal

Use a loop: ask, pause, reflect, confirm, deepen. Example: “You said supervisors spend two hours checking reports. Is that per supervisor per week?” After confirmation: “What do they check, and which errors matter most?” This is better than accepting the first number and putting it into an ROI slide.

Avoid interrupting with a success story before the buyer finishes. Avoid multiple questions in one breath. Write the buyer's exact language where it matters, but distinguish quotation from interpretation. Invite correction: “My understanding is that delayed approval, rather than report creation, is the main issue. Is that accurate?”

Watch contradictions. A buyer may say budget is unlimited but refuse any internal sponsor conversation. A deadline may be called urgent without consequences. Explore these respectfully rather than treating confidence as evidence.

12.6 Hidden requirements checklist

Ask about administration, roles, permissions, audit history, notifications, localization, accessibility, exports, data migration, retention, support, monitoring, disaster recovery, licensing, third-party fees, training, and offboarding. These are often missing from screen-based briefs.

A “simple marketplace” may need seller onboarding, commissions, disputes, refunds, moderation, payout reconciliation, fraud controls, and tax handling. A “chatbot” may need permission-aware retrieval, evaluation, content ownership, escalation, retention, and operating support. Hidden requirements often determine the real cost.

12.7 Qualification frameworks

Framework	Meaning	Best use and limitation
BANT	Budget, Authority, Need, Timeline	Useful commercial completeness check; weak if used as an interrogation or if budget is still being formed
MEDDICC	Metrics, Economic buyer, Decision criteria, Decision process, Identify pain, Champion, Competition	Useful for complex opportunities; requires real evidence rather than fields filled with guesses
MEDDPICC	MEDDICC plus Paper process	Adds contract/procurement path for complex deals
SPICED	Situation, Pain, Impact, Critical event, Decision	Strong conversation structure for understanding context and urgency
CHAMP	Challenges, Authority, Money, Prioritization	Useful problem-first qualification for service work
SPIN	Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff	Questioning method for developing impact; not a substitute for a buying-process check

For a fresher in IT services, use SPICED or CHAMP to guide the conversation, then a short BANT-style commercial check. Add MEDDPICC elements as deal complexity grows. Do not require a junior seller to recite every acronym on a call.

A practical opportunity score

Score each dimension 0, 1, or 2: problem evidence, business impact, owner/champion, commercial feasibility, decision path, timing/critical event, technical feasibility, and agency fit. Zero means absent or contradicted; one means plausible but unverified; two means confirmed with evidence. A training threshold of 11/16 can justify further discovery, provided no mandatory blocker exists. It is an internal teaching rule, not a validated prediction model.

Mandatory blockers override the score: unauthorized use, impossible critical constraints, unavailable capability, prohibited commercial terms, or an unwillingness to provide essential information. A high score does not automatically justify a fixed quote.

12.8 Worked discovery excerpt

Buyer: We need an app for our field reports.

BDE: What happens today from finishing a job to sending the customer the report?

Buyer: Technicians send photos on messaging apps. Office staff rebuild a report and finance waits for approval.

BDE: Where does the delay usually occur?

Buyer: Missing details and supervisor sign-off.

BDE: How often does that happen, and what waits on the report?

Buyer: Roughly 30 reports a week need chasing. Invoicing can wait several days.

BDE: I will record those as estimates until we confirm them. Do technicians need to capture the report without coverage?

Buyer: Yes. That was a problem with the last app.

BDE: Then offline capture and later sync are important. Who approves the final record, and which finance system receives it?

Buyer: A supervisor approves. Finance uses our ERP, but I do not know its API access.

BDE: The next useful step is a workflow session with a supervisor and the ERP owner. We can validate approval rules and access, then recommend the smallest first phase. Who would need to approve funding for that assessment?

The BDE identified the business chain, qualified an estimate, caught offline behavior, and proposed a concrete next step. The BDE did not promise a framework, launch date, or price before feasibility review.

12.9 After the call

Within the agreed time, send a concise recap: current problem, desired result, confirmed constraints, open questions, and actions with owners/dates. Ask the buyer to correct inaccuracies. Update CRM stage only when its evidence gate is met. Brief the architect before booking technical discovery. Do not send the architect a calendar invitation with “client wants an app” as the entire context.

Post-call scoring: Problem depth 20, impact 15, user/system understanding 15, commercial qualification 15, listening 15, summary/next step 10, accuracy and boundaries 10. Pass at 80/100. Fabricated claims, ignored opt-outs, or unauthorized commitments are critical failures requiring retraining.

13 Technical discovery and handoff

13.1 Collect constraints without pretending to design

Functional requirements describe what the system does. Non-functional requirements describe how well it must work and under which conditions. “Users can submit reports” is functional. “Reports must remain available offline and synchronize safely when a connection returns” adds operating behavior that materially changes design.

Area	Ask and record	Why it changes effort
Users and roles	User groups, counts, access differences, administrators	Permissions and workflows multiply beyond screen count
Platforms	Browser, iOS, Android, device fleet, offline needs	Testing, distribution, and synchronization requirements
Data	Types, source, volume, quality, owner, retention	Migration, privacy, cleanup, and storage design
Integrations	System, vendor, API, sandbox, limits, access owner	Feasibility and third-party dependencies
Security	Sensitive data, identity, audit, encryption requirements	Controls, review, and operational obligations
Scalability	Typical and peak load, growth assumptions	Capacity design and testing
Performance	Response targets under defined conditions	Architecture and validation effort
Compliance	Jurisdictions, activities, contractual obligations, reviewer	Specialist review and evidence needs
Hosting	Existing provider, regions, network restrictions, owner	Deployment, data access, procurement
Third parties	Fees, availability, support, licensing, change risk	Recurring cost and schedule dependencies
Operations	Support hours, incident process, backup/recovery targets	Ongoing team and service scope

13.2 Handoff document with a worked example

Opportunity: HarborRoute delivery reporting, fictional. **Commercial owner:** BDE [name]. **Client sponsor:** Operations director. **Technical lead:** To be assigned. **Version/date:** [ ].

Business context: Dispatch and finance wait for complete delivery evidence. Client estimates 30 reports weekly need chasing. Baseline is unverified.

Desired outcome: Reduce repeated data entry and time from completed delivery to approved billing evidence. Measurement owner to be confirmed.

Users and workflows: Driver captures delivery details and photos; dispatcher handles exceptions; supervisor approves; finance exports approved records. Driver offline use is required. Role permissions remain to be defined.

Existing systems: Telematics vendor named by client; ERP product and API availability not yet verified. No live credentials collected. Client IT owner will provide documentation and sandbox access through approved channels.

Data and constraints: Delivery addresses, contact details, location and photo evidence. Retention, regional hosting, device ownership, and consent practices need review. Expected load unknown.

Scope hypothesis: One driver workflow, supervisor approval, status view, and approved export. Native apps, route optimization, and ERP write-back are not yet agreed. All are assumptions for scoping, not sold scope.

Commercial context: Buyer is forming a budget. Proposed next step is paid discovery, not a production quote. Decision involves operations, IT, and finance. Procurement path and signer unknown.

Risks and architect questions: Offline conflicts; integration access; inaccurate customer data; approval audit; deployment/support ownership. Compare mobile web versus cross-platform after device requirements are known.

Required output from technical team: Feasibility questions, likely solution options, discovery work estimate, dependencies, and exclusions. No full architecture requested yet.

Next session: [date/time/time zone], with supervisor and ERP owner. **Documents:** [sanitized workflow sample, approved notes, source links]. **Handoff acceptance:** Architect confirms context sufficient or returns named gaps by [date].

13.3 Escalation triggers

Bring in specialists early for regulated data, payments/funds movement, unusual performance, production migration, offline synchronization, safety-related behavior, unclear third-party access, AI actions, or security obligations. A specialist is also useful when the buyer's technical questions exceed your confidence.

Say: “I can clarify the business and operating requirements. Our architect should validate that design choice.” This is credible when followed by an organized handoff.

Assignment. Produce a handoff from a recorded or simulated discovery call. The architect must be able to identify the buyer's problem, constraints, unknowns, and requested next decision without repeating the entire first call.

14 Solution and value selling

14.1 Connect a capability to a result

Feature selling describes what you have: “We have React developers.” Solution selling connects components to a need: “We can build your customer portal.” Outcome selling explains the intended business effect: “We can reduce duplicate order entry by connecting the approved portal workflow to your operations system.” The outcome remains a hypothesis until validated.

A dedicated team may help reduce a development bottleneck, but adding people can initially slow delivery through onboarding. Explain the mechanism, dependencies, and measurement. Never turn a plausible outcome into a guarantee.

14.2 Build a value case

Use five steps: establish a baseline, identify a controllable change, estimate the effect, subtract full costs, and assign a measurement owner. Include alternatives such as process change, configuration, an existing product, internal delivery, or doing nothing.

Illustrative example: six coordinators each spend five hours weekly rebuilding reports. At $20 loaded hourly cost and 48 working weeks, the modeled annual effort is $28,800. If a workflow change releases 40% of that time, gross capacity value is $11,520. If annual operating cost is $3,000, modeled annual net value is $8,520 before implementation. An $18,000 implementation has a simple payback of about 25 months under those assumptions. That may be unattractive unless there are additional verified benefits.

Do not hide a weak case by adding vague “efficiency” benefits. Ask whether improved billing speed, reduced errors, or new capacity can be measured without double counting. Revenue gain is not the same as profit gain. Use contribution margin when modeling additional sales.

14.3 Present options

Option	Benefit	Trade-off
Improve the current process	Low disruption and cost	May not solve system limitations
Configure an existing product	Faster standard functionality	Licensing and workflow constraints
Build a narrow custom workflow	Fits a valuable specific need	Integration and maintenance ownership
Build a broad platform	Wider control and capability	Larger budget, longer learning cycle, more risk

Recommend one option with reasons. A consultant can earn trust by saying that custom development is not currently justified.

Assignment. Rewrite five service-first statements as problem, mechanism, and measurable-result statements. Reject any claim that cannot identify the baseline, assumptions, or measurement owner.

15 Estimation and pricing

15.1 Effort is not elapsed time

Effort is the work required. Duration is the calendar time until completion. Five people cannot always complete a five-month job in one month because tasks depend on one another, decisions wait, and coordination costs grow. A senior engineer may cost more per hour but reduce design risk or review time. Job title alone does not prove competence.

The BDE collects scope and commercial constraints. Technical leads estimate the work. Delivery checks capacity and sequence. Finance or sales leadership approves rates, margin, and terms. The BDE communicates the approved estimate with its assumptions.

15.2 A complete project calculation

Illustrative USD example for a defined internal portal. The cost rates below are loaded direct delivery costs, not salaries, public market rates, or an agency rate card.

Role	Hours	Direct cost per hour	Direct cost
Designer	100	$18	$1,800
Frontend developer	240	$22	$5,280
Backend developer	280	$24	$6,720
QA engineer	160	$15	$2,400
Project manager	80	$25	$2,000
Total labor	860		$18,200

Add direct project tools of $800. Base direct cost is $19,000. Add a 15% risk reserve of $2,850 based on identified uncertainty. Risk-adjusted pricing cost is $21,850. The reserve is a pricing allowance, not an accounting expense until incurred.

For a target gross margin of 35%, client price = cost divided by (1 minus margin). Here $21,850 / 0.65 = $33,615.38. Round only through the approved commercial process, for example to $33,650. At that price, expected gross profit after the full modeled reserve is $11,800, and modeled margin is about 35.07%.

Markup is profit divided by cost. Margin is profit divided by selling price. Multiplying cost by 1.35 gives a 35% markup, not a 35% margin. With a $21,850 cost, that price would be $29,497.50 and margin about 25.93%.

15.3 Why discounts can destroy profit

A 10% discount on $33,650 produces a $30,285 price. With the same $21,850 cost, gross profit falls to $8,435 and margin to about 27.85%. Revenue falls 10%, but gross profit falls about 28.5%. Show that effect before approving a discount.

A better negotiation may reduce scope, change sequencing, remove an expensive dependency, or adjust approved payment terms. Do not remove essential testing or security just to reach a number.

Gross profit is not net profit. Sales cost, management overhead, office expenses, financing, taxes, and other costs still need coverage. Cash collection also differs from revenue. A profitable invoice can still create cash strain if payment arrives late.

15.4 Other model calculations

T&M: 200 approved hours at $45 = $9,000 invoiced before agreed expenses/taxes. If direct cost is $5,600, gross profit is $3,400 and gross margin is 37.78%. A spending cap limits authorization; it does not imply all backlog items fit.

Dedicated capacity: $6,000 monthly revenue less $3,800 modeled direct cost yields $2,200 gross profit, or 36.67% gross margin. Define allocated hours, holidays, leave, replacement, notice, and overtime. Do not silently assume 160 productive billable hours every month.

Timeline: The 860-hour portal may require 8 to 10 weeks under a particular team plan, dependency sequence, and client-response assumption. That duration is illustrative and must be validated; total hours divided by headcount is not enough.

15.5 Estimate maturity and commercial controls

An early range supports budgeting. A discovery estimate prices learning. A proposal estimate prices defined work. Mark confidence and assumptions at each stage. Include design, architecture, QA, PM, DevOps, security review, integration, migration, documentation, training, and warranty effort as applicable.

Document a scope baseline, client dependencies, estimate expiry, currency, taxes, third-party fees, payment milestones, change rules, and risk reserve. Fixed-price estimates need particular care where requirements or external APIs are uncertain.

For India-based agencies selling internationally, ask finance about currency risk, payment fees, tax treatment, withholding, export documentation, and the contracting entity. These are deal-specific professional decisions; do not teach trainees a universal tax answer.

Pricing exercise. At $12,000 direct cost, calculate price for 40% margin. Answer: $20,000. At a 10% discount, price becomes $18,000, profit $6,000, margin 33.33%. Explain what assumptions could change the cost before issuing the quote.

16 Proposals and commercial commitments

16.1 A proposal records an agreed understanding

A strong proposal should make the buyer's decision easier. It should not introduce a surprise scope or hide unresolved questions in a polished deck. Review the proposed approach with the sponsor before finalizing it. Use legal-approved agreement templates for binding terms.

Section	What to include	Example for the field reporting case
Executive summary	Problem, recommended phase, intended value	Validate and digitize delivery evidence and approval
Understanding	Current workflow and confirmed pain	Office rebuilds reports; delay baseline still being measured
Objectives	Observable business and delivery goals	One approved digital report from field to finance
Proposed solution	Recommended approach and alternatives considered	Offline capture plus supervisor approval and export
Scope	Boundaries by role, workflow, and system	One business unit and agreed report template
Features	Specific behavior with acceptance references	Photo capture, required fields, approval history
Technology	Architect-validated choices and rationale	Final choice subject to device feasibility results
Architecture overview	Components, data paths, trust boundaries	App, API, database, identity, approved export
Timeline	Phases, dependencies, decision dates	Discovery, prototype, build, UAT, pilot rollout
Team	Roles, allocation, responsibilities	Product analyst, mobile/backend, QA, PM
Deliverables	Concrete artifacts and working outputs	Code, test evidence, runbook, training, deployment
Assumptions	Facts on which price and schedule depend	Client supplies sample reports and test access by date
Exclusions	Explicitly omitted work	Route optimization and unvalidated ERP write-back
Pricing	Currency, fees, taxes, options, validity	Approved phase price plus separately listed recurring costs
Engagement model	Who owns priorities and delivery risk	Fixed discovery followed by approved delivery model
Payment terms	Invoice triggers, due dates, dependencies	Milestones linked to defined deliverables
Change requests	How new work is assessed and approved	Written impact on scope, price, and schedule
Warranty and support	Defect scope, duration, channels, exclusions	Bounded defect warranty; enhancements priced separately

Section	What to include	Example for the field reporting case
Next steps	Decision, signer, start conditions	Approve SOW, fulfill purchase requirements, schedule kickoff

16.2 Worked scope and acceptance excerpt

Included: A driver can create a delivery record, attach up to the agreed photo limit, complete required fields, and submit it. A supervisor can approve or reject it with a reason. Finance can export approved records in the agreed format. Authorized administrators manage user roles.

Acceptance example: A rejected report is not included in the finance export. The rejection reason and actor are recorded. A driver can correct and resubmit the report. Duplicate submission must not create duplicate approved records. Offline behavior is accepted against the device and connectivity test plan agreed during discovery.

Excluded unless added: Route optimization, inventory management, automated payments, unsupported devices, historical data cleanup, and additional report types. Exclusions must match the actual discussion, not be hidden after the price.

Client dependencies: Name a product owner and approver, provide sample data through approved channels, arrange system access, and respond within the agreed review period. State how late inputs affect scheduling, subject to the signed agreement.

16.3 Negotiate trades rather than automatic discounts

If the buyer wants a lower price, ask which constraint is fixed: budget, scope, or date. Offer explicit alternatives. A smaller release can preserve quality. A different start date may improve staffing. A longer commitment may change economics only with management approval. Do not invent concessions or exchange discounts for testimonials that could mislead future customers.

If the buyer proposes outcome-based fees, confirm a measurable baseline, attribution, access to data, authority over the relevant workflow, and a fair allocation of external risk. A development agency cannot responsibly guarantee the client's sales when it does not control pricing, marketing, or operations.

16.4 Close and hand over

Use a mutual action plan with steps, buyer and seller owners, due dates, and evidence of completion: solution review, budget approval, security/legal review, procurement, signature, purchase order if needed, payment/start conditions, staffing confirmation, and kickoff. A verbal yes is not a signed deal. A signature may still leave start conditions unmet.

At handoff, review the signed scope, assumptions, exclusions, estimate, stakeholder map, acceptance authority, success measures, risks, and every promise made. The delivery lead must accept the handoff. Schedule an early customer check-in to compare delivery reality with expectations.

Proposal assignment. Produce a five-to-eight-page proposal for a bounded scenario. Pass only if a buyer can identify what is included, what is excluded, how it is accepted, what it costs, and what must happen next.

17 Objection handling

17.1 Diagnose the concern before answering

An objection may reflect a real constraint, missing information, low priority, or polite refusal. Use acknowledge, clarify, respond, confirm. Do not manipulate discomfort into agreement. The best response sometimes recommends a smaller scope, a different provider, or no purchase.

Your price is too high

Bad: “We can discount immediately.” **Better:** “Which part is above your expectation?” **Best:** “Is the issue the available budget, the expected return, or a comparison with another scope? We can review those separately and decide whether a smaller first phase fits.” **Psychology:** Price can mean financial risk or unclear value. **Do not say:** “Cheap vendors always fail.”

We have a cheaper vendor

Bad: “They must use poor developers.” **Better:** “Are the proposals covering the same work?” **Best:** “Let's compare acceptance, integrations, testing, support, and responsibilities. If the lower proposal meets your needs with acceptable risk, it may be the right choice.” **Psychology:** Buyer wants confidence, not an attack. **Do not say:** “We are better” without proof.

We already have developers

Bad: “Ours are more skilled.” **Better:** “Where does your team still have a capacity gap?” **Best:** “Would specialist work or a bounded backlog item help, or is internal delivery already sufficient? We should only discuss support where it reduces load.” **Psychology:** Protect team status and ownership. **Do not say:** “Your team is the bottleneck.”

We need to think

Bad: “What is there to think about?” **Better:** “Which questions remain open?” **Best:** “Is the uncertainty about value, technical fit, timing, or internal approval? We can resolve a specific gap, or pause if this is not a priority.” **Psychology:** Could be uncertainty or a polite no. **Do not say:** “This offer expires today” unless that is a real approved condition.

Send me an email

Bad: Deliver a long pitch before agreeing. **Better:** “What would be most useful to include?” **Best:** “I will send a short note on [relevant issue]. Should it focus on scope, proof, or the first step?” If no engagement is offered, send only an appropriate concise note and respect refusal. **Psychology:** Time protection. **Do not say:** “I just need five more minutes.”

We are not ready

Bad: “You are falling behind.” **Better:** “What would need to change?” **Best:** “Which event would make this worth revisiting? If there is no defined trigger, I will close the opportunity rather than keep chasing.” **Psychology:** Priorities compete. **Do not say:** “Everyone else is already doing this.”

We can hire internally

Bad: “Hiring is always slower and more expensive.” **Better:** “Is this a permanent capability need?” **Best:** “Internal hiring may be right for core long-term ownership. We can compare that with a temporary specialist gap or bounded delivery phase if it helps.” **Psychology:** Control and institutional knowledge. **Do not say:** “Outsourcing removes all hiring risk.”

AI can build this cheaper

Bad: “AI cannot build real software.” **Better:** “AI can reduce some work; the full cost still includes validation and operations.” **Best:** “Let's compare both approaches against the same requirements: integration, permissions, tests, deployment, maintenance, and ownership. If AI-assisted delivery reduces our effort, that should inform the scope and commercial discussion.” **Psychology:** Buyer fears paying for outdated effort. **Do not say:** “Our rates are fixed because that is the market.”

Your agency is too small

Bad: Pretend the team is larger. **Better:** “Which capacity or continuity risk concerns you?” **Best:** “We can show the actual team, escalation cover, delivery limits, and transition plan. If your procurement requires a scale we do not meet, we should discuss a smaller scope or a qualified partner transparently.” **Psychology:** Continuity and accountability. **Do not say:** “Size never matters.”

You do not have enough enterprise experience

Bad: Borrow a team member's past employer's clients as agency references. **Better:** “That is a fair capability question.” **Best:** “Here is our verified experience and the gap. A bounded work package may fit; if the requirement is a proven enterprise prime contractor, we may not be the right lead vendor.” **Psychology:** Career and supplier risk. **Do not say:** “Enterprise software is the same as any app.”

Why should we trust you

Bad: “We guarantee satisfaction.” **Better:** “We can share relevant evidence and our delivery process.” **Best:** “Review a permission-cleared case, meet the responsible lead, inspect a sample deliverable, and start with a bounded phase and clear acceptance. Judge us on evidence.” **Psychology:** Buyer needs reduced uncertainty. **Do not say:** “Trust me.”

Can you work for X

Bad: Agree before checking cost. **Better:** “We need to see what scope fits.” **Best:** “At that budget, we can assess a smaller outcome or a diagnostic. I will validate the option with delivery and finance before committing.” **Psychology:** Budget constraint or negotiation anchor. **Do not say:** “Yes, everything is included.”

Can you start tomorrow

Bad: “Absolutely” without capacity confirmation. **Better:** “I will confirm staffing and access requirements.” **Best:** “We may be able to begin discovery, but production work depends on the agreement, team allocation, and required access. I will separate what can start from what cannot.” **Psychology:** Urgency and responsiveness. **Do not say:** “We will find someone later.”

We only need one developer

Bad: Force a larger team package. **Better:** “Who will handle design, review, testing, and deployment?” **Best:** “One developer may fit if your team owns those functions. Let's document the responsibilities and check the person's skill fit.” **Psychology:** Avoiding unnecessary spend. **Do not say:** “One person can do everything” without validating the scope.

Roleplay exercise. The manager chooses three objections randomly. Trainee must ask a diagnostic question before proposing a response, preserve factual boundaries, and end with an appropriate next step or respectful stop.

18 Competitor analysis

18.1 The main competitor may be doing nothing

Buyers compare alternatives, including process changes, existing software, internal capacity, and postponement. Learn the actual decision criteria before positioning. A competitive matrix should contain evidence, not insults or invented weaknesses.

Alternative	When it may be right	How an agency can compete honestly	Risk to avoid
Freelancer	Narrow work with strong buyer management	Offer team continuity, review, and coordinated delivery where needed	Claiming freelancers are inherently unreliable
Offshore agency	Suitable skills and cost with workable collaboration	Show domain fit, communication, evidence, and realistic overlap	Competing only on the lowest rate
Local agency	Close collaboration, local access, or procurement needs	Explain remote operating practices and relevant expertise	Dismissing legitimate onsite or jurisdiction needs
Large IT company	Large programs, procurement credentials, global coverage	Pursue a bounded specialist scope or transparent partnership	Pretending to match scale the agency lacks
Internal team	Core knowledge and sustained product ownership	Support a temporary gap, integration, or specialist workload	Undermining the buyer's own team
AI coding tools	Prototypes and some internal development needs	Sell validated production outcomes, integration, security, and operations	Claiming manual coding effort is inherently valuable
Low-cost vendor	Standardized work with clear scope and acceptable risk	Compare full scope, exclusions, rework, support, and ownership	Assuming low price proves low quality
Status quo	Change cost exceeds expected benefit	Quantify the verified consequence of delay	Fabricating urgency or losses

18.2 A useful competitive sheet

Record buyer criteria, each option, evidence source, strengths, limitations, total operating cost, switching risk, and unanswered questions. Include the agency's weaknesses. Ask the buyer which criteria matter most, and do not quietly change the weights to make your proposal win.

Exercise. Compare an existing SaaS, a freelancer, and the agency for a simple appointment workflow. A correct answer may choose SaaS. The trainee passes by reasoning from the need, not by always choosing the agency.

19 AI and the future of IT sales

19.1 What the evidence supports

The 2026 McKinsey survey reports that 32% of respondents' organizations had decided against purchasing at least one software product or feature because they could build it internally with agentic coding tools. This is a reported behavior within a survey, not proof that custom agencies or SaaS are disappearing. It does mean buyers may increasingly compare external delivery with AI-assisted internal work. [1]

DORA describes AI as amplifying existing organizational strengths and weaknesses. A controlled 2025 METR study found slower completion in a specific setting involving experienced open-source developers using early-2025 tools. Its small sample, task setting, and tool vintage limit generalization. Together these sources argue against quoting a universal productivity multiplier. [2][6]

Deloitte's outsourcing research discusses changing combinations of external providers, internal capability, and technology. The commercial implication is to clarify responsibility and demonstrate expertise, not assume every cost-conscious company will outsource. Demand must be validated by segment, geography, and actual buying triggers. [23]

19.2 How work changes

Function	Plausible AI contribution	What still needs accountable expertise
Software development	Draft code, documentation, tests, migration suggestions	Requirements, architecture, integration, review, production ownership
QA	Generate cases, assist analysis, summarize failures	Risk selection, meaningful coverage, reliable environments, validation
Design	Explore layouts, draft content, accelerate prototypes	User research, accessibility, interaction quality, evidence of usability
DevOps	Explain logs, draft configuration, assist incident analysis	Permissions, change approval, reliability engineering, recovery
Customer support	Retrieve information and draft responses	Correctness, escalation, policy, sensitive cases, service ownership
Sales	Draft notes, summarize calls, suggest questions	Trust, judgment, qualification, negotiation, factual accuracy
Lead generation	Enrichment and evidence organization	Identity verification, relevance, consent/basis, appropriate contact
Project management	Summarize status and surface dependencies	Decisions, accountability, conflict resolution, resource trade-offs
Business analysis	Draft stories and process maps	Context validation, exceptions, stakeholder agreement, acceptance

19.3 What may become easier to commoditize

Generic brochure websites, standard CRUD interfaces, undifferentiated code production, basic content drafts, and shallow chatbot demos may face more price pressure. This is a directional judgment, not a guaranteed 2030 forecast. Quality, integrations, operating requirements, and market context can keep apparently simple work valuable.

Hourly engineering capacity remains useful where buyers need skills and management control. The weaker proposition is selling hours without explaining what those hours achieve. Improve the offer by attaching domain context, accountable work boundaries, validated deliverables, and a credible transition plan.

Practical offers to investigate include legacy integration, modernization assessment, data quality, AI evaluation, permission-aware knowledge access, quality engineering, reliability, cloud cost diagnosis, and adoption support. Sell these only when the agency can demonstrate capability and the buyer has a meaningful problem.

19.4 Roadmap from 2026 to 2030

Period	Capability to build	Evidence of progress
2026	Business discovery, AI literacy, source verification, unit economics	Run a bounded AI or automation assessment with explicit success criteria
2027	Domain specialization, integration literacy, security/governance collaboration	Lead a multi-stakeholder solution evaluation with specialist support
2028	Value measurement, account expansion, portfolio prioritization	Connect delivered changes to buyer-verified operating results
2029	Complex negotiation, partnership design, outcome-risk allocation	Structure a larger program with measurable milestones and fair responsibilities
2030	Strategic account planning and adaptable commercial models	Advise on build/buy/operate trade-offs using evidence and real delivery history

The dates are a planning horizon, not predictions about when a technology will mature. Review the roadmap every six months. Do not postpone foundational sales skills while chasing each model release.

Exercise. Take an existing “developer for hours” offer. Add a named business problem, scope boundary, proof, onboarding plan, and measurement. Keep the pricing model if it still serves the buyer.

20 The sales technology stack

20.1 Buy a stack after defining the workflow

For a small agency, begin with one CRM, company email/calendar, a research process, shared approved documents, and meeting software. Add a data provider when manual research is the bottleneck. Add sequencing only after message and channel controls work. Add enrichment automation when the manual process is already repeatable.

The table gives examples, not a directive to buy every product. Vendor pages confirm broad categories; features, limits, availability, data terms, and pricing need a fresh check before purchase. No plan prices are assumed here. [24-33]

Category and purpose	When to use and what not to use it for	Beginner alternative	Advanced option
CRM: account, contact, deal, and action records	Use from the first real prospect; not a dumping ground for unverified lists	Simple CRM with few fields, such as HubSpot or Pipedrive	Configured CRM with permissions, stage rules, and reporting
Lead database: find possible accounts and contacts	Use after ICP definition; not proof of identity, consent, or buying intent	Official websites and manual verified research	Apollo with controlled verification and enrichment
LinkedIn: account and role research	Use for professional context; not unauthorized scraping or automated messaging	Manual LinkedIn research	Sales Navigator with approved account workflows
Email automation: schedule approved contact and follow-ups	Use after a small campaign works; not to bypass limits or send unwanted volume	Individual reviewed emails and CRM tasks	Instantly or Smartlead with suppression and monitoring
AI research: draft summaries and questions	Use with permitted data and source checks; not to invent facts or expose confidential material	Manual source notes	Approved enterprise AI workspace integrated with reviewed sources
Proposal: consistent approved scope and terms	Use after discovery; not to replace legal or technical review	Word/PDF template and approved signing process	PandaDoc or CRM-connected proposal workflow
Meeting: scheduled customer conversations	Use with agenda and correct time zone; not as a substitute for written decisions	Existing company meeting application	Managed Teams deployment or equivalent approved platform
Call recording: coaching and accurate notes	Use only with required permission and retention controls; not silent surveillance	Consented manual notes	Approved meeting recording/transcription with access policies

Category and purpose	When to use and what not to use it for	Beginner alternative	Advanced option
Analytics: understand conversion and quality	Use consistent cohorts and denominators; not to celebrate opens or raw activity	CRM reports and a small scorecard	CRM/BI reporting with validated definitions
Automation: reduce internal repetitive work	Use after process design; not for unreviewed commitments	Native CRM reminders and required fields	Clay or approved workflow tooling with audit and exception handling
Project management: track delivery commitments	Use after sales handoff; not as a replacement for CRM buying history	Shared task board	Jira or the delivery team's existing system

20.2 Data flow and ownership

Research enters a reviewed account record. A contact record links to that account and records role verification and communication status. An opportunity links a specific problem and buying process to the account. Emails and meetings update actions. A signed deal triggers an accepted delivery handoff. The account record remains the commercial history.

Define one source of truth for contact suppression, one owner for CRM administration, and one owner for vendor/data review. Prevent duplicate sequences across team members. Restrict sensitive notes to people who need them. Export and deletion processes matter when changing vendors.

20.3 A thirty day procurement test

Choose a tool only for a named bottleneck. Measure time saved, data accuracy, adoption, total cost, and the downstream quality of opportunities. Include setup and cleanup effort. A product can perform its advertised function while still being a poor investment for your workflow.

Assignment. Design a five-tool maximum beginner stack using existing company licenses where possible. State the job each tool does, who owns it, what data enters it, and how success will be measured.

21 Daily and weekly operating system

21.1 An outcome based day

The example uses an India-based workday. Move call blocks to agreed buyer overlap and plan lawful, sustainable working hours. Do not assume one schedule suits the US, Europe, Australia, and the Middle East simultaneously.

Time	Work block	Required outcome
09:00 to 09:30	Review commitments and urgent responses	No forgotten buyer promise or unowned blocker
09:30 to 10:30	Account research	Three to five defensible account decisions with evidence
10:30 to 11:15	Prospecting and message review	A small set of relevant, permitted contacts
11:15 to 12:00	Outreach and replies	Clear first contacts and correctly routed responses
12:00 to 12:30	Learning or call review	One corrected habit or concept
13:30 to 14:30	Call preparation and discovery	Prepared agenda, useful conversation, or roleplay
14:30 to 15:30	Technical coordination and proposal work	Named gaps resolved or assigned
15:30 to 16:15	Follow-ups	Every active opportunity has a buyer-relevant next step
16:15 to 16:45	CRM update	Accurate stage, evidence, owner, date, and risks
16:45 to 17:00	Plan tomorrow	Three priority outcomes, not an unranked task list

Breaks and working hours follow company policy. Shift the schedule for calls instead of adding an unlimited second workday.

21.2 Starter targets and calibration

After training gates, an illustrative weekly starting range is 15 to 25 researched accounts, 25 to 40 individually reviewed first contacts, and completion of all agreed follow-ups. A manager may set a learning goal of two held discovery conversations per week when lead supply allows. These are capacity hypotheses, not market benchmarks or guaranteed outcomes.

Review results after several comparable weeks. If replies are poor, inspect fit, source quality, message, and delivery before increasing volume. If meetings are high but opportunities are weak, inspect qualification. If proposals stall, inspect value, buying process, solution confidence, and competition. More activity at the wrong stage will not fix the constraint.

21.3 Weekly rhythm

Monday: review priorities, capacity, and the accounts worth pursuing. Midweek: review one conversation and one research/message sample. Friday: inspect pipeline evidence, stage aging, forecast changes, and losses. Hold a short sales-delivery sync to confirm capacity and recurring scoping problems.

For each opportunity, answer: What changed in the buyer's situation? What evidence supports the stage? What is the next buyer action? Who owns it? What could stop the deal? If there is no meaningful progress, downgrade, defer, or close it rather than repeatedly moving the close date.

21.4 Monthly rhythm

Review cohorts by ICP, source, service, and seller. Compare accepted opportunities, wins/losses, sales cycle, margin, and collected cash with finance definitions. Ask delivery whether sold scope matched actual work. Update the capability register, proof assets, and loss reasons. Choose one process improvement for the next month.

Pipeline arithmetic exercise: Four open opportunities at $20,000 each create $80,000 unweighted pipeline. If a historical cohort converts 25% by value within the relevant period, the expected aggregate value is $20,000 under that model. It does not mean each deal has a reliable 25% chance. Use stage probabilities only when calibrated from actual outcomes, and keep scenario forecasts distinct from committed business.

21.5 CRM stage gates

Stage	Evidence required to enter
Target account	ICP fit and a research hypothesis
Contacted lead	Verified relevant contact and appropriate communication record
Discovery scheduled	Relevant attendee and agreed purpose
Qualified opportunity	Confirmed problem, owner, commercial potential, and next step
Solution validation	Technical team engaged and material constraints being tested
Proposal	Reviewed solution, scope basis, decision criteria, and commercial approval
Negotiation	Buyer is actively resolving terms or trade-offs, not merely holding a proposal
Closed won	Signed commitment under the company's booking rules
Closed lost or deferred	Reason, evidence, competitor/status quo, and reopening condition if any

22 The 90 day training program

22.1 Gates and trainer responsibilities

Days are calendar stages mapped to the employee's working schedule. A gate that is not passed triggers targeted practice and reassessment. It does not trigger automatic advancement because the calendar moved. Learning outbound techniques is allowed before certification; scaled live outreach is not.

The sales mentor owns commercial coaching and stage decisions. The technical mentor checks explanations and handoffs. Delivery reviews estimates and promises. Finance approves pricing knowledge. Managers must provide the company-specific evidence the trainee cannot invent.

22.2 Days 1 to 7

Learn and why: Company truth, role boundaries, two core offers, customer problems, and the sales-to-delivery chain. A trainee must know what the agency can credibly sell before finding buyers. **Resources:** Chapters 1 to 3, approved company materials, two project retrospectives, one win/loss discussion.

Daily practice: Day 1 map the organization and responsibilities. Day 2 interview delivery about capabilities. Day 3 explain two offers. Day 4 analyze one successful project. Day 5 review one failure. Day 6 classify sample leads. Day 7 or the nearest working day complete the foundation review.

Expected output: Capability register for two offers, two-minute introduction, case-study explanation, disqualification list. **Assessment:** Foundation gate from Chapter 2, minimum 80/100. No invented proof or promises. **Manager action:** Correct claim wording and approve which offers the trainee may discuss. **Live activity:** Observation and internal practice only.

22.3 Days 8 to 14

Learn and why: SDLC, web/mobile systems, APIs, data, hosting, QA, and security boundaries. This prevents screen-count estimates and casual technical claims. **Resources:** Chapters 4 to 6; introductory MDN, cloud architecture concepts, internal demos.

Practical exercises: Draw a portal's system flow. Convert a vague request into stories and acceptance criteria. Compare a website, web app, mobile app, and SaaS. Sit with QA to review a real defect. Run five technology request roleplays.

Expected output: System diagram, terminology sheet, three decision-tree exercises, technical questions list. **Assessment:** Explain eight of ten core concepts accurately and score at least 80/100 on the technical mentor's review. Critical requirements: distinguish authentication/authorization, effort/duration, and POC/production. **Live activity:** Continue shadowing; no scaled outreach.

22.4 Days 15 to 30

Learn and why: Two industries, ICP/personas, research evidence, channel rules, outreach, and early discovery. Focus creates relevant conversations. **Resources:** Chapters 7 to 12 and the agency's market-specific outreach playbook.

Week 3 exercise: Research ten accounts, classify fit, map buyer roles, and draft two sequences. Roleplay first calls. **Week 4 exercise:** Run a manager-reviewed pilot on a small selected account set

after campaign approval. Shadow at least two calls where possible; use realistic simulations if call volume is low.

Expected output: Ten research sheets, two ICPs, two personas, one approved campaign, three call reviews. **Assessment:** At least 90% factual accuracy in research, no invented claims, message score at least 80/100, correct opt-out handling, and a passed simulated discovery call. **Gate:** Full-scale prospecting unlocks only after foundation, technology, and campaign gates all pass. **Manager action:** Review the first live messages and initial replies individually.

22.5 Days 31 to 45

Learn and why: Discovery depth, qualification, hidden requirements, and technical handoff. Meetings must turn into well-understood opportunities rather than generic proposal requests. **Resources:** Chapters 12 to 14, recorded examples with permission, architect feedback.

Exercises: Lead the opening and problem portion of supervised calls. Run three full simulated discoveries. Produce two handoffs. Practice declining a poor-fit request. Complete one basic value calculation with sensitivity to assumptions.

Expected output: Three scored call records, two architect-reviewed handoffs, one qualified opportunity brief or equivalent simulation. **Assessment:** Minimum 80/100 on discovery; architect accepts the handoff without restarting the entire conversation. Unknown facts must remain labeled. **Manager action:** Attend live calls and retain approval over promises and proposal scope.

22.6 Days 46 to 60

Learn and why: Estimation, margin, proposals, objections, and competitive alternatives. A proposal should be deliverable and commercially sound. **Resources:** Chapters 15 to 18 and approved company contracts/rates.

Exercises: Build two cost-and-price examples. Review a real estimate with a technical lead. Prepare one proposal from a completed discovery scenario. Roleplay price, internal hiring, and AI objections. Create a mutual action plan.

Expected output: Pricing worksheet, reviewed proposal, objection recordings, decision-process map. **Assessment:** All pricing calculations correct; proposal at least 80/100 with explicit acceptance, assumptions, exclusions, and responsibilities. No unauthorized discount or date. **Manager action:** Keep final technical, financial, and legal approvals with their owners.

22.7 Days 61 to 75

Learn and why: Pipeline management, forecasting, negotiation, closing conditions, handoff, and account health. Progress must reflect buyer action rather than seller optimism. **Resources:** Chapters 20, 21, 24, and 26.

Exercises: Run a weekly pipeline review. Identify stale deals and correct stages. Participate in one negotiation or simulation. Prepare a complete delivery handoff. Analyze a loss and a win. Develop an account expansion hypothesis from delivered value.

Expected output: Clean pipeline sample, mutual action plan, accepted handoff, win/loss reviews. **Assessment:** Every active opportunity has evidence, owner, next action, and date; no unsupported forecast. Manager scores judgment and follow-through at least 80/100. **Live scope:** Independent standard follow-ups, supervised commitments.

22.8 Days 76 to 90

Learn and why: Integrated execution and specialization. The trainee must connect research, discovery, technology, economics, and delivery. **Resources:** Chapters 24 to 29 and one chosen industry/service pair.

Capstone: Research a realistic account, conduct a recorded simulation, qualify, prepare technical handoff, compare solution options, price an approved scope, present a proposal, handle objections, and perform delivery handoff. Include a no-go option.

Expected output: Complete opportunity file, final assessment, personal development plan. **Assessment:** Beginner and intermediate exams passed, capstone at least 80/100, no critical failures, and manager/technical mentor approval. A live closed deal is valuable but is not required if the sales cycle or lead supply makes it unrealistic. **Manager action:** Document permitted independence and the next three skill gaps.

22.9 Recovery plan for a failed gate

Identify the exact failure: knowledge, judgment, communication, or execution. Assign one corrective resource, one practice exercise, and a new observed work sample within five working days where practical. Repeat the relevant assessment with a different scenario. Do not compensate for weak fundamentals by assigning more message volume.

23 The six month development plan

Month	Expected capability	Evidence and management support
1	Explain two offers, research suitable accounts, understand core systems, write reviewed outreach	Foundation and technical gates; mentor reviews initial live work
2	Run structured discovery and coordinate technical validation under supervision	Accepted handoffs, accurate calculations, reviewed proposal
3	Manage standard opportunities with clear boundaries	Passed capstone, clean CRM, reliable next steps; complex deals still supervised
4	Specialize in one industry and service pair	Ten buyer conversations or equivalent deep reviews, domain workflow map, relevant proof assets
5	Improve commercial judgment and account development	Loss analysis, tested positioning, expansion brief based on actual delivery value
6	Own a repeatable small segment motion and mentor basic tasks	Cohort pipeline review, credible forecast, quality/margin evidence, documented playbook

Revenue expectations depend on the agency's average deal size, sales cycle, lead access, market, delivery capacity, and role definition. Set targets from that operating model, not from an internet list of BDE KPIs.

By month six, a strong BDE should independently identify good-fit accounts, run first discovery, coordinate specialists, maintain a credible opportunity, and communicate approved proposals. Enterprise commitments, liability decisions, regulated solution design, and exceptional pricing remain specialist or leadership responsibilities.

Monthly review questions: What can the BDE now do without rework? Which promise or assumption created risk? Which buyer question exposed a knowledge gap? What did delivery teach sales? What will the next month's practice improve?

24 Ten practical case studies

All scenarios are fictional training cases. Technology options are hypotheses pending specialist review. Commercial approaches illustrate deal structure, not recommended market prices or guaranteed delivery schedules.

24.1 Founder wants a SaaS product

Lead information: A founder wants a subscription tool for small maintenance companies, with customer portal, job scheduling, billing, AI assistant, and mobile apps. **Research:** Verify target users, any pilot customers, existing competitors, funding route, and founder availability. Do not treat a pitch deck as proof of demand.

Likely pain: The founder sees fragmented scheduling but may not have validated willingness to pay. **Discovery questions:** Which user will pay first? What complete workflow matters? What do pilot users do now? What evidence supports the business case? Which features are essential to learning?

Qualification: Proceed if the founder can fund a bounded phase, recruit users, and own product decisions. Defer if there is no access to users and only equity is offered outside policy. **Technology solution:** Prototype first; then narrow multi-tenant web application with identity, tenant permissions, and billing if required. Defer AI and native apps unless essential.

Team required: Product analyst, designer, full-stack engineer, QA, part-time architect/DevOps. **Commercial model:** Fixed-fee discovery then phased T&M or bounded MVP. **Proposal approach:** One core job, success measure, exclusions, recurring costs, and data ownership. **Objection:** “A competitor has twenty features.” Explain the cost of testing too many assumptions at once. **Closing strategy:** Agree the discovery output, user access, budget owner, and go/no-go review. A smaller paid learning step is a valid close.

24.2 Healthcare company wants a patient portal

Lead information: A clinic group wants patients to complete intake, view appointments, and exchange administrative messages. **Research:** Identify clinic locations, services, existing EHR, authorized project owner, and any published integration information.

Likely pain: Staff re-enter forms and answer repeated appointment questions. **Discovery:** Which data is clinical? Which patients and roles? What does the EHR permit? Who reviews privacy, security, and accessibility? What must happen if an urgent clinical message appears?

Qualification: Require sponsor, EHR access path, appropriate legal/security review, and a viable budget. **Technology solution:** Portal with appropriate identity, role-based access, audit, and approved EHR interfaces. Avoid clinical advice functionality in an administrative scope.

Team: Healthcare workflow analyst, architect, frontend/backend, QA, security, client clinical/operations reviewer. **Commercial model:** Paid discovery with integration feasibility, then phased build. **Proposal:** Define data flows, responsibilities, relevant agreements, supported messages, escalation, and acceptance. **Objection:** “Our cloud vendor is compliant, so why more work?” Explain that application and operating controls remain necessary. **Closing strategy:** Secure technical and administrative stakeholders for discovery before committing to a production price. No blanket HIPAA or regulatory certification claim.

24.3 Logistics company wants fleet tracking

Lead information: A delivery operator wants live vehicle positions and customer delivery updates. **Research:** Determine whether telematics already exists and which customer-service workflow is affected. Check public service regions and fleet information without inventing vehicle counts.

Likely pain: Dispatch spends time answering status questions and chasing delayed deliveries. **Discovery:** New devices or existing data? Required update interval? Offline behavior? Which alerts lead to action? Who owns device installation and driver privacy requirements?

Qualification: Proceed when device/data access and an operations owner exist. **Technology solution:** Integrate existing telematics if possible, add dispatch exception view and proof-of-delivery workflow; validate hardware only if needed.

Team: Integration/backend, frontend/mobile, IoT specialist if needed, QA, operations owner. **Commercial model:** One-depot pilot then rollout. **Proposal:** Separate software, device, connectivity, installation, and support costs. **Objection:** “We need real-time everywhere.” Define latency under network conditions and show fallback. **Closing strategy:** Agree a representative pilot fleet and measurable reduction in status-handling effort. Do not sell a map without an operating response process.

24.4 Retail company wants eCommerce

Lead information: A regional retailer wants to sell its catalog online. **Research:** Review current catalog, store operations, existing POS, and actual customer channels. **Likely pain:** The retailer cannot manage online orders and stock consistently.

Discovery: How many product variants? Which system owns inventory? Which payment, shipping, tax, refund, and discount rules apply? Who maintains content? What happens when stock sells simultaneously in store and online?

Qualification: Ensure an operations owner, catalog readiness, and funding for integration and ongoing operation. **Technology solution:** Standard commerce platform first, with inventory and fulfillment integrations where needed. Custom checkout only if a validated requirement demands it.

Team: Commerce specialist, designer, integration engineer, QA, client catalog/operations staff. **Commercial model:** Discovery and launch project, then support. **Proposal:** Separate licenses, integrations, content entry, testing, and launch responsibilities. **Objection:** “A template costs very little.” Agree, then distinguish theme setup from stock and order operations. **Closing strategy:** Present configure-versus-custom options and close the smallest viable channel launch. Avoid revenue guarantees.

24.5 Company wants an AI chatbot

Lead information: A B2B software company wants support questions answered from its knowledge base. **Research:** Review public documentation, support channels, and any authenticated content boundaries. **Likely pain:** Repeated questions consume support capacity, but content may be outdated.

Discovery: Internal or customer-facing? Which questions? How current are documents? Must answers cite sources? What must be escalated? Are customer-specific records involved? How will success be measured after review?

Qualification: Need content owner, data permissions, evaluation examples, and an exception owner. **Technology solution:** Search or RAG-based assistant with source references, authorization,

refusal/escalation, and logging. **Team:** AI/backend, content owner, QA/evaluation, security, support lead.

Commercial model: Paid readiness assessment and pilot. **Proposal:** Baseline handling time, representative tests, unacceptable errors, operating cost, and rollout gates. **Objection:** “We already pay for an AI subscription.” Explain integration and content controls, then check whether the subscription already meets the need. **Closing strategy:** Agree a measurable pilot and stop criteria. Do not promise all tickets will be automated.

24.6 Company wants an AI voice agent

Lead information: A service business wants automated appointment calls. **Research:** Determine inbound versus outbound, countries, languages, call types, and existing telephony/CRM. **Likely pain:** Missed inbound calls or repetitive scheduling.

Discovery: What actions may the agent take? How are callers informed? What consent and recording rules apply? How does human transfer work? Which booking system confirms availability? What happens after misunderstood dates or identities?

Qualification: Legal/telecom approval, controlled scripts, permitted data, escalation owner, and measurable economics are prerequisites. **Technology solution:** Speech interface connected to approved scheduling tools, with bounded permissions and human fallback. **Team:** Voice/AI engineer, backend integration, QA, operations, legal/security reviewers.

Commercial model: Controlled test, then limited live pilot after approval. **Proposal:** Define disclosure, allowed actions, languages, latency, transfer, failed-call handling, and total call costs. **Objection:** “We want unlimited outbound calls immediately.” Explain why volume must follow compliance and quality validation. **Closing strategy:** Start with a suitable permitted narrow workflow, often inbound scheduling, and review completed-task quality before expansion.

24.7 Company wants CRM

Lead information: A 35-person services firm uses spreadsheets and individual inboxes. **Research:** Understand sales roles, offer types, and any existing licenses. **Likely pain:** Leads are forgotten, forecasting is inconsistent, and handoff to delivery is weak.

Discovery: What stages actually occur? Which fields drive decisions? Who maintains records? How are duplicates handled? What reports are needed? Which emails, forms, and finance systems must connect?

Qualification: Sponsor must own adoption and process decisions. **Technology solution:** Configure an appropriate existing CRM; use limited custom integration where justified. **Team:** Functional consultant, CRM specialist, migration/integration support, trainer.

Commercial model: Fit-gap assessment, configuration/migration project, optional support. **Proposal:** Include data cleanup, roles, stage gates, training, and adoption review. **Objection:** “Our team will not update another tool.” Simplify required fields and embed useful routines. **Closing strategy:** Agree the operating process with managers and run a small team pilot. Selling licenses alone does not solve behavior.

24.8 Company wants legacy modernization

Lead information: A distributor's older order system is hard to change and depends on unsupported components. **Research:** Verify the reported support issue, business criticality, and integration landscape. **Likely pain:** Slow change, outages, and dependence on a few knowledgeable people.

Discovery: Which failures occur? What behavior is undocumented? What must remain available? How will data reconcile? Who can validate historical business rules? Which components can be replaced independently?

Qualification: Need access, business owner, technical sponsor, migration funding, and realistic tolerance for staged work. **Technology solution:** Assess retain/rehost/replatform/refactor/replace by component. Prefer controlled transition where feasible. **Team:** Architect, legacy specialist, target-stack engineers, data migration, QA, DevOps.

Commercial model: Paid assessment then phased delivery. **Proposal:** Characterization tests, parity criteria, migration rehearsals, rollback, and operating handoff. **Objection:** “Can you just rebuild it quickly?” Explain hidden behavior and transition risk. **Closing strategy:** Sell the assessment and first isolated replacement, not a blind big-bang commitment.

24.9 Company needs dedicated developers

Lead information: A SaaS engineering manager needs two backend engineers for an integration backlog. **Research:** Verify product, published roles, stack clues, and actual contracting requirements. **Likely pain:** Roadmap demand exceeds current capacity.

Discovery: Which backlog? Who reviews work? Required seniority? Overlap hours? Security onboarding? Expected duration? What does productive contribution look like in month one?

Qualification: Need a client manager, real work, fair onboarding expectations, approved rates, and available candidates. **Technology solution:** Match skills to existing architecture; do not propose a rewrite. **Team:** Named engineers, account owner, defined escalation/replacement support.

Commercial model: Monthly allocation with explicit hours, leave, notice, and responsibilities. **Proposal:** Skills validation, onboarding plan, ownership of QA/DevOps, and knowledge transfer. **Objection:** “We only pay when every feature is complete.” Clarify whether the buyer wants capacity or managed delivery; change the model if needed. **Closing strategy:** Technical evaluation and a bounded initial period with clear contribution goals. Never submit fabricated CVs.

24.10 Company needs QA automation

Lead information: A commerce product takes four days to run manual regression before each release. **Research:** Understand product journeys, release cadence, current QA team, and available test environments. **Likely pain:** Slow release confidence and repeated escaped defects.

Discovery: Which failures cause loss? How stable is the UI? Is test data reproducible? Who fixes flaky tests? What checks already exist below the UI? Is the objective faster releases, fewer incidents, or both?

Qualification: Need engineering cooperation, stable-enough environments, access, and maintenance ownership. **Technology solution:** Risk-based automation combining API and selected end-to-end checks; tool choice follows browser and team requirements. **Team:** QA lead, automation engineer, developer support, DevOps.

Commercial model: Test strategy audit and pilot suite, then expansion/maintenance. **Proposal:** Critical journeys, reliability criteria, CI integration, failure triage, and ownership. **Objection:** “Automate every test.” Explain maintenance and risk-based selection. **Closing strategy:** Prove a reliable subset reduces repeated effort without masking failures, then expand based on evidence.

25 Roleplay training

25.1 How to run a roleplay

Use three people where possible: buyer, BDE, observer. Give the buyer a private constraint to reveal only when asked. Run eight minutes, debrief for five, then repeat the weakest section. The observer records specific questions and promises rather than saying the seller “sounded confident.”

25.2 BDE and founder

Founder: I need a marketplace with mobile apps in six weeks.

BDE: What must happen at six weeks: a demonstration, a user pilot, or paid production use?

Founder: An investor demo, but I want the full product later.

BDE: Which transaction must the demo show, and have buyers and suppliers tested that workflow?

Founder: Not yet. I have a few people willing to speak with us.

BDE: Then the useful first phase is interviews and a prototype of that transaction. We should estimate production after validating the workflow and payment responsibilities.

Founder: Can you give me the full price today?

BDE: I can explain what drives it. A reliable production quote needs the transaction rules and operating scope. I can take a bounded discovery proposal to our team now.

Review: Correctly separated demo and production, checked users, and avoided an unsupported quote. Improvement: ask who funds discovery and when the founder can provide user access. **Private buyer constraint:** Budget is enough for discovery but not full build.

25.3 BDE and CTO

CTO: We want two React developers. Send CVs.

BDE: What work should they own, and who will review their changes?

CTO: A complex admin portal. Our lead will review, but is already overloaded.

BDE: Then onboarding and review load may limit the benefit. Would a more senior engineer or a bounded delivery work package be worth comparing?

CTO: I do not want an agency redesigning our architecture.

BDE: Understood. We can work within your standards. Our technical lead would validate skill fit and responsibilities, then present the options for your decision.

Review: Protected the CTO's ownership and diagnosed the real constraint. Improvement: ask about test coverage, overlap, and the start conditions. **Private constraint:** The CTO dislikes vendors who bypass the engineering lead.

25.4 BDE and procurement

Procurement: Another vendor is 20% cheaper. Match it.

BDE: Before changing price, can we confirm both scopes include the same integration, testing, and support responsibilities?

Procurement: Their proposal includes fewer details. The business wants the lower cost.

BDE: We can create a neutral comparison and also price a smaller first phase. Any discount needs our commercial approval because the current scope has real delivery cost.

Procurement: We also require 90-day payment terms.

BDE: I will take that to finance with the project cash-flow needs. We should resolve price, scope, and payment terms together.

Review: Correctly avoided unsupported discounting and recognized cash terms. Improvement: ask whether procurement's criteria and the sponsor's priorities are aligned. **Private constraint:** Procurement can approve a phased purchase.

25.5 BDE and skeptical client

Client: The last agency promised everything and disappeared after launch.

BDE: What support or ownership was missing when that happened?

Client: We did not have repository access or someone responsible for bugs.

BDE: Then repository ownership, documentation, support scope, and escalation need to be explicit. You should also meet the delivery lead before deciding.

Client: Everyone says that.

BDE: Fair point. We can show a sample handoff and approved reference, and define a small first phase with acceptance. If our evidence does not address the concern, you should not rely on the promise alone.

Review: Connected trust to inspectable controls. Improvement: ask what contract and access arrangements exist for the inherited system. **Private constraint:** Client needs independent recovery of current assets first.

25.6 BDE and price sensitive client

Client: I have $5,000 and need the whole platform.

BDE: Which single workflow must be usable for this investment to be worthwhile?

Client: Customer intake and booking. The rest could wait.

BDE: We should compare an existing product with a narrowly scoped custom option. I will ask our team what fits, including setup and ongoing cost.

Client: Can you remove testing to lower the price?

BDE: We can reduce scope. We should not remove the checks needed for the agreed workflow to operate responsibly.

Review: Correctly reduced scope rather than essential quality. Improvement: clarify whether the $5,000 includes licenses, hosting, tax, and future support. **Private constraint:** An existing scheduling tool may cover most needs.

25.7 BDE and technical buyer

Buyer: Can your AI system guarantee no hallucinations and automatically update our ERP?

BDE: We cannot guarantee zero incorrect output from a generative model. Which updates are allowed, and what would a wrong update cost?

Buyer: It could change order quantities and discounts.

BDE: Those are consequential actions. We should compare a draft-and-approve workflow with a more automated option, then validate authorization, rules, and evaluation with our architect and security lead.

Buyer: I thought an agent could handle all of it.

BDE: It may assist parts of the process. The proposal should specify where deterministic checks and human approval remain, and prove the benefit before extending permissions.

Review: Correctly distinguished assistance from authorized action and avoided an accuracy guarantee. Improvement: ask about source data and how orders are reconciled. **Private constraint:** Buyer has no clean test data yet.

25.8 Observer rubric

Score problem diagnosis 25, listening and follow-up 20, business/technical accuracy 20, commercial judgment 20, next step 15. Pass at 80/100 with no critical failure. A smooth delivery cannot compensate for a false claim. Repeat with a new buyer constraint to ensure the trainee learned the reasoning, not a script.

26 Ready to use BDE toolkit

Copy each template into the CRM or an approved document. Bracketed fields are intentional response fields. Use “unknown” when a fact is missing. Do not fill blanks with guesses. Every active item should have an owner and a review date.

26.1 Company research sheet

Account and URL: [ ]. **Researcher/date:** [ ]. **Business model and customers:** [ ]. **Region/entity:** [ ]. **Size and confidence:** [ ]. **Leadership/roles:** [ ]. **Products/services:** [ ]. **Hiring/funding/announcements:** [ ]. **Systems and evidence:** [ ]. **Competitors:** [ ].

Evidence log: Claim [ ]; source URL [ ]; source date [ ]; checked date [ ]; confirmed/inferred/unknown [ ]. Repeat for each material claim.

Fit: [ ]. **Trigger:** [ ]. **Pain hypothesis:** [ ]. **Relevant approved proof:** [ ]. **Disqualifier:** [ ]. **Pursue/defer/decline:** [reason]. **Next action, owner, date:** [ ].

26.2 ICP template

ICP name/version/owner: [ ]. **Service offer:** [ ]. **Industry and workflow:** [ ]. **Region and buying requirements:** [ ]. **Company size band and why it matters:** [ ]. **Existing systems:** [ ]. **Business problem:** [ ]. **Buying triggers:** [ ]. **Funding/budget route:** [ ].

Evidence from wins and losses: [ ]. **Required proof/capability:** [ ]. **Positive selection rules:** [ ]. **Exclusions:** [ ]. **Likely economic buyer:** [ ]. **First offer:** [ ]. **Success metric for this segment:** [ ]. **Review date:** [ ].

26.3 Buyer persona template

Role and segment: [ ]. **Responsibilities:** [ ]. **Business KPI:** [ ]. **Problem experienced:** [ ]. **Career or operating risk:** [ ]. **Trigger:** [ ]. **Language used by actual buyers:** [ ]. **Typical objection:** [ ]. **Proof needed:** [ ].

Buying role: user / champion / economic buyer / evaluator / signer / other [ ]. **Influence and evidence:** [ ]. **Other stakeholders:** [ ]. **Where they obtain information:** [ ]. **Appropriate opening question:** [ ]. **Unknowns to validate:** [ ].

26.4 Lead qualification sheet

Opportunity/account/owner/date: [ ]. **Problem evidence:** [0/1/2 and evidence]. **Impact:** [ ]. **Owner/champion:** [ ]. **Commercial feasibility:** [ ]. **Decision path:** [ ]. **Timing:** [ ]. **Technical feasibility:** [ ]. **Agency fit:** [ ].

Total: [ ] /16. **Mandatory blockers:** [ ]. **Budget approved or being formed:** [ ]. **Alternatives/status quo:** [ ]. **Decision:** qualify / continue discovery / defer / decline. **Why:** [ ]. **Missing evidence and owner:** [ ]. **Buyer-agreed next action/date:** [ ].

26.5 Discovery questionnaire

Call purpose: [ ]. **What changed:** [ ]. **Current workflow:** [ ]. **Recent example:** [ ]. **Affected users:** [ ]. **Frequency and baseline:** [ ]. **Business consequence:** [ ]. **Desired result:** [ ].

Current systems: [ ]. **Team responsibilities:** [ ]. **Constraints:** [ ]. **Target date and reason:** [ ]. **Budget route:** [ ]. **Decision participants and process:** [ ]. **Alternatives:** [ ]. **Main risks:** [ ]. **Success measure and owner:** [ ]. **Summary confirmed by buyer:** [ ]. **Next step:** [ ].

26.6 Technical discovery checklist

Record status as confirmed / unknown / not applicable, with evidence and owner for each item: functional workflows; roles and permissions; platform/device needs; offline behavior; integrations; data sources and quality; migration; sensitive data; identity; audit; retention; accessibility; localization; typical and peak load; performance targets; availability; RTO/RPO; hosting region; third-party fees; operating owner; support hours; acceptance; client dependencies.

Technical review owner: [ ]. **Critical unresolved question:** [ ]. **Required specialist:** [ ]. **Decision blocked until:** [ ]. **Review date:** [ ].

26.7 BDE to architect handoff

Opportunity ID and version: [ ]. **BDE and client sponsor:** [ ]. **Business context:** [ ]. **Problem and baseline:** [ ]. **Desired outcome:** [ ]. **Users/workflows:** [ ]. **Current systems:** [ ]. **Data:** [ ]. **Constraints:** [ ].

Confirmed requirements: [ ]. **Assumptions:** [ ]. **Unknowns:** [ ]. **Commercial context:** [ ]. **Decision process:** [ ]. **Risks:** [ ]. **What has been promised:** [exact wording]. **Requested technical output:** [ ]. **Artifacts/access owners:** [ ]. **Next meeting:** [ ]. **Architect acceptance or returned gaps:** [ ].

26.8 Proposal checklist

Proposal ID/version/owner: [ ]. **Problem confirmed:** [ ]. **Objectives measurable:** [ ]. **Solution reviewed:** [ ]. **Scope and features:** [ ]. **Architecture approved:** [ ]. **Team and availability:** [ ]. **Timeline dependencies:** [ ]. **Deliverables and acceptance:** [ ].

Assumptions/exclusions: [ ]. **Pricing and margin approval:** [ ]. **Recurring fees/taxes/currency:** [ ]. **Engagement/payment terms:** [ ]. **Change procedure:** [ ]. **Warranty/support:** [ ]. **IP/data/security/legal review:** [ ]. **Buyer decision meeting:** [ ]. **Approvers and date:** [ ].

26.9 Follow up tracker

Account and opportunity	Last meaningful exchange	Buyer need or commitment	Next action	Owner and due date	Reply or stop status
[ ]	[date and summary]	[ ]	[specific useful action]	[ ]	[active/replied/ deferred/opted out]

A follow-up should fulfill a commitment, resolve a question, or enable a decision. “Just checking in” is not a reason to contact indefinitely.

26.10 Opportunity tracker

Opportunity	Stage and evidence	Value and basis	Decision date evidence	Main risk	Next buyer action
[ ]	[ ]	[currency, period, approved/indicative]	[ ]	[ ]	[owner/date]

Additional fields: account owner [ ]; sponsor [ ]; economic buyer [ ]; technical reviewer [ ]; procurement/legal [ ]; source [ ]; service [ ]; expected direct cost [ ]; margin approval [ ]; competition [ ]; stage entry date [ ]; close/loss reason [ ].

26.11 Competitor analysis template

Decision and buyer criteria: [ ]. **Options:** agency / internal / product / competitor / status quo. For each record strengths [ ], limitations [ ], evidence/source [ ], scope differences [ ], total operating cost [ ], implementation risk [ ], support/exit [ ], and unknowns [ ].

Buyer-confirmed weights: [ ]. **Our real weakness:** [ ]. **How to reduce it:** [ ]. **Recommendation and reason:** [ ]. **Claims approved for external use:** [ ].

26.12 Account plan

Account owner/date: [ ]. **Business priorities:** [ ]. **Current contracted scope:** [ ]. **Stakeholder map:** [ ]. **Delivered value and evidence:** [ ]. **Open issues:** [ ]. **Renewal/contract dates:** [ ]. **Customer health:** [evidence].

Expansion hypothesis: [new problem, owner, impact]. **Capability fit:** [ ]. **Delivery capacity:** [ ]. **Next value review:** [ ]. **Commercial risks:** [ ]. **Actions/owners/dates:** [ ]. Resolve material delivery problems before using a review to force an upsell.

26.13 Meeting notes

Meeting/date/time zone: [ ]. **Attendees and roles:** [ ]. **Purpose:** [ ]. **Recording permission if relevant:** [ ]. **Confirmed facts:** [ ]. **Estimates or assumptions:** [ ]. **Decisions:** [ ]. **Open questions:** [ ]. **Risks:** [ ].

Action: [ ]; **owner:** [ ]; **due:** [ ]; **completion evidence:** [ ]. Repeat for each action. **Buyer corrections requested:** [ ]. **Next meeting and purpose:** [ ].

26.14 Call preparation sheet

Account/person and verification: [ ]. **Previous exchange:** [ ]. **Business hypothesis:** [ ]. **Verified trigger:** [ ]. **Three unknowns:** [ ]. **Approved proof:** [ ]. **Questions in priority order:** [ ].

Possible technical escalation: [ ]. **Commercial boundaries:** [ ]. **Desired next decision:** [ ]. **Agenda and timing:** [ ]. **Attendee roles:** [ ]. **Time-zone/access check:** [ ]. **If not a fit:** [respectful stop or referral plan].

26.15 Post call analysis

Call and reviewer: [ ]. **Problem understood:** [ ]. **Impact validated:** [ ]. **Listening example:** [ ]. **Question missed:** [ ]. **Assumption made:** [ ]. **Promise requiring follow-through:** [ ]. **Qualification gaps:** [ ]. **Technical gaps:** [ ].

Stage justified or corrected: [ ]. **Next step agreed:** [ ]. **Score using Chapter 12:** [ ]. **One behavior to improve:** [ ]. **Practice assignment and review date:** [ ].

26.16 Lost deal analysis

Opportunity/value/cohort: [ ]. **Buyer-confirmed reason:** [ ]. **Internal hypothesis, separately labeled:** [ ]. **Alternative chosen:** [ ]. **Where evidence weakened:** [ ]. **Scope/value/price/process/capability issue:** [ ].

Could we have identified it earlier: [ ]. **What we should change:** [ ]. **What we should not generalize from one loss:** [ ]. **Reopening condition if appropriate:** [ ]. **Owner/date for learning action:** [ ]. Do not record “price” as the default when nobody asked the buyer.

26.17 Win analysis

Opportunity and signed scope: [ ]. **Why the buyer selected us:** [buyer evidence]. **Trigger:** [ ]. **Persona and champion:** [ ]. **Proof that mattered:** [ ]. **Alternatives considered:** [ ]. **Commercial concessions:** [ ].

Expected margin and delivery risks: [ ]. **Promises to preserve:** [ ]. **Handoff accepted by:** [ ]. **Permission to use reference/case:** [ ]. **What appears repeatable:** [ ]. **What was unusual:** [ ]. **Outcome review date:** [ ]. A signed win is not yet proof of delivered customer value.

27 Certification assessment and answer keys

27.1 How certification works

Use three levels. Beginner tests concepts; intermediate tests application; advanced tests judgment. This is an internal training certificate, not an external professional accreditation. Each test totals 100 points. Pass each at 80, with no critical failure. Assessments should be taken before reading the answer section; the manager can issue a separate copy of the questions.

Critical failures include fabricating evidence, knowingly misrepresenting capability, ignoring refusal or opt-out, exposing confidential data through an unapproved tool, or making an unauthorized binding price, legal, or technical promise. Retrain and reassess after a critical failure, regardless of the numeric score.

27.2 Beginner assessment

Twenty short-answer questions, five points each. Award 5 for a correct explanation with the key distinction, 3 for a substantially correct but incomplete answer, 1 for relevant terminology without understanding, and 0 for incorrect or unsafe reasoning.

1. What distinguishes a lead from a qualified opportunity?
2. Explain frontend, backend, and database using an order example.
3. What is an API, and why does integration access affect an estimate?
4. How does a business requirement differ from a functional requirement?
5. Write one testable acceptance criterion for order approval.
6. Explain QA versus UAT.
7. Why does 400 hours of effort not necessarily mean ten calendar weeks?
8. What is the difference between fixed price and T&M?
9. Distinguish dedicated capacity from managed delivery responsibility.
10. Define gross margin and explain how it differs from markup.
11. What is an ICP? What is a buyer persona?
12. Name three facts to verify before an outreach message.
13. What should happen after a prospect asks not to be contacted?
14. What is RAG, and what does it fail to guarantee?
15. Why might a standard CRM be better than a custom build?
16. What is the difference between authentication and authorization?
17. Explain a cloud provider's responsibility versus the application's responsibility.
18. Name three facts a BDE should include in a technical handoff.
19. Why is a meeting count insufficient to measure sales performance?
20. What is the correct response when a buyer asks a technical question beyond your knowledge?

Beginner answer key

1. A lead is a possible contact/account; an opportunity has evidence of a suitable problem, owner, commercial potential, and next step.

2. Frontend captures the order, backend validates rules and permission, database stores the record.

3. An API permits controlled communication; missing access/docs, limits, or unsupported behavior create feasibility and schedule risk.

4. Business requirement states the business change; functional requirement states required system behavior.

5. Example: only a finance approver may approve an over-limit order, and the decision is recorded.

6. QA checks quality and risks; UAT is business-user acceptance against agreed needs.

7. Dependencies, team allocation, parallelism, reviews, and client delays affect duration.

8. Fixed price buys defined scope at an agreed price; T&M pays approved effort at rates, with scope and budget governance.

9. Capacity supplies people/time under agreed direction; managed delivery owns an agreed deliverable or service responsibility.

10. Margin = (revenue minus direct cost) / revenue; markup divides profit by cost.

11. ICP defines suitable organizations; persona defines relevant roles, priorities, and buying behavior.

12. Identity/role, account/trigger claim, and relevant capability/proof. Channel permission or basis also needs validation.

13. Stop the sequence, record suppression, and follow the approved process to prevent recontact.

14. It retrieves source material for generation; it does not guarantee accurate, authorized, or complete answers.

15. Standard workflows may already fit, reducing custom cost and operating burden; verify limits and total cost.

16. Authentication establishes identity; authorization determines allowed actions and data access.

17. Provider operates contracted cloud layers; customer/application responsibilities remain for configuration, access, data, code, and processes as applicable.

18. Problem/outcome, workflows/users, systems/data, constraints, commercial context, unknowns, and requested technical decision. Any three well explained earn full credit.

19. Meetings can be poor fit; inspect accepted opportunities, progress, wins, margin, and delivered value.

20. Acknowledge the limit, clarify the requirement, involve the right specialist, and commit to a realistic follow-up.

27.3 Intermediate assessment

Ten applied questions, ten points each. Award two points for each of five elements in the matching key. Equivalent sound reasoning is acceptable.

1. A prospect says “We need an app.” Write a first-discovery plan.

2. A 300-hour project is requested at a fixed price, but API access is unknown. What do you do?

3. Calculate selling price for $15,600 cost at a 35% gross margin. Then calculate margin after a 10% price discount.

4. Research finds a new funding announcement and two engineering vacancies. Write a fact, an inference, and appropriate outreach.

5. A CRM opportunity has had no buyer response in six weeks. The seller moves the close date again. Diagnose and correct it.

6. A company wants an AI assistant using confidential documents. List the main discovery and pilot controls.

7. A CTO asks for one developer but expects the agency to own design, QA, deployment, and support. Propose a commercial clarification.

8. A buyer compares your $40,000 proposal with a $25,000 competitor. Plan the discussion.

9. Draft a technical handoff for offline field reporting with an unknown ERP integration.

10. An operations sponsor likes the solution, but finance, IT security, and procurement have not participated. Plan the next steps.

Intermediate answer key

1. Identify users/core workflow; trigger and impact; current systems/constraints; budget and decision process; agreed next step and unknowns.

2. Record integration uncertainty; obtain documentation/access owner; propose feasibility/discovery; ask technical team to estimate after learning; avoid unconditional fixed-price promise.

3. Price = $15,600 / 0.65 = $24,000; discounted price = $21,600; profit = $6,000; margin = 27.78%; explain unchanged-cost assumption. Two points per item.

4. Verify primary funding/job sources; label hiring-related workload as inference; do not infer outsourcing intent; ask a relevant neutral question; include appropriate identity and outreach controls.

5. Seek reason and buyer action; check stage evidence; separate no-decision from active negotiation; defer/close/downgrade as justified; record reopening trigger rather than inventing a date.

6. Data rights/classification; document-level permissions and provider terms; representative evaluation with critical errors; human escalation and owner; total economics, monitoring, and go/no-go criteria.

7. Clarify desired responsibility; inventory missing roles; compare augmentation and managed scope; obtain staffing/cost validation; document acceptance and support boundaries.

8. Ask budget/value/scope issue; compare like-for-like deliverables; examine assumptions/support/quality; offer justified scope options; obtain approval for any concession without attacking the competitor.

9. Business problem/baseline; driver/supervisor/finance workflow; offline and data constraints; ERP unknowns/access owner; requested architect output and next session. Include explicit assumptions.

10. Map stakeholders; obtain their criteria; verify budget authority; plan security/procurement/legal sequence; agree a mutual action plan with owners and dates.

27.4 Advanced assessment

Five scenarios, twenty points each. Score four dimensions per scenario from 0 to 5: diagnosis, option quality, risk/commercial judgment, and next-step clarity. Use the expected elements below to calibrate the score.

Scenario A: A hospital asks for an AI triage assistant that recommends treatment, wants a low fixed price, and says the software vendor will be responsible for all compliance. The agency has only administrative portal experience.

Expected reasoning: Recognize clinical and regulatory scope; disclose capability gap; avoid a clinical/compliance guarantee; involve qualified clinical, legal, security, and technical experts; decline or restrict to a suitable administrative assessment if a safe, authorized scope exists. A generic chatbot proposal earns no credit for judgment.

Scenario B: An enterprise champion requests a free full architecture and detailed implementation plan before budget approval. The probable contract is large, but the agency has limited pre-sales capacity.

Expected reasoning: Determine decision process and competitive status; distinguish reasonable qualification from substantive consulting; propose a bounded paid discovery or limited free fit review; agree outputs and ownership; assess pursuit cost and stop conditions. Automatically providing unlimited work is not strategic judgment.

Scenario C: A modernization project appears profitable, but the buyer demands a fixed launch date, no downtime, unknown data migration, and uncapped liability.

Expected reasoning: Separate technical, schedule, and legal risks; require discovery and migration testing; clarify recovery and acceptance; escalate liability and commercial terms; offer phased alternatives or decline if constraints remain impossible. Do not allow headline revenue to override delivery viability.

Scenario D: A successful pilot shows an AI assistant saves drafting time, but reviewers correct many outputs and usage costs rise sharply on long documents.

Expected reasoning: Recalculate total handling cost; analyze task segments and error severity; compare smaller models/rules/retrieval or reduced scope with specialist input; define quality/cost gates; stop or revise if net value fails. Do not present drafting speed alone as ROI.

Scenario E: A customer is considering expansion, but the current project has unresolved acceptance disputes and support complaints. The seller wants to offer a discount for a larger contract.

Expected reasoning: Resolve facts and ownership of the current issues; involve delivery/account leadership; agree a remediation and acceptance plan; separate expansion discovery from pressure to buy; revisit expansion only when trust and value justify it. Discounting does not repair delivery ambiguity.

27.5 Final capstone and certification record

The capstone is separate from the 100-point exams. Score research/ICP 10, discovery 20, qualification 10, technical handoff 15, solution/value reasoning 10, pricing/proposal 15, objection/negotiation 10, and delivery handoff/CRM 10. Pass at 80/100 with no critical failure. Require evidence of at least competent performance in discovery, handoff, and pricing rather than allowing perfect presentation to hide gaps.

Certificate record: Trainee [ ]; dates [ ]; beginner [ ]/100; intermediate [ ]/100; advanced [ ]/100 if attempted; capstone [ ]/100; critical failures/remediation [ ]; sales mentor [ ]; technical mentor [ ]; permitted independent tasks [ ]; tasks requiring approval [ ]; next review [ ].

Passing beginner and intermediate plus the capstone supports supervised-to-standard independent BDE work. The advanced assessment is for progression and complex-deal readiness; passing it does not replace actual enterprise delivery or sales experience.

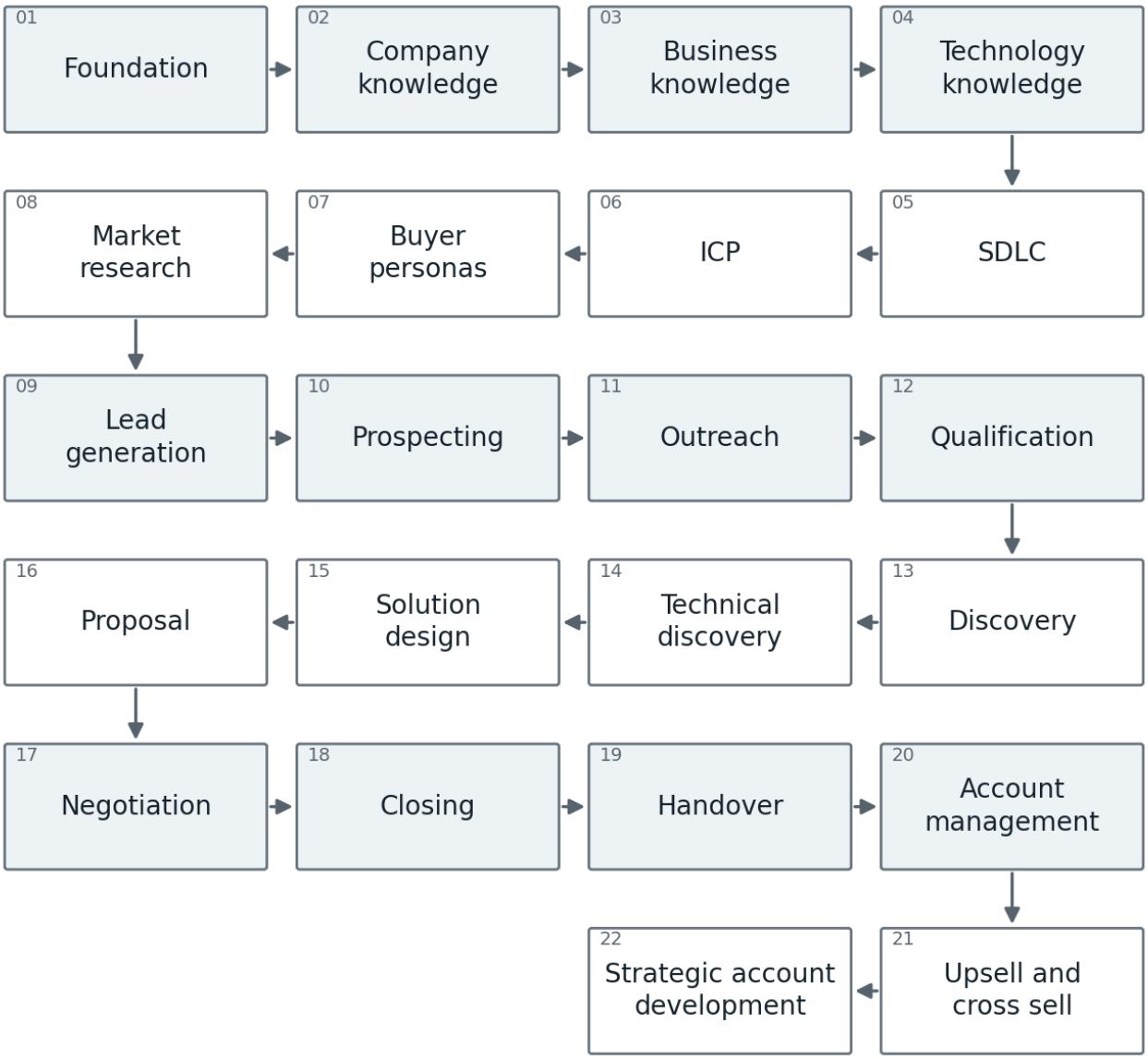
28 What a great IT BDE looks like

Level	Knowledge and technology understanding	Behavior and sales ability	Expected performance and independence
0 No knowledge	Unfamiliar with services, systems, and buying	Asks basic questions; may confuse tools with outcomes	Internal learning only; no unsupervised claims or outreach
1 Basic sales understanding	Understands role, ICP, and a small offer set	Accurate research and reviewed messages	Produces useful research; live work closely supervised
2 Technology aware BDE	Explains core systems, SDLC, integrations, and risk boundaries	Runs structured first discovery and flags unknowns	Qualified briefs and usable notes; technical and commercial review required
3 Independent BDE	Understands standard service models and deal economics	Manages a standard opportunity with evidence and follow-through	Owns normal prospecting, discovery, and coordination within approved limits
4 Consultative BDE	Strong domain knowledge and option/value reasoning	Challenges weak assumptions and aligns stakeholders	Leads complex solution evaluation with specialists; improves win quality and account value
5 Strategic enterprise BDE	Understands portfolio, procurement, partnerships, and risk allocation	Builds executive alignment and long-term commercial plans	Owns strategic account development and complex pursuits with governance

Levels are capability descriptions, not guaranteed revenue bands. A capable BDE can fail to close when the offer, proof, delivery capacity, or market is weak. Management must diagnose those foundations instead of blaming activity alone.

The strongest BDEs make the technical team more effective because their handoffs are clear. They make buyers more confident because claims are specific and limitations are explicit. They make the agency healthier because wins fit capacity and preserve margin. They stay involved long enough to learn whether the sold solution actually helped.

29 The master roadmap



Progress requires evidence. Revisit earlier steps when discovery changes the facts.

29.1 What to learn first

Start with the company's real capability, two core services, one buyer workflow, the business problem, and the basic system map. Learn to ask a follow-up question, write accurate notes, identify an unknown, and honor a commitment. These skills create useful conversations before any advanced sales tool does.

29.2 What to learn later

Add more industries, enterprise procurement, advanced AI patterns, specialized cloud services, outcome-based contracts, channel economics, and strategic accounts after mastering standard

opportunities. Depth in one credible segment is more valuable than a shallow vocabulary across every technology.

29.3 What not to waste time learning

Do not memorize every framework version, model ranking, cloud product, or programming syntax. Do not spend weeks perfecting automation before proving an offer. Do not collect contact data without a use case. Avoid memorizing objection scripts so rigidly that you stop listening.

29.4 Tools and technologies to understand

Master CRM records and stage gates, official-source research, approved email/calendar, meeting notes, and proposal templates. Understand frontend/backend/database, APIs, identity, cloud responsibilities, QA, deployment, data flows, AI limits, and the agency's actual delivery stack. Learn enough to ask useful questions and involve the right person.

29.5 Sales skills and practical experience

Practice research, problem-first outreach, discovery, qualification, business-impact calculations, technical handoff, proposal presentation, fair negotiation, and follow-through. Observe delivery kickoff, a QA review, a support incident review, a project retrospective, and a customer value review. Selling improves when you see what happens after signature.

29.6 Metrics and mistakes

Track researched fit, held meetings, accepted opportunities, stage conversion, cycle time, pipeline aging, bookings, margin, and retention/expansion with clear ownership. Watch promise accuracy and handoff quality. Avoid broad targeting, invented proof, premature pricing, unsupported timelines, tool-driven spam, hidden exclusions, and unowned next steps.

29.7 How to pursue top tier performance

“Top 10%” is an aspiration here, not a percentile this course can certify. Build the behaviors that make strong performance repeatable: specialize, verify evidence, diagnose the buyer's process, quantify value honestly, choose good-fit work, and learn from delivered outcomes. Review one call and one deal every week. Improve one measurable weakness each month.

First action for the trainee: Complete the capability register and explain one real customer problem in plain English. **First action for the manager:** Name the mentors, approve the two starting offers, and put the training gates on the calendar.

Research register and refresher schedule

Research notes

Research checked on 8 October 2026. Publication dates below identify the underlying study where known; living documentation may change. The market-priority and future-roadmap recommendations are editorial judgments informed by the sources, not direct forecasts from them. No single survey is treated as a universal market benchmark. Commercial examples, curricula, scripts, cases, and scoring rules are original training designs.

[1] McKinsey. The state of AI in 2026 On the road to ROI. Published 25 August 2026. Used for deployment, operating-economics, and build-versus-buy context. Survey reports are not causal proof or a guarantee for any buyer. Open source

[2] Google Cloud DORA. State of AI-assisted Software Development 2025. Used for the relationship between AI and the broader delivery system. Open source

[3] Stack Overflow. 2025 Developer Survey, technology and AI sections. Used for developer-usage context, not IT-services purchasing demand. Self-selected developer responses and changing question groupings limit comparisons. Open source and Open source

[4] CNCF. Annual Cloud Native Survey, published 20 January 2026, reporting 2025 survey findings. The Kubernetes percentage refers to surveyed container users. Open source

[5] Gartner. Sales survey on rep-free buying and irrelevant outreach, published 25 June 2025; 632 B2B buyers surveyed in August to September 2024. Used for buyer preference context. Open source

[6] Becker, Rush, Barnes, and Rein, METR. Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity. July 2025. Specific randomized study with 16 developers and 246 tasks; do not generalize to every team or later tool. Open source

[7] Google. Email sender guidelines FAQ. Living provider requirements for sending to personal Gmail accounts, including bulk-sender rules. Open source

[8] Anthropic. Building effective agents. Engineering guidance on workflows, agents, and choosing appropriate complexity. Open source

[9] Microsoft Learn. Design and develop a RAG solution on Azure. Architecture and evaluation guidance. Open source

[10] AWS. Well-Architected Framework. Cloud architecture quality considerations; not an automatic compliance certification. Open source

[11] MDN. The web standards model. Web foundations and how standards fit together. Open source

[12] PostgreSQL. About PostgreSQL. Database capabilities and positioning. Open source

[13] Playwright. Introduction and installation documentation. Browser testing capabilities; validate actual project requirements. Open source

[14] NIST. AI Risk Management Framework. Voluntary risk-management reference and related generative AI resources. Open source

[15] OWASP. Top 10 for Large Language Model Applications project. AI application security risk reference. Open source

[16] European Commission. AI Act policy and implementation guidance. Living source for staged obligations and current timelines. Open source and Open source

[17] US HHS. Business Associate Contracts. Relevant responsibilities and contract provisions under HIPAA where applicable. Open source

[18] US FTC. CAN-SPAM Act A Compliance Guide for Business. Commercial-email requirements, including B2B. Open source

[19] CRTC. Spam and malware, including Canada's anti-spam legislation resources. Open source

[20] UK ICO. Business-to-business marketing. Corporate/individual subscriber distinctions and related data-protection duties. Open source

[21] ACMA. Avoid sending spam. Australian commercial-message guidance. Open source

[22] LinkedIn. Prohibited software and extensions. Platform rules concerning unauthorized scraping and automated activity. Open source

[23] Deloitte. Global Outsourcing Survey 2024. Used for sourcing-model context; not presented as a 2026 spending forecast. Open source

[24] Apollo official product information. Account/contact data and sales workflow category. Open source

[25] Clay official product information. Enrichment and workflow category. Open source

[26] Instantly official product information. Email outreach operations category. Open source

[27] Smartlead official product information. Email campaign operations category. Open source

[28] HubSpot CRM official information. CRM category and current product details. Open source

[29] Pipedrive official information. Sales CRM and pipeline management. Open source

[30] LinkedIn Sales Navigator official information. Account and buyer research. Open source

[31] PandaDoc official information. Document/proposal workflow. Open source

[32] Microsoft Teams official information. Meetings and collaboration. Recording/transcription availability and policy depend on configuration and plan. Open source

[33] Atlassian Jira official information. Work and project tracking. Open source

Refresh ownership

Sales leadership reviews ICPs, buyer messages, channel performance, and training examples quarterly. Delivery reviews capability, staffing, technology support status, and estimates before each proposal. Security/legal owners review applicable outreach, data, AI, and contract requirements before a new market or material use case. Finance reviews cost rates, margin rules, and payment terms on its operating cycle.

Review model/provider terms, prices, tool features, supported integrations, and regulatory guidance at the point of use. Replace a source when a newer directly relevant study is available and its methodology is understood. Keep stable fundamentals intact unless actual delivery or sales evidence reveals a better practice.